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HISTORY & CULTURE

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1 CHAPTER ANCIENT HISTORY OF INDIA

1. HARAPPAN CIVILISATION

A. NEAR KUTCH HARAPPAN GRAVEYARD, A SKELETON & THE KEY TO A PUZZLE

*Archaeologists have found a human skeleton at a **Harappan site (Padta Bet) in Gujarat.***

MORE INFORMATION

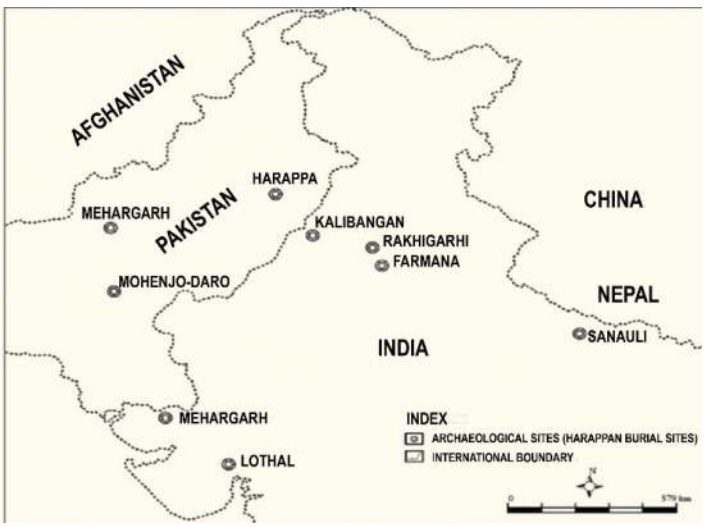
- In 2018, archaeologists had unearthed a mass burial site with **500 graves on the outskirts of Khatiya village in Gujarat's Kutch district.**
- In the recent excavations, the finding of the skeleton, along with pottery artefacts and animal bones, from, **nearby Padta Bet site, point to the presence of a 5,200-year-old Harappan settlement that was nearby the mass burial ground of Juna Khatiya**, an Early Harappan **necropolis (a cemetery, especially a large one belonging to an ancient city).**

B. RAKHIGARHI FINDINGS IN NCERT BOOKS

Among the latest set of revisions that the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has proposed in school textbooks are additions about findings from the DNA analysis of skeletal remains found at the archaeological site of Rakhigarhi in Haryana.

MORE INFORMATION FROM THE NEWS

- NCERT has stated that study of ancient DNA from archaeological sources in Rakhigarhi, Haryana suggests that the **genetic roots of the Harappans go back to 10,000 BCE.**
- The DNA of the Harappans has continued till today and a **majority of the south Asian population appears to be their descendants.**
- The research indicated that the people coming from the bordering areas and distant regions were absorbed in the Indian society.
- **At no stage, the genetic history of the Indians was either discontinued or broken.**
- This implies unbroken continuity for 5000 years in this region.



ABOUT RAKHIGARHI

- It is one of the **five biggest townships of Harappan Civilization, located in Hisar in Haryana.**
- **It is the largest site in terms of area among the Indus Valley Civilisation Sites.**
- Five interconnected mounds spread in a huge area to form the Rakhigarhi's unique site.
- This site was excavated by Amarendra Nath of the Archaeological Survey of India.
- It presents **existence of civilisation from the early phase, mature phase and late phase of Indus Valley Civilisation.**
- The site has both mudbrick as well as burnt-brick houses with a proper drainage system.

- The ceramic industry represented by red ware, which included dish-on-stand, vase, jar, bowl, beaker, perforated jar, goblet and 'handis' (pans).
- **Necropolis:** The excavations have yielded **a few extended burials, which certainly belong to a very late stage, may be the medieval times.** A rare grave having double burial of a male and female has been found here.
- **Ritual system:** Animal sacrificial pit lined with mud brick and triangular and circular fire altars on the mud floor have also been excavated pointing to the ritual system of Harappans.
- **A cylindrical seal with 5 Harappan characters on one side and a symbol of an alligator on the other side is an important find from this site.**
- A site has been found which is believed to be jewellery making unit.

2. HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION WILL BE CALLED 'SINDHU-SARASVATI' IN NEW TEXTBOOKS

Michel Danino, visiting professor at IIT Gandhinagar and chair of the NCERT committee for new social science textbooks, recently supervised the release of the Class 6 textbook 'Exploring Society: India and Beyond'. In an interview, ***he addressed concerns about the use of alternative names like 'Sindhu-Sarasvati' and 'Indus-Sarasvati' for the Harappan Civilization,*** *stating that these terms are based on established archaeological research rather than political agendas.*

MORE INFORMATION

- In contrast to previous editions, the new Class 6 social science textbook 'Exploring Society: India and Beyond features' **extensive references to the 'Sarasvati' river in its chapter on the origins of Indian civilization.** The earlier textbook, **Our Past I, briefly mentioned the Sarasvati only in the context of Rig Vedic hymns.**
- The updated textbook highlights the *Sarasvati river's significance in the chapter on the 'Beginnings of Indian Civilization,' identifying the Harappan Civilization as the 'Indus-Sarasvati' or 'Sindhu-Sarasvati' Civilization.*
- It describes how the **Sarasvati basin, which included major sites like Rakhigarhi and Ganweriwala, was integral to this ancient civilization.** The river, now known as the 'Ghaggar' in India and 'Hakra' in Pakistan, is depicted as seasonal in the new textbook.
- The textbook also **discusses the role of the Sarasvati-river in the decline of the Harappan Civilization. It cites two primary factors:**
  - climate change leading to reduced rainfall; and
  - the drying up of the Sarasvati-river in its central basin, resulting in the abandonment of cities such as Kalibangan and Banawali.
- **In contrast, the old textbook did not specifically attribute the river's decline to the downfall of Harappan cities.** It mentioned various theories including river drying, deforestation, and flooding, but did not conclusively link these factors to the collapse of all cities, suggesting instead a loss of control by the rulers.

HARAPPAN CIVILISATION

- The Harappan civilization, also known as the Indus Valley Civilization, is considered the beginning of Indian history. It can be divided into three phases:
  - ***Early Harappan Phase from 3200 to 2600 BCE.***
  - ***Mature Harappan Phase from 2600 to 1900 BCE.***
  - ***Late Harappan Phase from 1900 to 1700 BCE.***
- The early Harappan phase marked the transition towards the mature Harappan period.
- During this phase, farmers from the highlands gradually migrated between their mountain residences and the lowland river valleys.

- The earliest specimens of the Indus script date back to the third millennium BCE, and trade networks connected this civilization to other regional cultures and distant sources of raw materials.
- By this time, the villagers had successfully cultivated a diverse range of crops such as peas, sesame seeds, dates, and cotton. Additionally, they also domesticated animals like the water buffalo.
- By 2600 BCE, early Harappan villages had developed into major urban centres, signalling the beginning of the mature Harappan phase.

GEOGRAPHICAL SETTING OF THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

1. **Geographic extent:** The Harappan Civilization's geographic reach encompassed:

- **Northern Extent**: From Mandu in Jammu
- **Southern Extent**: To Daimabad in Maharashtra
- **Western Extent**: From Sutkagendor in Balochistan, Pakistan
- **Eastern Extent**: To Alamgirpur in Western Uttar Pradesh

2. **The civilization covered regions including:** Punjab, Sindh, Balochistan, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Western Uttar Pradesh. Notably, Harappan sites have also been discovered in parts of Afghanistan and Turkmenistan.

3. **The Pre-Harappan site of Mehrgarh in Pakistan** provides evidence of early cotton cultivation, indicating the region's agricultural development prior to the rise of the Harappan Civilization.

IMPORTANT SITES OF THE CIVILIZATION

1.Harappa:

- **Location**: Situated on the **banks of the Ravi River in Punjab, Pakistan.**
- **Findings**: Significant discoveries include Cemetery-37, Two sandstone statues depicting human anatomy, Two rows of six Granaries, workmen quarters, red sandstone male torso.

2.Mohenjo-Daro:

- **Location**: Located on the banks of the **Indus River in Punjab, Pakistan.**
- **Findings**: Notable structures such as the Great Bath and Assembly Hall were found. Additionally, a seal depicting Pashupati Mahadeva (Proto-Shiva) and a fragment of woven cotton were unearthed.

3.Chanhudaro:

- **Location**: Situated on the **banks of the Indus River in Sindh, Pakistan.**
- **Findings**: This site is unique for lacking a citadel. Discoveries include bronze figurines of a bullock cart and ekkas (two-wheeled carts), along with a small pot that suggests the presence of a kink well.

4.Lothal:

- **Location**: Located on the banks of the **Bhogva River near Gulf of Cambay, in Gujarat, India.**
- **Findings**: The city was divided into a citadel and a lower town, with a notable dockyard. Evidence of rice cultivation was also found.

5.Kalibangan:

- **Location**: Situated on the banks of **the Ghaggar River in Rajasthan, India.**
- **Findings**: Discoveries include evidence of a ploughed field, a wooden furrow, seven fire-altars, camel bones, and two types of burials—circular and rectangular graves.

6.Dholavira:

- **Location**: Situated near the **Luni River in the Kachchh district of Gujarat, India.**
- **Findings**: The site revealed a unique water management system, a Harappan inscription, and evidence of a stadium.

7.Surkotada:

- **Location**: Located between the **Sabarmati and Bhogavo rivers in Gujarat, India.**
- **Findings**: Important finds include evidence of horses, an oval grave, and pit burial practices.

8.Banawali:

- **Location**: Situated on the **banks of the Saraswati River in Haryana, India.**
- **Findings**: The site shows evidence of both pre-Harappan and Harappan cultures. Noteworthy discoveries include high-quality barley remains.

3. MYSTERY OF INDUS VALLEY SCRIPT

*The Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu has announced a **$1 million prize** for **deciphering the script of the Indus Valley Civilisation**.*

ABOUT INDUS VALLEY CIVILISATION

- **In 1924, Sir John Marshall** announced the discovery of **Bronze Age culture or** Harappan Civilization in the Indus valley between **c. 3300 BCE and 1300 BCE.**
- IVC flourished in **north-western regions of South Asia**, primarily in present-day Pakistan and northwest India.
- **Key archaeological sites include:**
  - **Harappa (Punjab, Pakistan):** One of the first sites to be excavated, giving its name to the civilisation.
  - **Mohenjo-daro (Sindh, Pakistan):** Known for its advanced urban planning and the Great Bath.
  - **Dholavira (Gujarat, India):** Notable for its unique water conservation system.
  - **Lothal (Gujarat, India):** An important port city with a dockyard.
  - **Rakhigarhi (Haryana, India):** One of the largest Harappan sites.

INDUS VALLEY SCRIPT

- Harappan script is **largely undeciphered**. Attempts have been made to compare it with the contemporary scripts of Mesopotamia and Egypt, but it is the indigenous product of the Indus region.
- It **does not indicate any connection with the scripts of western Asia.**

KEY FEATURES

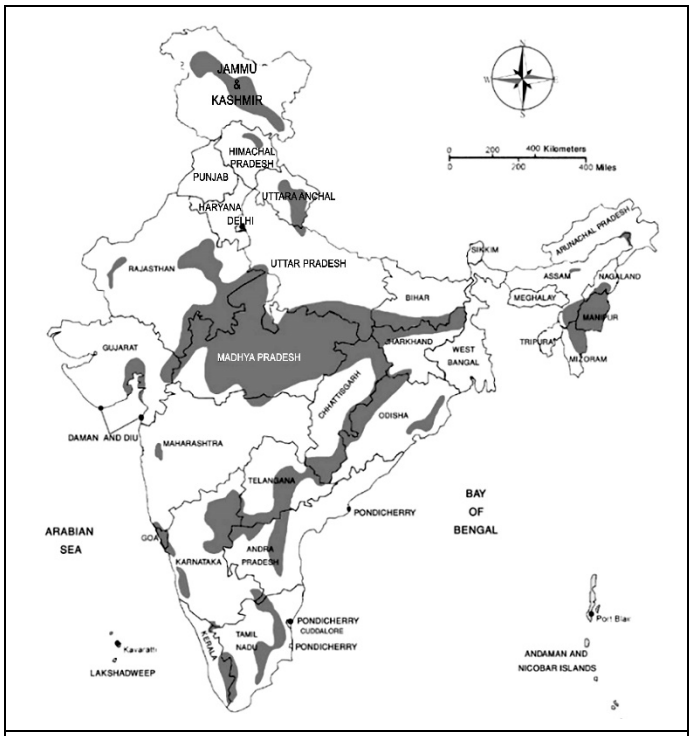
- **Short inscriptions-** with only **about five characters** on average – with the longest having only 26 characters.
  - There are **nearly 4000 specimens** of Harappan writing on stone seals and other objects.
  - Unlike the Egyptians and Mesopotamians, the Harappans **did not write long inscriptions**.
  - Most inscriptions were **recorded on seals** and **contain only a few words.** These seals may have been used by the proprietors to mark and identify their private property.
- **Boustrophedon script** i.e., it is written from **right to left** on one line and then from left to right in the next line.
- The script is **not alphabetical but largely pictographic.** There are about 250 to 400 pictographs in the form of a picture; each **letter stands for some sound, idea, or object**.

4. FIRST EVIDENCE OF ROCK ART IN MANGALURU CITY

*The first evidence of rock art in **Mangaluru (Karnataka) has been found near Boloor Panne Koteda Babbu Swamy shrine.** The rock art is in the form of a pair of human footprints, found on a natural stone boulder near the shrine. **These footprints might have been created in the first or second century A.D.***

ROCK ART TRADITION IN INDIA

- **Paintings and engravings on natural surfaces of caves, shelters and boulders are together termed as rock art.** It is a global phenomenon and one of the earliest human artistic manifestations.
- The spectrum of rock art available in India is vast and varied both in stylistic and thematic content. **Its chronology can be traced from the Upper Palaeolithic continuing through different periods up to Historic times** and probably even echoing in the artistic articulations of present day tribal and ethnic communities.
- **Rock art characterized by the presence of writings in Brahmi, Kharosthi, Shankha and even Nagari scripts** have been grouped as rock art of the Historic period in India.
- In India, rock art sites have been reported from rocky landscapes composed of sandstone or sedimentary rocks.



Main regions of rock art site in India

5. SEARCHING FOR INDRAPRASTHA

*Under **Ministry of Tourism's 'Adopt a Heritage scheme',** the Dalmia Group's Sabhyata Foundation has adopted the Purana Qila for maintenance and operations and promote sustainable tourism at the site. For Purana Qila, the foundation has a vision monument, i.e., **'Indraprastha and the Mahabharata'.***

- The **Purana Qila was built by the Mughal Emperor Humayun**.
- The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), is set to begin seventh round of excavations at the site to find evidence about the link of the fort to the ancient site of Indraprastha and the Mahabharata.

FINDINGS IN 2014

- In 1954, archaeologist B B Lal, first dug up the site.
- **In 2014, Grey pottery, rolled up inside a piece of soft white cotton cloth was found.**
- **Painted Grey Ware (PGW) pottery suggests links of the site to the ancient city Indraprastha.**
- **Painted Grey Ware:**
  - **PGW** is a fine, smooth, grey coloured pottery that's produced by firing techniques.
  - They contain mostly **geometric patterns in black or deep chocolate brown and usually occur in shapes such as open-mouthed bowls and dishes.**
  - Mostly found in the Indo-Gangetic divide, the **Sutlej Basin and the Upper Ganga plains, PGW is dated between approximately 1100 BCE and 500/400 BCE.**
  - **1100 BCE and 500/400 BCE:** This is the timeframe that matches some of the wide estimates of when the Mahabharata was composed.
  - Also, as ASI's findings, in each of the other Mahabharata-related sites excavated by Lal, such as Hastinapur, Tilpat and Kurukshetra, PGW formed the lowest cultural deposit. So its presence at Purana Qila suggests its Mahabharata link.
  - It was well established by B B Lal that PGW is associated with the Mahabharata period.

- **The Purana Qila excavation proves that there has been continuous habitation in Delhi from 1200 BCE till today.**

- However, other archaeologists, have different views and suggest that it is hard to connect PGW with Mahabharata there is lack of evidences proving whether the events in the Mahabharata actually **happened** and *the occurrence of PGW in itself does not necessarily mean that a site is connected with the Mahabharata story.*
- **As per Historian Upinder Singh** the presence of PGW in sites related to the story in the Mahabharata simply suggests that these sites were inhabited from about *1000 BCE onwards and that people who lived there shared a similar material culture.*

ABOUT INDRAPRASTHA

- Indraprastha is mentioned in ancient Indian literature as a city of the Kuru Kingdom.
- **During the Mauryan period, Indraprastha was known as Indapatta in Buddhist Pali literature, as the capital of the Kuru Mahajanapada.**
- Modern historians cite its location in the region of present-day New **Delhi**, particularly the Old Fort (Purana Qila).
- **About Kuru kingdom:**
  - The Kuru kingdom appeared in the **Middle Vedic period (1200 BCE),** encompassing parts of the **modern-day states of Haryana, Delhi, and some parts of western Uttar Pradesh.**
  - It **declined in importance during the late Vedic period (900-500 BCE).**
  - It corresponds with the archaeological Painted Grey Ware culture.

FROM TRIBAL TO TERRITORIAL STATES IN THE LATER VEDIC PERIOD (900–600 BCE)

- **During the Later Vedic period, the social and political structure** evolved significantly, shifting from a tribal polity based on lineage to a more structured **territorial** state.
- **The janas, initially migratory tribes, began to settle in specific regions,** leading to a shift in loyalty from the tribe (**jana**) to the territory (janapada).
- The term 'janapada' translates to 'the place where the tribe sets its foot **upon**,' signifying this transition.
- The janapadas competed for resources and political dominance, some expanded their territories and **incorporated various tribes, evolving into mahajanapadas.**

ABOUT ADOPT A HERITAGE SCHEME (APNI DHAROHAR, APNI PEHCHAAN)

- The scheme is an initiative of the **Ministry of Tourism, in collaboration with the Ministry of Culture and the Archaeological Survey of India.**
- **Launched:** In 2017 on World Tourism Day (September 27th).
- Under the scheme, the government invites entities, including public sector companies, private sector firms as well as individuals, to develop selected monuments and heritage and tourist sites across India.
- **Objective is the development of these tourist sites,** which calls for providing and maintaining basic amenities, **including** drinking water, ease of access for the differently abled and senior citizens etc.
- **Selection of sites:**
  - On the basis of tourist footfall and visibility and can be adopted by private and public sector companies and individuals, known as Monument Mitras (for an initial period of five years.
  - There is no financial bid involved.
  - The corporate sector is expected to use corporate social responsibility (CSR) funds for the upkeep of the site.
- **Adopt a Heritage 2.0:**
  - The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) launched a revamped version of the 'Adopt a Heritage' programme.
  - Earlier, the corporate partners' proposed visions and expression of interest would go through two levels of scrutiny via three committees.

- In the updated programme, **more freedom has been given to companies s**uch as the option to either adopt a monument in whole and develop its tourism infrastructure, or provide a particular amenity such as drinking water facility or cleaning services for one or several sites.

The permissible activities **have been now clearly stated as per the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (AMASR) Act.**

6. NALANDA UNIVERSITY

*Prime Minister inaugurated the **new campus of Nalanda University in Bihar** located close to the **ruins of the ancient university in Rajgir.** About 17 countries, besides India, had signed bilateral and multilateral agreements for setting up of the University.*

ABOUT NALANDA MAHAVIHARA



Introduction:

- Nalanda Mahavihara, **the 5th-12th Century AD** (in ancient and medieval Magadha) university is considered to be one of the greatest centres of learning in ancient India.
- The ruins of ancient Nalanda University in Bihar **was declared as the World Cultural Heritage by UNESCO in 2016.**
- The details of the university can be found in the writings of the **famous Chinese traveller Huang Tsang.** According to him, **there were 10,000 monks and 2000 teachers at Nalanda at that time.**

FOUNDATION OF THE MAHAVIHARA



- Nalanda was established during the **Gupta Empire period (3rd–6th century CE),** and was supported by numerous Indian and Javanese patrons, **both Buddhists and non-Buddhists.**
- The **numismatic evidence discovered at Nalanda suggests that Kumaragupta I was the founder patron of the Nalanda.**
- Kumaragupta's successors, **Budhagupta, Tathagatagupta, Baladitya, and Vajra,** later extended and expanded the institution by building additional monasteries and temples. **Nalanda, thus flourished through the 5th and 6th centuries under the Guptas.**
- It was also patronized by **King Harshavardhana of Kannauj (7th century CE) and the Pala rulers (8th-12th century CE).**
- After the fall of the Palas, **the monks of Nalanda were patronised by the Pithipatis of Bodh Gaya.**

CURRICULUM AND ASSOCIATED SCHOLARS

- **The curriculum at Nalanda was a skill full blend of secular and religious knowledge**, of the theoretical and the practical.
- **Curriculum of Nalanda included major Buddhist philosophies** like **Mahayana, Madhyamaka, Yogachara, Sarvastivada, Hinayana, Samkhya**
- The curriculum also included other subjects like the **Vedas, Sanskrit grammar, medicine, logic, mathematics, astronomy, arts, medicine and even metal casting technique.**
- The mahavihara had a renowned library that was a key source for the **Sanskrit texts that were transmitted to East Asia by pilgrims like Huang Tsang.**
- Many texts composed at Nalanda played an important role in the **development of Mahayana and Vajrayana Buddhism.**

- **Examples:** Works of Dharmakirti, the Boddhisattvacharyavatara of Shantideva and the Mahavairokana Tantra.

- One of the things that set Nalanda apart from other schools of the time was that it took **international students from countries like Korea, Japan, China, Tibet and other parts of Asia.**
- Part of Nalanda's mission was to bring Buddhism to the world.
- **Nalanda was** famed **for its learned professors, or Upajjhaya.**
  - Famous scholars associated with the Mahavihara: **Nagarjuna, Aryadeva, Vasubandhu, and Asanga.**

DECLINE OF THE MAHAVIHARA

In its lifetime, the different invaders destroyed Nalanda University three times.

- The first destruction was caused by **the Huns under the reign of Mihirakula.**
- The second destruction came during the **7th century by the Goudas.**
- The third attack on the **Nalanda University by the Turkish leader Bakhtiyar Khilji** during the year 1193 was the most destructive and lethal which the Nalanda University could not bear its damages and ruined into the pieces as well.
- **However,** it is found that Turkish invasion by Khilji is not solely responsible for the destruction of the Nalanda university, rather there were a lot of destructive reasons for its downfall.
  - **Loss of Royal Patronage:** The historical records show a steady decline in royal patronage, affecting the university's finances and causing economic instability to run the university.
  - There were more universities during Nalanda University's time. They were Vikramashila, Somapura and Jaggadala. It is said that the **regular invasion and plundering of manuscripts made the scholars to leave Nalanda University** at regular intervals which weakened its teaching ecosystem as well.
  - **Competition from Emerging Centres:** Vikramshila became the prime teaching competitor at that time. As time passed, Nalanda University kept losing its manuscripts at regular intervals and other universities were getting extra advantages from it.
  - **Plundered Manuscripts:** Plundering the manuscripts did not happen only at the hand of the invaders rather it was also plundered by the other invaders like different religious sects.
  - **Religious Conflicts:** The advent of **Hinduism at the time of the later stage of Nalanda University's lifespan** caused the development of religious conflicts with Buddhism. The continuous conflicts between the two religious sects developed and it ultimately began to resist to keep serenity in the Nalanda University.
  - **Political Instability:** At that time, there was **political instability in the Magadh region** which was affecting the university. The **religious conflicts also destabilised the political stability** in that region which ultimately destroyed the political serenity as well.

Erosion of Trade Routes: The main reason for the erosion of trade routes is the recurring invasions.

7. UDAYAGIRI-KHANDAGIRI CAVES

*The President of India, Droupadi Murmu visited **Udayagiri caves, situated in Bhubaneswar, Odisha.***

ABOUT UDAYAGIRI AND KHANDAGIRI CAVES

- The caves are situated on two adjacent hills, **Udayagiri and Khandagiri mentioned as Kumari Parvata in the Hathigumpha inscription.**
- They have a number of finely carved caves **built during the 1st century BCE.**



(Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves)

- Most of these caves were carved out as **residential blocks for Jain ascetics during the reign of King Kharavela.**
  - **Kharavela was a monarch of Kalinga in present-day Odisha,** who ruled during the second or first century BCE.
  - The **kingdom of Kalinga was invaded by Ashoka in 262-261 BCE.**
  - The **Hathigumpha inscription implies** that Kalinga regained its independence from the Maurya Empire sometime after Ashoka's death.
  - **Kharavela was born in an independent Kalinga.**
- The rock cutting activities continued **till the time of the Somavamsis of tenth-eleventh century A.D.**
- Most of the caves consist of a row of cells with portion opening into courtyard. The door way of cells has pilasters on either side with crowning animal figures and arches, decorated with flowers, creepers and animal motifs.
- **Udayagiri means has 18 caves while Khandagiri has 15 caves.**
- The caves of Udayagiri and Khandagiri **are called called lena or leṇa in the inscriptions.**
- The most important **was Ranigumpha in Udayagiri which is a double storeyed monastery.**
- **Other important caves** include ***Hathi Gumpha, Ananta Gumpha, Ganesha Gumpha, Jaya Vijaya Gumpha, Mancapuri Gumpha, Bagha/ Vyaghra Gumpha and Sarpa Gumpha.***
- The Caves are also listed as one of the **Adarsh Smarak Monument by Archaeological Survey of India.**
  - Under Adarsh Smarak initiative, the selected places are provided with additional facilities like wi-fi, cafeteria, interpretation centre, Braille signages and illumination among other things.
  - **The scheme was launched in 2014** for providing improved visitor amenities, especially for the physically challenged.

SOME IMPORTANT CAVES AT UDAYAGIRI

RANI GUMPHA 'CAVE OF THE QUEEN'

- Rani Gumpha is the **largest and most popular cave among the caves of Udayagiri and Khandagiri.**
- This cave is double storeyed.
- The upper portion of the central wing has relief images depicting the victory march of a king.
- **Many of the cells have carved Dwara Pala images.**

MANCAPURI AND SWARGAPURI GUMPHA

- Mancapuri and Swargapuri Gumpha is double storeyed.
- Manchapuri cave depicts two male and two female figures worshipping the **Kalinga Jina that Kharavela brought back from Magadha.**
  - **Kalinga Jina had been taken away from Kalinga by Mahapadmananda** and its **restoration was considered to be a great achievement of Kharavela.**
- **There are three inscriptions:** one inscription talks about the **chief queen of Kharavela,** and the *other* two *refer to Kudepasiri, the successor of Kharavela and Badukha, the son or brother of Kudepasiri.*

GANESHA GUMPHA

- The cave is named for the **carved figure of Ganesha on the back of its right cell. It would have been carved in the later period.**
- The carved figures of **Dwara Palas are found at the entrances.**

HATHIGUMPHA

- It is a **large natural cave** with an inscription carved **out in Brahmi Script by King Kharavela which is the main source of information about him.**

- The cave is known as **Hathi Gumpha due to its exquisite carvings of elephant.**

8. MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM

'Abhaya Mudra'**, the **gesture depicted with raised open palm that is commonly understood as conveying reassurance and a freedom from fear** was invoked by the Leader of Opposition in his speech in Lok Sabha. **The Abhaya Mudra is a commonly associated with Buddhism, Jainism and Hinduism.



INTRODUCTION

- It is one of the major religions of the world that originated from the Indian subcontinent and has now spread to large parts of South-east Asia.
- The origin of Buddhism is attached to the story of Siddhartha who came to be known as Buddha.
- Gautam Buddha was born at Lumbini (in present Nepal) in 563 BC as Siddhartha Gautam.
- At the age of 29, he left his house to find the truth of life and he wandered as an ascetic.
- **At Gaya (Bihar), he attained enlightenment (Nirvana) under a pipal tree and became the Buddha, the Enlightened One.**
- After attaining Nirvana, he gave his first sermon to his five companions at the Deer Park in Sarnath near Varanasi. **This event was called Dharma-chakra-pravartana (Turning the wheel of Law).**
- Buddha attained **Mahaparinirvana at Kushinagar (Malla Mahajanapada) in Uttar Pradesh in 483 BC.**

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM

- In the Buddhist context, it refers to *"hand and arm gestures made during the course of ritual practice or depicted in images of buddhas, bodhisattvas, tantric deities, and other Buddhist images".*
- Mudras are most commonly associated with visual depictions of the Buddha with different gestures conveying different moods and meanings, signifying the subtle manifestations of the Buddha's states of realisation.
- **The earliest depictions of the Buddha in physical form date to roughly around the turn of the first millennium.**
- **Depictions started appearing in the Gandhara art from the northwestern edge of the Indian subcontinent** (present day Pakistan and Afghanistan), which drew on **Hellenistic influences (Greek)** and **later in the art of the Gupta period, in the Gangetic plains.**
- In the earliest depictions of Buddha, **four mudras can be found:**
  - Abhaya mudra (gesture of fearlessness)
  - Bhumisparsha mudra (Earth-touching gesture)
  - Dharmachakra mudra (gesture of the wheel of dharma)
  - Dhyana mudra (gesture of meditation).
- **With the evolution of Mahayana and Vajrayana Buddhism,** and the proliferation of Buddhist artwork outside India, hundreds of mudras entered Buddhist iconography.

ABOUT ABHAYA MUDRA



- The Abhaya mudra is described as one *'typically formed with the palm of the right-hand facing* outward *at shoulder height and the fingers pointing up and the index, second, or third finger touches the thumb, with the remaining fingers extended upward.*
- In Buddhist tradition, the Abhaya mudra is associated with the Buddha immediately after he obtained

Enlightenment, **'portraying a sense of the security, serenity, and compassion that derive from enlightenment'**

- This gesture identifies the moment when **Shakyamuni (the Buddha) tamed the mad elephant, thus, illustrating the Buddha's ability to grant fearlessness to his followers.** The elephant calmed down immediately, gone down on her knees, and bowed her head to the Buddha.
- This is why the abhaya mudra is also seen as a '**gesture of protection' or 'gesture of granting refuge'.**

OTHER MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



DHARMACHAKRA MUDRA

- It is also called as the gesture of **'Teaching of the Wheel of Dharma'** that describes one of the most important moments in the Buddha's life as he **performed the Dharmachakra mudra in his first sermon in Sarnath after he attained enlightenment.**
- It is shown with the *help of both the hands which are held against the chest, the left-facing inward, covering the right facing outward.*



DHYAN MUDRA

- **It is also known as Samadhi or Yoga mudra.**
- It is shown with the *help of two hands which are placed on the lap and place the right hand on the left hand* with *stretched fingers (thumbs facing upwards and other fingers of both the hand resting on each other.)*



BHUMISPARSA MUDRA

- This gesture is also known as **'touching the Earth'** which **represents the moment of the Buddha's awakening as he claims the earth as the witness of his enlightenment**
- It is shown with the help of *the right hand, which is held above the right knee, reaching toward the ground with the palm inward while touching the lotus throne.*



VARADA MUDRA

- **This mudra represents the offering, welcome, charity, giving, compassion and sincerity.**
- It is shown with the *help of both the hands in which palm of the right hand facing forward and fingers extended and left-hand palm placed near omphalos with extended fingers.*



KARANA MUDRA

- This gesture signifies the **warding off evil** which is *performed by raising the index and the little finger and folding the other fingers.*
- The karana mudra expels *demons* and removes obstacles such as sickness or negative thoughts.



VAJRA MUDRA

- This gesture denotes the **fiery thunderbolt that symbolizes the five elements of nature, i.e. air, water, fire, earth, and metal.**
- It is shown with the *help of right fist, left-hand forefinger, which placed by enclosing the erect forefinger of the left hand in the right fist with the tip of the right forefinger touching (or curled around) the tip of the left forefinger.*



VITARKA MUDRA

- **It signifies the discussion and transmission of the teachings of the Buddha.**
- It is shown by joining the *tips of the thumb and the index fingers together while keeping the other fingers straight,* which is just like to Abhaya Mudra and varada *mudra but in this Mudra the thumbs touching the index fingers.*

9. THE GREAT STUPA OF SANCHI

*In December 2022, the Humboldt Forum Museum in Berlin, Germany, unveiled an intricately designed red sandstone gateway, a 1:1 replica of the original **East Gate of Sanchi's Great Stupa**. At nearly 10 metres tall, 6 metres wide, and weighing around 150 tonnes, this reproduction reflects the detailed craftsmanship of the ancient structure. Its significance was highlighted by a visit from India's External Affairs Minister, S. Jaishankar, emphasizing the ongoing cultural dialogue between India and Germany.*

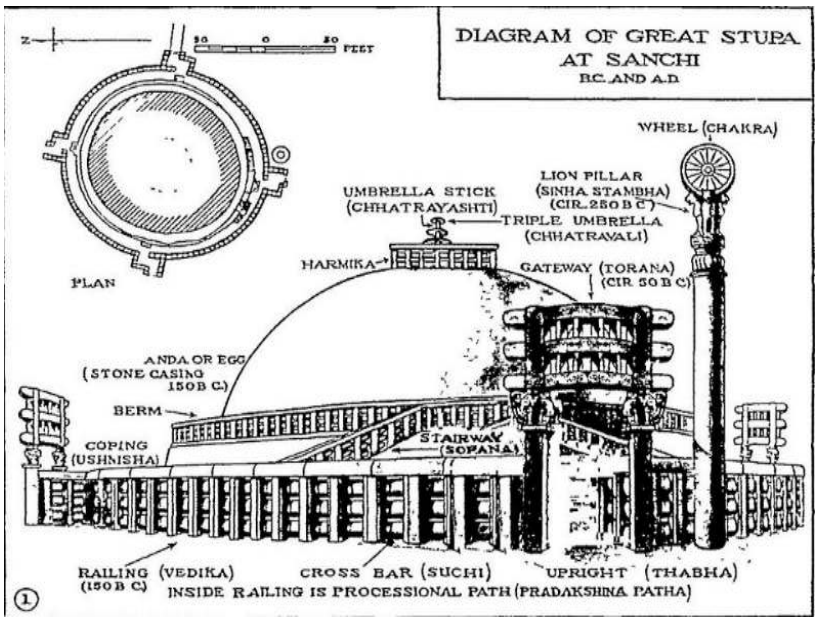
STUPA



- A stupa is a **commemorative monument** usually containing sacred relics of the Buddha or other venerable saints.
- **The archetypal/typical stupa is a hemispherical structure,** whose origins can be traced to pre-Buddhist burial mounds found in India.
- The Great Stupa of Sanchi exemplifies this form.

SANCHI STUPA

- **Location:** Raisen District of Madhya Pradesh.
- The Sanchi complex was in a state of profound disrepair when it was first encountered by **British officer Henry Taylor in 1818.**
- This discovery led to a renewed interest in the site, which was subsequently formally surveyed and excavated by **Alexander Cunningham, the founder of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), in 1851.**
- The restoration of the site to its current condition was overseen by **ASI Director-General John Marshall during the 1910s,** with crucial financial support from the begums of Bhopal.
- The most recent construction in Sanchi can be dated to as late as the **twelfth century CE**.
- The Great Stupa is **one of the oldest standing stone structures in India,** believed to have been built over the **Buddha's relics.**
- The development of the Sanchi complex was supported by patronage from **Vidisha's mercantile community.**
- The Great Stupa and Sanchi's other Buddhist monuments were collectively **designated a UNESCO World Heritage site in 1989.**
- The Sanchi Stupa is featured on the **reverse side of the ₹200 Indian currency** note to highlight its significance as a cornerstone of Indian cultural heritage.



COMMISSIONED BY EMPEROR ASHOKA

- The Sanchi Stupa was originally commissioned by the **Mauryan Emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE.**
- The initial design of the stupa featured a simple hemispherical **brick dome constructed over the** relics **of the Buddha.**
- This early form was crowned with a **Chatra, a symbolizing high rank,** intended to honour and protect the sacred relics of Buddha.
- **Ashoka's wife Devi** was a merchant's daughter from nearby Vidisha and a native of Sanchi, oversaw the construction.

Expansions:

- **In the 1st century BCE, significant enhancements** were made to the original stupa.
- **Four elaborately carved Toranas (ornamental gateways)** and **a balustrade** (railing or barrier supported by a series of vertical posts) encircling the structure were added.
- These additions marked the stupa's transition from its Mauryan origins to a more ornate and decorative phase.

STRUCTURAL DEVELOPMENTS

- Subsequent rulers, **particularly the Shungas and Satavahanas,** expanded and embellished the stupa.
- During the **Shunga period, the stupa was significantly enlarged with stone slabs**, increasing its size to nearly twice its original diameter.
- The dome was flattened near the top and **crowned with three superimposed parasols**, set within a square railing, **symbolizing the Dharma, or Wheel of the Law.**
- The high circular drum supporting the dome was designed **for circumambulation (Pradakshinapath) and accessible via a double staircase,** complemented by a stone balustrade enclosing a second pathway at ground level.
- The railings surrounding **Stupa 1, dating to around 150 BCE or 175–125 BCE**, are composed of plain stone slabs with dedicatory inscriptions.
- These railings, though made of stone, mimic a wooden prototype, evident from the slanted joints resembling those in wood rather than vertical cuts typical of stonework.
- The railings also feature **short donor inscriptions in Brahmi script,** with **additional inscriptions added during the Gupta Period.**

SATAVAHANA CONTRIBUTIONS

- The Satavahana Empire, **under the rule of Satakarni II, conquered eastern Malwa from the Shungas, gaining control over the Sanchi site.**
- The Satavahanas are credited with constructing the **ornate gateways around the original Mauryan and Shunga stupas.**
- The **1st century BCE saw the introduction of highly decorated gateways**, which were also coloured.
- **An inscription in Brahmi script, the Siri-Satakani inscription,** commemorates the donation of one of the top lintels of the Southern Gateway by the **artisans of King Satakarni II**, reflecting the ongoing patronage and cultural significance of the site.

GATEWAYS OF THE GREAT STUPA

- The Great Stupa at Sanchi is renowned not just for its hemispherical dome crowned with a chhatra (parasol) **but also for its intricately carved ornamental gateways or toranas.**
- These gateways, constructed in the first century BCE during the Satavahana dynasty, serve as remarkable illustrations of Buddhist art and iconography.
- The Stupa is surrounded by four toranas, **each oriented towards one of the cardinal directions.**
- These gateways are composed of **two square pillars topped with capitals,** which support a superstructure.
- The pillars and lintels are adorned with elaborate bas reliefs and sculptures depicting scenes from the Buddha's life, stories from the Jataka Tales, and other Buddhist motifs.

1.Southern gateway:

- The Southern Gateway, **the first of the four to be erected**, is situated directly in front of the steps leading to the stupa's terrace.
- It is considered the main entrance to the stupa.
- The decorations emphasize the **role of Ashoka in spreading Buddhism.**

2.Northern gateway:

- The Northern Gateway, the second to be constructed, is the best-preserved of the four.
- It retains most of its original ornamental figures and provides a clear view of the artistic style used in all the gateways.
- This gateway features panels that narrate various events from the Buddha's life.
- **A notable atypical panel depicts foreigners making a dedication at the Southern Gateway.**

3.Eastern gateway:

- **The Eastern Gateway, constructed third,** is particularly famous in Europe due to its plaster cast, **created by Lieutenant Henry Hardy Cole in the late 1860s.** This cast was widely distributed and displayed across Europe, including at the Victoria and Albert Museum.
- The upper lintel of the Eastern Gateway represents the seven **Manushi Buddhas**, with the historical Buddha being the latest.
- The middle lintel depicts the Great Departure, **where Prince Siddhartha leaves Kapilavastu.**
- The lower lintel portrays **Emperor Ashoka visiting the Bodhi tree**.



(Eastern Gateway)

- Decorative elements include **shalabhanjika** (fertility emblems represented by a yakshi grasping a tree branch), elephants, winged lions, and peacocks.

4.Western gateway:

- The Western Gateway, the **last of the four to be built**, follows the same structural design as the other gateways, with two square pillars, capitals, and a superstructure of three architraves.

10. BUDDHIST EXCAVATIONS IN RATNAGIRI

Archaeological Survey of India *has made significant discoveries during ongoing excavations at historic* ***Ratnagiri Buddhist site*** *in* ***Jajpur district****,* ***Odisha.***

MAJOR HIGHLIGHTS

- ASI's ongoing excavations at 5th-13th Century Buddhist complex in Ratnagiri have **uncovered many ancient Buddhist artefacts,** including:
  - Buddhist monastery complex (dates back to 8th CE).
  - Hundreds of votive stupas
  - Colossal Buddha head and sculptural fragments of Buddhist deities, a massive palm.
    - Buddha's head is 3-4 feet tall and the palm is 5 feet.
  - Inscribed stones, pottery, beads, stone pillars
  - Ancient brick wall, believed to be part of a larger structure.
  - Monolithic elephant measuring 5 feet in length and 3.5 feet in height.
- **Significance:**
  - Site experts believe **Ratnagiri rivaled Nalanda** as a centre of Buddhist learning. Findings enhance **Ratnagiri's 1,200-year legacy**, and solidifies its status as a cornerstone of Buddhist heritage in Odisha.
  - Current excavation will greatly enhance understanding of evolution of Buddhism in Odisha, and its **connections with Southeast Asia.**



A view of the Buddha head in Ratnagiri Odisha | Express Photo

RATNAGIRI BUDDHIST SITE

- **Ratnagiri** (hill of jewels) is the site of a **ruined mahavihara** (once the major Buddhist monastery) in **Odisha.**
- **Location**:
  - Located on a hill between **Brahmani** and **Birupa rivers** in Jajpur district.
  - Close to other Buddhist sites in the area, including **Lalitagiri** (oldest Buddhist monastery in Odisha) and **Udayagiri**.
  - Ratnagiri is a part of famous **Diamond Triangle** of Odisha along with Udaygiri and Lalitgiri.
- Developed under the patronage of **Bhauma kara dynasty,** the site flourished as a **prominent Buddhist centre from the 8th-11th centuries CE.**

- Buddhist monuments were constructed from 5th **century CE** onwards, with the last work in the 13th century. The peak period is between about 7th-10th CE.
- Ratnagiri began to **decline in 13th century CE** due to invasions by Muslim rulers. Although some activity at the site persisted until 16th century CE.

- **Key fact:** Buddha sculptures discovered in Ratnagiri feature **intricate and distinctive hairstyles,** not found elsewhere in India.

ODISHA & BUDDHISM

- **Tapassu and Bhallika**, the two merchant brothers, who became the first disciples of Lord Buddha, have their origins from **Utkala** (ancient name of Odisha).
- **Mauryan Emperor Ashoka** (304-232 BCE) invaded **Kalinga** (ancient name for Odisha) in 261 BC, and later embraced Buddhism.
- Though there is **no evidence of Buddha visiting Odisha** during his lifetime, Kalinga played a great role in popularising Buddhism, especially in Southeast Asia due to **its trade links** with the region.
  - Pepper, cinnamon, cardamom, silk, camphor, gold, and jewellery were popular items of trade between Kalinga and SE Asia.
  - Odisha annually holds **Baliyatra** ('voyage to Bali'). It is a 7 day festival to commemorate 2,000-year-old maritime and cultural links between Kalinga and Bali and other SE nations like Java, Sumatra, Borneo, Myanmar and Sri Lanka.
- Studies suggest that renowned **Chinese Buddhist monk and traveller- Hiuen Tsang** visited Odisha (during 638-639 AD), might have visited Ratnagiri.
- In Odisha, Buddhism particularly flourished under the **Bhaumakara dynasty,** which ruled parts of the state between 8th-10th CE.

2 CHAPTER MEDIEVAL HISTORY OF INDIA

1. GURU RAVIDAS

Magh Purnima marks the observance of Sant Guru Ravidas Jayanti (February 24). To commemorate the 647th birth anniversary of Sant Guru Ravidas, Prime Minister unveiled a statue in Varanasi.

ABOUT GURU RAVIDAS

- **Born: 1377 CE in Govardhanpur near (Varanasi) Uttar Pradesh.**
- His place of birth is now known as Shri Guru Ravidas Janam Asthan.
- Revered as a guru in regions such as *Punjab, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, and Madhya Pradesh.*
- **Early life:**
  - **Parents:** Mata Kalsi and Santokh Das, belonged to an untouchable caste and were engaged in leatherworking.
  - At the age of 12, he married Lona Devi, and together they had a son named Vijay Dass.
  - Ravidas redirected his focus towards spiritual pursuits **along the banks of the Ganga.**
  - Took extensive pilgrimage travels to *Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, and the Himalayas.*
  - He became a **disciple of the bhakti saint-poet Ramananda.**
- **Contributions to Bhakti movement:**
  - He adhered to the **Nirguna sampradaya and rejects the Saguna form of Bhakti.**



(Ravidas's statue in Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh)

HISTORIANS OF RELIGION CLASSIFY BHAKTI TRADITIONS INTO TWO BROAD CATEGORIES

1. **Saguna (with attributes):** Focused on the worship of specific deities such as Shiva, Vishnu and his avatars (incarnations) and forms of the goddess or Devi, all often conceptualised in anthropomorphic forms.
2. **Nirguna (without attributes):** Nirguna bhakti on the other hand was worship of an abstract form of God.

  - Ravidas's teachings symbolized **resistance against untouchability, confronting discrimination by higher-caste individuals** against those from lower castes.
    - His egalitarian teachings are adhered by various scheduled classes, now known as Dalits, influencing social-reform movements in the 20th century.
  - He engaged with Sufi saints, sadhus, and ascetics, fostering a diverse spiritual understanding.

IN LITERARY WORKS/TRADITIONS

- **His devotional verses have found a significant place in Sikh scriptures:**
  - Scholars suggest that **Ravidas had interactions with Guru Nanak**, the founder of Sikhism.
  - **41 of his poems are included in the Adi Granth,** signifying his status as one of the 36 contributors to this central scripture of Sikhism.
  - **Premambodha, a Sikh hagiography** written over 170 years after his death, portrays him as one of the seventeen saints in the Indian religious tradition.

- **Dadu Panthi tradition** within Hinduism incorporates numerous poems attributed to **Ravidas in the Panch Vani text.**
- **Anantadas Parcai,** considered one of the earliest surviving biographies of poets from the Bhakti movement, narrates the birth of Ravidas.
- **Bhaktamal,** propose that he was a disciple of the **Brahmin bhakti-poet Ramananda (1400-1480 A.D),** and thus, it is believed that **Ravidas was the contemporary of Sant Kabir.**
- Although Ravidas's hagiographies were penned long after his demise, they shed light on **social dynamics during the period he lived:**
  - Illustrate a clash between heterodox communities and the orthodox Brahminical traditions as well as an inter-communal and inter-religious struggle for social unity
  - Present various legends, including Ravidas's interactions with Hindu Brahmins and **the Delhi Sultanate ruler Sikander Lodi (1458-1517).**

GURU RAVIDAS AND MEERA BAI

- In Chittorgarh, Rajasthan, adjacent to Mirabai's temple, a chhatri (pavilion) having the engraved footprints of Ravidas is found.
- This signifies the spiritual and poetic connection between Ravidas and Mirabai.
  - As per the legends, Ravidas was a guru to Mirabai.
  - Mirabai, as a respect to her Guru, wrote: ***'Guru Miliya Ravidasji'.***

PHILOSOPHY

- A recurring term in his verses is ***'Sahaj,'*** representing a mystical state characterized by the **union of diverse truths into a singular reality.**
- Manuscripts originating from Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh (18th and 19th centuries), feature a debate between **Ravidas and Kabir on the nature of the 'Absolute'.**
  - **Kabir advocates for a monistic Oneness,** while ***Ravidas argues from the premise that the Brahman can be both a monistic Oneness and a separate anthropomorphic incarnation.***
- According to the **Bhaktamal text, Ravidas's teachings aligned with Vedic** and ancient scriptures, **embracing 'non-dualism'.**
  - However, conflicting beliefs within the Dalit community suggest that **Ravidas rejected the Hindu Vedas and faced opposition from Brahmins and caste Hindus**, as reflected in certain hymns **present in the Guru Granth Sahib.**
- **His concept of Beghumpura:**
  - Signifies a **'city without sorrow.'**
  - His vision encompassed a utopian world free from discrimination and inequality.
  - Aiming to eradicate the evil of untouchability.
  - Emphasizing the significance of **labor (Kirat).**
- **Ravidas followed Ananya bhakti,** which emphasises on the devotion that **transcends the sense of duality between the worshipper and the object of worship.**
- **Rejected formal devotion** and advocated for personal bhakti through meditative meditation.
- Disapproved of rituals, pilgrimages, and penances as the optimal paths to realize God.

RAVIDASSIA RELIGION

- **Originating in the 21st century**, it emerged as a distinct faith separate from Sikhism, shaped by the followers Guru Ravidas's teachings.
- It was established following an event in 2009, when Sikh militants attacked a Ravidas temple, in Vienna, Austria.

- Ravidassia religion formulated a new sacred text, the **'Amritbani Guru Ravidas ji'**, exclusively based on teachings and writings of Guru Ravidas and comprises 240 hymns.

2. MEHRAULI

*Mehrauli city in Delhi is **a UNESCO World Heritage Site** and was recently revamped for the G-20 summit.*

ABOUT MEHRAULI CITY

INTRODUCTION

- Mehrauli is **one of the seven medieval cities** that make up the present union territory of Delhi apart **from *Siri, Tughlaqabad, Jahanpanah, Ferozabad, Deenpanah and Shahjahanabad.***
- The **Lal Kot fort was constructed by the Tomar chief Anangpal I** around 731 AD and expanded by **AnangPal II in the 11th century,** who shifted his capital to **Lal Kot from Kannauj.**
- The Tomars were defeated by the Chauhans in the 12th century.
- **Prithviraj Chauhan further expanded the fort, which is now Qila Rai Pithora.** He was defeated and killed in **1192 by Mohammed Ghori, who put his general Qutb-ud-din Aybak** in charge and returned to Afghanistan.
- In 1206, after the death of Mohammed Ghori, **Qutubuddin enthroned himself** as the first Sultan of Delhi.
- **Thus, Delhi became the capital of the Mamluk dynasty of Delhi (Slave dynasty),** the first dynasty of Muslim sultans to rule over northern India.
- **Mehrauli remained the capital of the Mamluk dynasty which ruled until 1290.**
- During **the Khilji dynasty, the capital shifted to Siri.**
- In **12th-century Jain scriptures, the location is also mentioned as *Yogninipura*,** now noticeable by the presence of the 'Yogmaya Temple', near the Qutub Minar complex.
- It was also the **execution place of Banda Singh Bahadur** after he **sacked the regional Mughal capital of Samana.**

VARIOUS HISTORICAL STRUCTURE IN MEHRAULI

- There are a number of tombs of prominent people from the Sultanate (1206 to 1506) and Mughal (1506 to 1857) era. These tombs are usually placed near the dargahs of saints.
  - Tombs of the later Mughals are near the dargah of Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki in Mehrauli or Humayun's tomb near Nizamuddin Auliya's dargah.
- **16th Century tomb of Adham Khan and his mother, Maham Anaga:**
  - Reminder of Akbar's wrath on Adham for murdering his general and prime minister Atgah Khan.
  - Built in an octagonal shape with low towers at corners.
  - Consists of Lodhi-style domed octagonal chambers with 'Verandahs' on each side.
- **Zafar Mahal or Lal Mahal built in red sandstone:**
  - **Zafar Mahal was the summer palace of the last Mughal Emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar II.**
  - ***The building has two components namely, the Mahal, which was built first by Akbar Shah II** in the 18th century, and the entrance gate that was reconstructed in the **19th century by last Mughal ruler Bahadur Shah Zafar II.***
  - Bahadur Shah Zafar II, wished to be buried in the precincts of the Zafar Mahal. However, after the first war of Independence (1857**), he was deported by Major William Hudson in 1858 to Rangoon (Burma/Myanmar),** where he died of old age.
  - This palace is also known for the **Phoolwalon Ki Sair pass.** This festival was started in **1812 by Akbar Shah II's wife Mumtaz Mahal,** after her son **Mirza Jahangir was exiled to Allahabad by the British Resident Sir Archibald Seton.**

- **Jamali Kamali tomb and mosque** contain the tombs of **Sufi saint Jamali or Shaikh Fazlu'llah and his disciple.** *Jamali was a well-known court poet who enjoyed the patronage of the Lodhi dynasty and that of Babur and Humayun as well.*
- **Tombs of Ghiyasuddin Balban (1266-87) and his son, Shahid Khan:**
  - Shahid had died fighting against the Mongols near Multan during Balban's reing.
  - Balban of Mamluk dynasty is remembered for taking strong steps to control dacoity and robbery on Delhi roads in the 13th Century.
  - **Balban's tomb is housed in the building Dar-ul Amaan (**Haven **of Safety)** and as the name suggests, it served as a haven from debt collectors.
  - ***It is the first site where the true arch and dome, a prominent feature of Indo-Islamic architecture, introduced by the Turks, made its appearance.***
- **A baoli or stepwell known as Rajon Ki Baoli**:
  - ***It was constructed in 1506 during Sikandar Lodhi's reign.***
  - It was used to store water.
  - ***It was commissioned by Daulat Khan in 1506 CE, an administrator of the Lodi dynasty of the Delhi Sultanate.***
  - The enclosure of Rajon Ki Baoli includes a mosque and a tomb.
  - The name Rajon Ki Baoli is derived from the 'Rajbirs' or 'Mistris', the term used for masons.
  - A courtyard surrounded by a verandah with many beautiful pillars and the arches in the verandah are made in the typical north Indian fashion of that time.
- **Qutb Complex, close to the North-West of Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque:**
  - Tomb of Shamsuddin Iltutmish (1211-1236 CE):
    - Built by Iltutmish himself in 1235, a year before his death.
    - Made in white marble, surrounded by carved arched entrances on the three sides.

3. TUGHLAQ-ERA DAM STRUCTURE

Satpula is located east of the Khirki Masjid, that is integral to the compound wall of the medieval fourth city of the Jahanpanah in Delhi.

ABOUT SATPULA



- **Built in 1340 by Mohammad Bin Tughlaq (1325-1351) of the Tughlaq dynasty,** the dam served two purposes:
  - **Providing a reliable source of water for irrigation**, and **acting as a defence against possible intruders (such as Mongol invasions).**
  - Served as a boundary wall for **Jahapanah, the fourth city of Delhi**.
- The dam got its name from the seven arches through which water used to flow from a canal originating from the Aravalli.
- **During the British rule,** the stream over which the dam was built was diverted, which reduced the water body to a mere drain flowing on one side.
- **Spiritual significance:**
  - **Sufi saint Nasiruddin Mahmud (popularly known as Chirag Dehlavi/Chirag-e-Dilli)** used to live nearby.
  - People used to believe that the canal water had healing properties.
  - For centuries, the area used to host a Diwali mela.

- **Why was the dam built?**
  - During the rule of Mohammad Bin Tughlaq, the economic conditions of the Delhi Sultanate was in distress:
    - Due to very high expenses incurred on the **war campaign in Deccan.**
    - Also, due to the Sultan establishing his southern capital at **Daulatabad (in 1329).**
    - Between 1334 and 1344, **repeated droughts caused famines, adding to the suffering of the people.**
  - Urgent solutions had to be found.
    - One of the viable options planned was of building **the Satpula, the seven arches bridge or gate-controlled dam,** to tap the water resources of the local stream feeding the Yamuna River.
    - This brought large areas of land under controlled irrigated agriculture to grow food crops.
- **Structure:**
  - **Built using quartz (stone found in the Aravalli).**
  - It has been constructed in **stone masonry.**
  - The eleven bays consist of eleven water tunnels and these are located at different levels, with seven main bays at the lowest level.
  - When built, wooden vertical gates made of heavy boards were **operated by a rope and pulley arrangement to control flow of water.**
- **It connected four principal cities:** the Qila Rai Pithora, Siri, Tughlaqabad, and Jahanpanah.



ABOUT KHIRKI MASJID

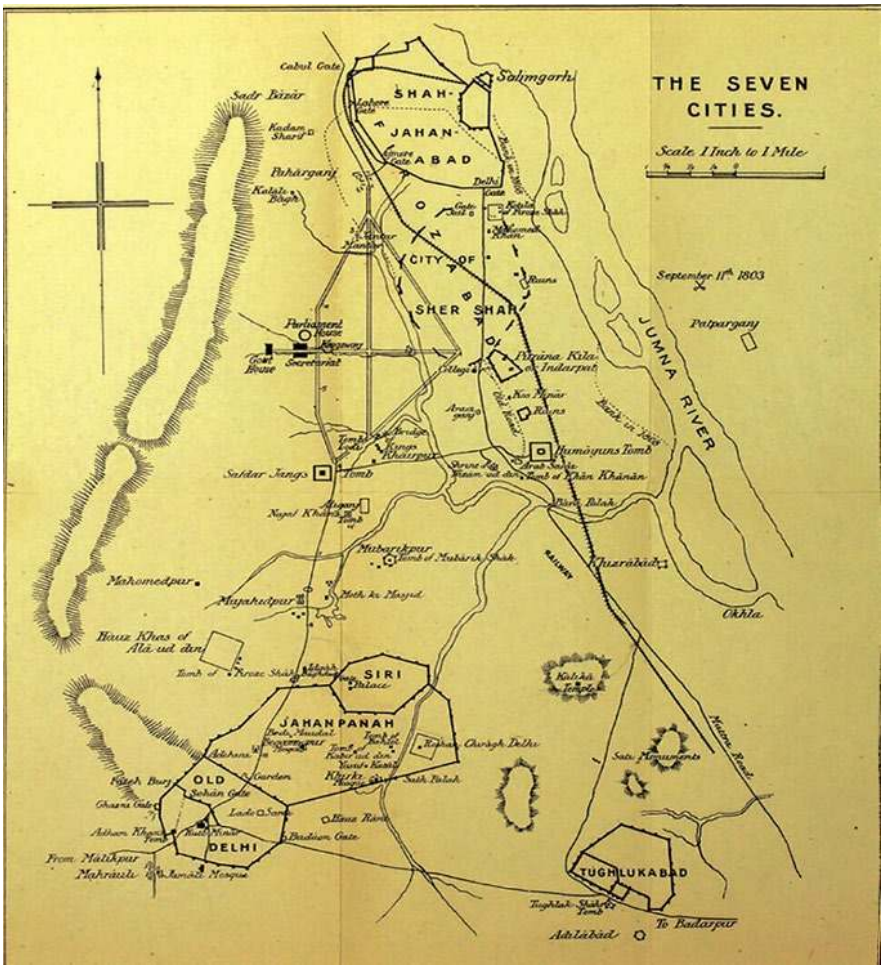
- **Built by Khan-i-Jahan Junan Shah,** the prime minister of **Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351–1388).**
- It is constructed in the Jahanpanah city.
- There are no specific inscriptions on the Mosque on its construction date. The **name of the builder is inscribed on the eastern gate of the Mosque as 'Khan-i-Jahan Junan Shah'.**
- **Structure:**
  - There are four open courtyards encircled by arcades.
  - The main gate, leading to the qibla on the western wall, has a projecting mihrab.
    - Qibla wall is the wall in a mosque that faces Mecca.
    - Mihrab is a niche in the qibla wall indicating the direction of Mecca.
  - Arch windows with perforated screens or jalis known as 'Khirkis', are seen on second floor.
  - The mosque's walls are of **rubble masonry construction** with plastered surface on the outside.

SEVEN CITIES OF DELHI

- **Qila Rai Pithora:**
  - Anangpal Tomar founded Delhi or Lalkot in 1052.
  - Chauhan kings of Ajmer conquered Lal Kot in 1180 and renamed it Qila Rai Pithora.
- **Siri:**
  - It was built by Alauddin Khilji and expanded by subsequent rulers.
  - He constructed Siri between 1297 and 1307 to defend India and Delhi against Mongol raids.
  - Structures inside the Siri fort: Hauz Khas reservoir; Hazar Sutan palace.
  - Subsequent rulers expanded the city with other urban centres like Tughlaqabad, Jahanpanah, and Firozabad.
- **Tughlaqabad:**

- Ghiyas-ud-din Tughlaq founded the fortified city of Tughlaqabad in the 14th century.
- Walled city included seven rainwater tanks.

- **Jahanpanah:**
  - The fourth city of Delhi established in 1326–1327 by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
  - To address the constant threat of the Mongols, the Sultan, built the fortified city of Jahanpanah, which subsumed the Adilabad fort and also all the establishments lying between Qila Rai Pithora and Siri Fort.
  - Partially surviving structures: Bijay Mandal, Begumpur Mosque, Serai Shaji Mahal, Lal Gumbad, Baradari.



  - The accounts of Ibn Battuta's mention that, Lal Kot (Qutb complex) was then the urban area and Siri was the military cantonment.

- **Firozabad:**
  - Built by Firoz Shah Tughlaq, near the Yamuna River.
  - Included Firoz Shah Kotla.

- **Sher-garh or Purana Qila:**
  - Humayun built the city of Dinpanah.
  - But he was ousted by the Suri Dynasty in the Battle of Chausa and the Battle of Kannauj
  - Sher Shah Suri demolished it and renamed it Shergarh or Dilli Sher Shahi
  - It is known as Purana Qila now.

- **Shahjahanabad:**
  - Shahjahanabad was founded by Emperor Shah Jahan in the 17th century.
  - Famous monuments: Red Fort and the Jama Masjid.

4. HISTORY OF SULTHAN BATHERY

Sulthan Bathery *in Wayanad, Kerala, is home to a temple that was partly destroyed by* ***Tipu Sultan and used as a store for arms in the 1700s.*** *There have been political debates going on regarding the question of changing its name to* ***Ganapathyvattam.***

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ABOUT GANAPATHYVATTAM TEMPLE



- Sulthan Bathery has a Jain stone temple that was once known as **Ganapathyvattam.**
- Built in the **Vijaynagara architectural style**, it was constructed by Jains who migrated to Wayanad from areas in present-day Tamil Nadu and Karnataka in the 13th century.
- The temple was partly destroyed **during the invasions of Tipu Sultan, the ruler of Mysuru** in the second half of the 18th century.
- The temple is part of Jain circuit of Kerala.
- Presently, it is under **Archaeological Survey of India as a monument of national importance.**
- **The erstwhile Hindu temple:**
  - During the time of **Kulashekara (an Indian dynasty ruling over parts of Kerala from 9th to 12th century),** the Ganapathyvattam temple was situated here.
  - There are beliefs that the **kings of Purakizha** completed the construction of the temple.
  - **Later, the temple came under the rulers of Kottayam.**
  - Tipu destroyed the Temple and **used the stones for building a Fort.**
  - **The remains or site of this fort is does not exist now.**
  - **Chief deity:** Ganapathi (Lord Ganesh)
  - Other dieties: Baghavathi, Ayyappan, Nagaraja and Shiva.



HISTORY OF SULTAN BATHERY

- **930 AD: ruler Erayappa of the Ganga dynasty** led his troops to the south-west of Mysore and, after **conquering it, called it Bayalnad, meaning the land of swamps.**
- **12th century AD:** Gangas were dethroned by the **Kadamba dynasty of North Canara.**
- **1104 AD**: **Vishnuvardhana of Hoysala** invaded Bayalnad followed by the **Vijayanagara dynasty in the 16th century.**
- **1610 AD: Udaiyar Raja Wadiyar of Mysore** drove out Vijayanagara and became the ruler of Bayalnad.
- **Under Haider Ali and Tipu Sultan:**
  - Between 1750 and 1790, northern Kerala was invaded several times by the rulers of Mysuru, Hyder Ali and Tipu.
  - The armies of Tipu destroyed temples and churches.
  - **Tipu Sultan used Maha Ganapathy temple in Sulthan Bathery** as a battery or store for weapons for his army in the Malabar region.
  - This led to the **British recording Ganapathyvattam as Tipu Sultan's Battery,** and the name survived as **Sulthan Bathery.**
- **Under British rule:**

- East India Company (EIC) seized Wayanad from Pazhassi Raja.
- EIC administered the district until it was superseded by the British Raj in 1858.

5. BHOJSHALA COMPLEX

*The Madhya Pradesh High Court directed the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to conduct a scientific survey of the **Bhojshala Temple**-Kamal Maula Mosque complex.*



ABOUT BHOJSHALA

- **Located in**: Dhar district, Madhya Pradesh
- **Established in**: 1034 AD
- **Built by:** Raja Bhoj of Parmar Dynasty **(1000–1055 AD)**
- **Key features of the temple**:
  - It was the **University** in which the statue of **Vagdevi** (**Mata Saraswati**) was installed.
  - Bhojshala was first attacked by **Alauddin Khilji in 1305 AD.**
  - In 1514 AD, **Mehmudshah Khilji II** attacked Bhojshala and tried to convert it into dargah. He encroached land outside Saraswati Temple and built **'Kamal Moulana' Makbara.**
  - In 1952, the Central Government gave up Bhojshala to the Archaeological Survey of India.
- **Architecture of the complex:**
  - It has a large open courtyard around which there is a **verandah decorated with pillars and a prayer hall is located behind it in the west**.
  - The carved pillars and the exquisitely carved ceiling of the prayer hall were from Bhojshal.
- **Inscriptions:**
  - In the rocks of complex , two hymns written in Prakrit language of the **Karmavatar or crocodile incarnation of Vishnu are engraved**.
  - **Two Sarpabandha pillar inscriptions**, one containing the Sanskrit alphabet and the main endings of nouns and verbs and the other containing the individual declensions of the ten tenses and moods of Sanskrit grammar.
  - These inscriptions belong to the 11th-12th century.
  - Two Sanskrit texts are engraved in **Anustubha verse**.
  - In one of these, Raja Bhoj's **successors Udayaditya and Narvarman have been praised**.
  - In the second, it is told that these pillars were installed by Udayaditya.

6. OLD FORT OF DELHI (PURANA QILA)

***As the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)** prepares for another round of excavations at **the 16th-century fort, the contentious debate over Purana Qila's** historical significance reignites among scholars and historians. Central to this discussion is whether Purana Qila and its surrounding area, served as the legendary capital of the Pandava brothers from the Mahabharata.*



ABOUT PURANA QILA

- Purana Qila is one of the oldest forts in Delhi, India.
- **It was built by the second Mughal Emperor Humayun and Sur dynasty Sultan Sher Shah Suri.**

- **The fort forms the inner citadel of the city of Dinpanah.**

HISTORY

Indraprastha theory:

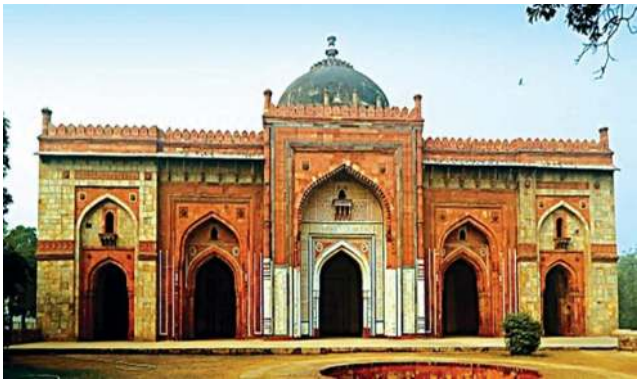
- Excavations point to traces and continued habitation from the 1000 BC, during the Painted Grey Ware period.
- The first two rounds of excavations, by B. B. Lal, had unearthed traces of Painted Grey Ware culture.
- Historian Alexander Cunningham identified the fort with that of Indraprastha, though he referred to the present structure as built by Muslim rulers**.**
- It must be remembered that coordinating material archaeological culture with literary and bardic literature is methodologically difficult:

Dinpanah:

- **Dinpanah, the new city of Delhi was constructed by Mughal emperor Humayun, in the vicinity of the ancient Indraprastha ruins.**
- Abul Fazl stated that fort was built in the place of that of ancient Indraprastha.
- **The founder of the Suri Dynasty, Sher Shah Suri,** defeated Humayun and made changes to the fort, strengthening its fortifications and completing its walls.
- **He also had another fort built there called Shergarh.**
- His project, however, was a continuation of Humayun's construction of a citadel for a royal city.
- **Purana Qila and its surroundings flourished as the 'sixth city of Delhi'.**

ARCHAEOLOGICAL FEATURES

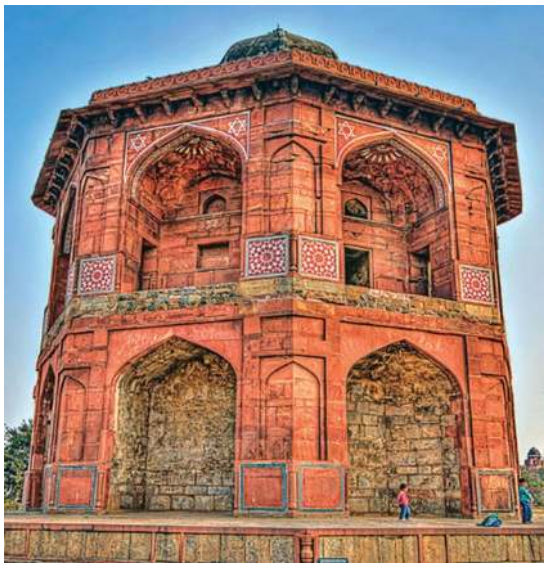
- The walls of the fort have three arched gateways: **the Bara Darwaza; the south gate, also popularly known as the 'Humayun Gate'; and lastly, the 'Talaqi Gate'.**
- **All the gates are double-storeyed sandstone** structures flanked by two huge semi-circular bastion towers, decorated with white and coloured-marble inlays and blue tiles.
- The **gates are designed with detailing, which includes ornate overhanging balconies, or jharokhas, and are topped by pillared pavilions (chhatris),** all features that are reminiscent of Rajasthani architecture.
- Despite the grandeurs of the exterior, few of interior structures have survived except the **Qila-i Kuhna Mosque and the Shermandal, both credited to Sher Shah.**



Qila-Kuhna Mosque:

- **The single-domed Mosque, built by Sher Shah in 1541** is an example of a pre-Mughal design and an early example of the extensive use of the pointed arch in the region as seen in its five doorways with the 'true' horseshoe-shaped arches.
- It was designed as a Jami Mosque or Friday-mosque for the Sultan and his courtiers.
- The prayer hall inside has five elegant arched prayer niches or mihrabs set in its western wall.
- **Marble in shades of red, white and slate is used for the calligraphic inscriptions** on the central iwan/hall, marks a transition from Lodhi to Mughal architecture.

Sher Mandal:



- **Sher Shah tried to finish what was ordered by Babur but had died during the initial phase and so construction was halted until the arrival of Humayun.**
- **It is a double-storeyed octagonal tower of red sandstone.**
- Its original builder was Babur who ordered the construction. It was finished only after Humayun recaptured the fort.
- **It is also one of the first observatories of Delhi, the earliest being in Pir Ghaib at Hindu Rao at Ridge built in the 14th century by Firoz Shah Tughlaq.**
- The tower is topped by an octagonal chhatri supported by eight pillars and decorated with white marble in typical Mughal style.
- Here, in 1556 Humayun fell from the second floor to his death.

Other monuments:

Several other monuments lie around the complex, **like Kairul Manzil, mosque built by Maham Anga, Akbar's foster-mother.**

7. HAMPI-A WORLD HERITAGE SITE

The recent collapse of the Saalu Mantapa at the Virupaksha temple in Hampi has ignited discussions about the potential neglect of one of India's largest World Heritage Sites.

INTRODUCTION

- Hampi is a treasure trove of monuments. Some structures stand proudly against a backdrop of colossal granite boulders, while others lie in disrepair, marred by the ravages of time and conflict.
- Scattered throughout the site are damaged sculptures, elephants missing trunks and musicians with missing limbs, testimonies to the destruction inflicted by a 16th-century war.

CONSERVATION EFFORTS

- **Designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1986, Hampi's heritage is regulated,** though it encompasses 30 villages across two districts, each managed by separate local authorities.
- **The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and the Karnataka government's Department of Archaeology** are responsible for the task of preserving these historical treasures.
- Hampi remained largely forgotten until the late 18th century when British explorers began documenting the site.
- **Colin Mackenzie, the first surveyor-general of India, created the first map of Hampi in 1799, and early restoration efforts began.**
- Systematic excavation began in the 1970s, leading to the Hampi National Project of 1976. This initiative uncovered significant remnants of the 14th-century metropolis, such as the submerged granite pavilions of the Vitthala temple.
- Recent excavations have continued to reveal parts of Hampi's vibrant past, including the paan-supari bazaar, a kilometre-long market.

IMPACT OF UNESCO'S WORLD HERITAGE STATUS

- The World Heritage designation has spurred increased conservation efforts but has also introduced challenges.

- **In 1999, Hampi was briefly placed on the 'World Heritage in Danger List' due to a proposed bridge construction.**
- This led to the establishment of the Hampi World Heritage Area Management Authority (HWHAMA) in 2007, which implemented a masterplan dividing the site into core, buffer, and peripheral zones.
- While the designation has protected Hampi's monuments, it has also led to the displacement of local residents and their commercial activities.
- The HWHAMA regulations have been criticized for excluding local communities from the conservation process.
- For example, the bustling market in front of the Virupaksha temple was cleared to comply with these regulations, affecting local livelihoods.

NEED FOR BALANCING CONSERVATION WITH COMMUNITY NEEDS

- The conservation of Hampi involves more than preserving its physical structures; it requires balancing heritage protection with the needs of local communities.
- Hampi needs better sanitation, green mobility plans, and architectural guidelines.

HISTORY OF HAMPI

- **Founded in 1336 by Harihara I and Bukka Raya I of the Sangama dynasty,** the Vijayanagara Empire flourished across southern India.
- **The site of Hampi was the last capital of the Kingdom of Vijayanagar.**
  - **Anegundi** was the first capital of the Vijayanagara empire.
  - The other capitals of **Vijayanagara were Penukonda and Chandragiri.**
- The Dravidian temples and palaces won the admiration of travellers between the 14th and 16th centuries, like Portuguese Domingo Paes, who described it as 'as large and beautiful as Rome.'
- **Hampi is located on the banks of the Tungabhadra River.**
- **Zones of the Hampi:**
  - **Sacred Centre**: This zone, identified by scholars like Burton Stein, is considered the spiritual and religious heart of the site.
  - **Urban Core/Royal Centre**: This area represents the administrative and royal hub of Hampi, central to the city's governance and elite activities.
  - **Metropolitan Vijayanagara**: The remaining expanse of the site beyond the sacred and royal zones, encompassing the broader urban and suburban areas of the Vijayanagara Empire.

MONUMENTS AND TEMPLES

1.Virupaksha temple:

- Known as the 'Pampavathi Temple,' the Virupaksha Temple **is one of Hampi's oldest** structures.
- Dedicated **to Sri Virupaksha (Lord Shiva) the temple was originally constructed by Lakkan Dandesha, a chieftain under Deva Raya II of the Vijayanagara Empire.**
- Pampadevi, associated with the Tungabhadra River is also worshipped.
- The temple's history dates back to the 7th century CE, with inscriptions referring to Shiva found from the 9th and 10th centuries.



- It features three gopuras (entrance towers).

2.Vittala temple complex:



- **The Vittala Temple Complex, famous for its iconic stone chariot** and the symbol of Karnataka Tourism, is a notable feature of Hampi.
- **It is dedicated to Lord Vittala, an incarnation of Vishnu.**
- The Temple dates back to the 15th century. **It was built during the reign of King Devaraya II (1422-1446 A.D.),** one of the rulers of the Vijayanagara Empire.
- Several portions of the temple were expanded and enhanced during the reign **of Krishnadevaraya (1509 -1529 A.D.).**
- The complex boasts intricately carved pillared halls and **remnants of the Vittalapuram Township that once surrounded it.**



- **The Ranga Mantapa** is one of the main attractions of the Vittala Temple. **It is renowned for its 56 musical pillars.** These musical pillars are also known as **SAREGAMA pillars, indicating the musical notes emitted by them. The musical notes and emanated when the pillars are tapped gently.**

3.Mahanavami Dibba:

- Also known as the **'Great Platform' or 'House of Victory,'** it is a grand ceremonial monument in the royal centre of Vijayanagara.
- The platform's **three-tiered design includes detailed granite reliefs** depicting royal activities, battles, and festivities.
- The top tier, originally supporting a wooden pavilion, was destroyed, but the intricate carvings on the lower tiers remain.
- Adjacent features include an audience hall with stone stubs, an aqueduct leading to a large stepped tank, and additional water pools and gardens.

THE VIJAYANAGARA EMPIRE

INTRODUCTION:

- The Vijayanagara Empire was a prominent late medieval Hindu empire that dominated southern India.
- **Established in 1336 by the brothers Harihara I and Bukka Raya I of the Sangama dynasty.**
- The emergence of the Vijayanagara Empire was a strategic response to the threats posed by Muslim invasions at the end of the 13th century.
- By the early 16th century, **under the leadership of Krishnadevaraya, the empire achieved significant territorial expansion.**
- It subjugated nearly all of Southern India's ruling dynasties, pushed the Deccan sultanates beyond the Tungabhadra-Krishna River doab region, and **annexed the Gajapati Empire (Odisha) up to the Krishna River, becoming one of the most powerful states in India.**
- The empire's territory spanned much of *modern-day Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Goa, and parts of Telangana, Maharashtra, and Sri Lanka.*

EARLY RULERS AND CONSOLIDATION:

- In its formative years, **Harihara I expanded the empire's territory** south **of the Tungabhadra River.**
- By 1374, his successor, **Bukka Raya I, had conquered significant regions including Goa and the Tungabhadra-Krishna River doab.**
- The capital was initially located in **Anegondi but was moved to Vijayanagara** for better defence against northern Muslim invasions.
- **Harihara II,** the second son of Bukka Raya I, continued to consolidate the empire's dominance beyond the Krishna River.
- Subsequent rulers such as **Deva Raya I and Deva Raya II** played crucial roles in fortifying the empire, expanding its territory, and defending it against various external threats.
- **Deva Raya II's** reign saw significant military and diplomatic activity, **including interactions with the Bahmani Sultanate and incursions into Sri Lanka and Burma.**

THE TULUVA DYNASTY:

- **In 1503, Vira** Narasimha **of the Tuluva dynasty** ascended to power, followed by his successor Krishna Deva Raya in 1509.
- **Under Krishna Deva Raya's rule,** the empire reached its zenith, expanding its territory **further into the Deccan and gaining control over key regions such as Raichur and Gulbarga.**
- Krishna Deva Raya's reign was marked by both military successes and extensive cultural patronage.
- Following Krishna Deva Raya's death in 1529, the empire faced internal strife and external pressures.
- The brief but **impactful rule of Sadashiva Raya and the subsequent dominance of Rama Raya** led to internal conflicts and a weakening of the empire's stability.

DECLINE AND FRAGMENTATION:

- **The Vijayanagara empire's power began to decline after the Battle of Talikota in 1565,** where a coalition of **Deccan sultanates decisively defeated Rama Raya, the *de facto* ruler of the Empire.**
- Despite efforts to reconstitute the empire by figures such as Tirumala Deva Raya, the **Vijayanagara Empire eventually disintegrated by 1646.**

CULTURAL LIFE

RELIGIOUS PRACTICES AND SOCIAL NORMS:

- **Sati,** the practice of widow immolation, is evidenced in Vijayanagara ruins, although interpretations of this practice vary among historians.
- The era also saw the rise of socio-religious movements like **Lingayatism,** which influenced social norms and the role of women.
- Women in South India became active in administration, business, and the fine arts, breaking traditional barriers.
- Notable **women poets included Tirumalamba Devi and Gangadevi,** who contributed significantly to Sanskrit literature.

LITERARY DEVELOPMENTS:

- The Vijayanagara Empire was a hub of literary and intellectual activity.
- **Prominent works were produced in Kannada, Telugu, and Sanskrit, with contributions in Tamil** and other regional languages.
- The **empire's administrative and court languages were Kannada and Telugu,** with Telugu literature gaining prominence during the reign of the last Vijayanagara emperors, especially Krishnadevaraya.
- **Sanskrit literature** primarily consisted of commentaries on the Vedas and the Ramayana and Mahabharata epics. Key figures included **Sayanacharya and Vidyaranya,** who wrote influential treatises and commentaries.
- Notable works from the Vijayanagara court included **Jambavati Kalyana by Emperor Krishnadevaraya and Madura Vijayam by Princess Gangadevi, which chronicled the conquest of Madurai.**

- **Kannada literature** flourished with contributions from **Haridasa poets like Purandaradasa and Kanakadasa**, and **Brahmin scholars like Kumara Vyasa, who translated the Mahabharata into Kannada.**
- In **Telugu, the Prabandha style reached its zenith with works like Emperor Krishnadevaraya's Amuktamalyada.**
- The **court's Ashtadiggajas, including Allasani Peddana and Tenali Ramakrishna,** significantly contributed to Telugu literature.

ARCHITECTURE:

- Vijayanagara architecture is known for its **synthesis of Chalukya, Hoysala, Pandya, and Chola styles.**
- This fusion is exemplified in the **ornate Kalyanamantapa (marriage halls), Vasanthamantapa (open pillared halls), and Rayagopura (towers).**
- The use of locally available **granite was a practical choice due to its durability.**
- The architecture of the Vijayanagara period evolved from the **vesara (Deccan-style) to incorporate Dravida-style gopuras.**
- Notable examples include the **Virupaksha temple and the Hazare Rama temple at Hampi.**
- The **Vitthala and Hazara Ramaswamy temples are examples of the ornate Kalyanamantapa style.**
- The construction of **large monolithic sculptures,** such as the Ganesha at Hampi, reflect another architectural hallmark.
- A unique aspect of Vijayanagara architecture is its **incorporation of Islamic features,** including arches, domes, and vaults. This influence, evident in structures like the **'Great Platform' (Mahanavami Dibba), suggests a creative interaction between Hindu and Muslim architectural styles** during periods of peace.

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3 CHAPTER MODERN HISTORY & POST INDEPENDENCE

1. 150TH BIRTH ANNIVERSARY OF BIRSA MUNDA

*The Prime Minister Narendra of India launched a commemorative stamp and coin on to mark the **150th birth anniversary** of **tribal icon and freedom fighter Birsa Munda** in Bihar. Previously, the Central Government in 2021 had decided to celebrate November 15, the birth anniversary of Birsa Munda, as **Janjatiya Gaurav Diwas.***

WHO WAS BIRSA MUNDA?



- Born in 1875, Birsa Munda was an Indian tribal freedom fighter and folk hero who belonged to the **Munda tribe.**
- Between 1886 and 1890, Birsa spent time at a place which was near the centre of the Sardari agitation, a peaceful movement led by the **Oraon and Munda tribes** against British rule. This experience inspired him to join the anti-missionary and anti-colonial cause.
- By 1890, Birsa was deeply involved in the movement against British oppression of tribal communities.
- He emerged as a **prominent tribal leader,** uniting people to fight for their rights. He founded the **Birsait faith** and became a **God-like figure** to his followers.
- His movement attracted members from the Munda and Oraon communities, challenging British conversion efforts and reinforcing tribal unity and resistance.

PLIGHT OF MUNDAS

- The Mundas, a tribe of former nomadic hunters turned farmers in the **Chota-Nagpur region** of present-day Jharkhand, faced significant challenges due to adverse policies and events.
  - Before colonial rule, they practiced **'khuntkatti',** a land ownership system based on customary rights that excluded landlords.
  - However, the **Permanent Settlement Act of 1793** ended this system, enabling colonial exploitation.
  - The East India Company introduced the **zamindari system** for land revenue collection, creating a dual class system of land-owning zamindars, viewed as outsiders or 'dikus' by the indigenous people, and tenant farmers or 'ryots'.
  - This Act allowed the **dikus to claim ownership** through deeds specifying precise areas, displacing the indigenous inhabitants from their ancestral lands.
  - Additionally, the community suffered from **exploitative practices** like the 'begar' system of forced labor, dependence on moneylenders for credit, and the replacement of traditional clan councils with colonial courts.
  - Famines in 1896-97 and 1899-1900 further exacerbated their plight, leading to mass starvation.

THE ULGULAN MOVEMENT (1899-1900) AND AFTERMATH

- The **Munda Ulgulan** (rebellion) stands as one of the most notable tribal revolts in the history of Indian Independence.

- The main cause of the Munda revolt was the **'unfair land grabbing practices'** by colonial and local authorities that demolished the tribal conventional land system.
- Their exploitation included high-interest loans and withheld receipts, leading to conflict with the dikus (outsiders).
- Additionally, large forest areas were declared protected, **stripping the Mundas of their rights.** The Mundas desperately needed a leader to guide their struggle for justice.
- **Course of the rebellion:**
  - Birsa Munda emerged as a leader of the tribal movement.
  - Birsa aimed for **both religious and political independence,** advocating for the Mundas' rights as the true landowners and visioned an agrarian order free from European influence.
  - Birsa called on the Mundas to reject superstitions, abandon animal sacrifice, abstain from intoxicants, wear the sacred thread, and maintain traditional worship in the sarna (sacred grove).
  - He wanted Munda society to get rid of foreign elements and restore its original character.
  - By the 1890s, Birsa had mobilised the tribes, inciting rebellion.
  - In 1894, he declared a revolt against the British and the dikus, aiming to establish a **'Munda Raj'.**
  - Under his leadership, villagers attacked police stations, churches, and government properties in 1899.
  - However, in 1900, the rebels were defeated.
  - Birsa was **captured and died in jail**, while nearly 350 Mundas were tried.
- **Aftermath:**
  - Demonstrated the tribal people's ability to protest against injustice and colonial rule.
  - The British enacted the **Chota-Nagpur Tenancy Act of 1908,** which restricted the transfer of tribal land to non-tribal people, recognized Khuntkatti rights, and banned begari.
  - Consequently, tribals gained legal protection for their land rights.

2. REMEMBERING THE VAIKOM SATYAGRAHA

*The Chief Ministers of Tamil Nadu and Kerala will inaugurate the centenary celebrations of the **Vaikom Satyagraha**. On **March 30th, 1924,** in the **princely state of Travancore,** a non-violent agitation started, which marked the beginning of **'temple entry movements'** across the country.*

INTRODUCTION

- Widespread **caste discrimination and untouchability** across in Travancore.
- Lower castes like the **Ezhavas and Pulayas were considered polluting** and various rules were in place to distance them from upper castes.
  - Idea of caste pollution worked not only on the basis of touch but also sight.
  - **This was documented by Portugues traveller Duarte Barbosa** in his memoirs.
  - They were prohibited not just on temple entry, but even on walking on the roads surrounding temples.
- **Social context of Travancore at the dawn of the 20th century:**
  - A number of **social and political developments** were leading to social change.
  - **Christian missionaries, supported by the East India Company,** had expanded their reach and many lower castes **converted** to Christianity to escape the oppressive system.
  - With pressure from the British Resident as well as the accession to the throne of **Maharaja Ayilyam Thirunal, brought many progressive reforms.**

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- **Example:** Introduction of a modern education system with free primary education for all, including lower castes.
- **Forces of capitalism and western education** created new social hierarchies. Certain sections among the **Ezhavas emerged as an educated class,** and now they were fighting for rights of their community.
- **Ezhavas emerged as the most educated and organised untouchable community in Travancore.** The government's education policies were significant in this regard.
- Some Ezhavas successfully pursued education as a portal to advancement, **however, due to the reservation of posts for members of the upper castes,** they were not able to get the jobs at upper levels.
  - **Example:** In 1918, out of 4000 jobs in the revenue department, 3800 were held by caste Hindus, **a numerical minority in the population.**
- While a small Ezhava elite had begun to emerge, **ritual discrimination was still prevalent.** Continued discrimination sowed the **seeds for agitations to come.**

VAIKOM SATYAGRAHA

- **Vaikom:**
  - Religious town located inside **Kingdom of Travancore.**
  - The town is famous for **Vaikom Shiva Temple.**
  - City was known as **Varanasi of the South.**
  - The temple did not permit lower castes to enter it and even the roads around the Vaikom Shiva temple were closed to the polluting castes.
- The issue of temple entry was first raised by **Ezhava leader TK Madhavan in a 1917** editorial in his paper **Deshabhimani.**
- **Till 1917, the Indian National Congress** refused to take up social reform, but with the rise of Gandhi and increased activism within lower caste communities and untouchables, **social reform soon found itself front and centre of Congress's and Gandhi's politics.**
- **In 1921, T K Madhavan met with Mahatma Gandhi at Tirunelveli** to seek his advice and support for launching an agitation.
- Gandhi's involvement in the struggle proved crucial as it **mobilised the educated upper-caste Hindu opinion in favour of temple entry.**
- **Madhavan joined the Congress and participated in the party's Kakinada session in 1923**, where a resolution was passed for the eradication of **untouchability.**
  - The resolution also stated that temple **entry was the birth-right of all Hindus** and authorised the state Congress to take charge of the struggle.
  - Following which **Kerala Congress formed an untouchability eradication council** under the leadership of **K Kelappan.**
  - The council arrived **in Vaikom in February 1924** to take out a procession through the prohibited roads.
- **March 30, 1924:**
  - Two untouchables and an upper caste Nair community person took the road around Vaikom Shiva temple that was closed to 'polluting castes'.
  - They were arrested and sentenced to six months' imprisonment.
  - **Gandhi approved the agitation and suggested civil disobedience and non-violent satyagraha.**
- Between April and September, protests reached their peak. Protestors sat in front of the barricades, undertaking **rigorous fasts and singing patriotic songs.**
- Leaders such as **Periyar, who was arrested multiple times, and C Rajagopalachari came to Vaikom** to offer support and lead the protesters.
- **Contribution of Periyar:** Social reformer and **President of Madras Congress Committee** E V Ramaswamy Naicker arrived at Vaikom when some leaders of the Satyagraha leaders were jailed.

- **Cross religious support:** Even Christians and Sikhs supported the Vaikom Satyagraha. **A group of 15 Akalis led by Lala Lal Singh and Kripal Singh** opened a vegetarian mess for anyone who visited the Ashram where Satyagrahis stayed.
- **Ashram of Sree Narayan Guru:** Functioned as the camp for the satyagrahis.
- As volunteers and prominent leaders tried to walk through the prohibited roads, they were arrested. The arrested leaders did not seek a bail.
- On the other hand**, counter-agitations raged** on and protesters were often met with violence and intimidation from **conservative caste Hindus.**
- **In August, 1924, the Maharaja of Travancore died,** following which, **the young Maharani Regent, Queen Sethulakshmi Bai, released all prisoners.**
- But when a large group of protesters marched to the royal palace in Trivandrum**, she refused to allow all castes access to temples.**
- **In March 1925, Gandhi began his tour of Travancore and was able to iron out a compromise:**
  - Gandhi organised a peaceful jatha of Hindus from Vaikom to Thiruvananthapuram and back. This **jatha helped raise social consciousness against untouchability.**
  - **Three out of the four roads** surrounding the temples were opened up for everyone but the fourth, eastern road, was kept reserved for brahmins.
  - This was **finally implemented in November 1925,** when the government completed diversionary roads that could be used by the low castes without polluting the temple.
  - **On November 23, 1925, the last satyagrahi was recalled from Vaikom.**

The legacy and the aftermath:

- Vaikom satyagraha saw **previously unseen unity across caste lines.**
- In **November 1936,** almost a decade after the conclusion of the Satyagraha, the historic **Temple Entry Proclamation was signed by the Maharaja of Travancore** which removed the age-old ban on the entry of marginalised castes into the temples of Travancore.
- It showed the effectiveness of Gandhian civil disobedience as a tool for protest.
- The satyagraha brought untouchability to the forefront of political issues in India.

3. FORT EMMANUEL

Historians are seeking steps to conserve the laterite-brick remnants of Fort Emmanuel that was built by the Portuguese in 1503.

ABOUT THE FORT

- Fort Emmanuel, also known as **Fort Manuel, is a ruined fort located in Kochi, Kerala**.
- It was a bastion of the Portuguese and a symbol of the strategic alliance between **the Maharaja of Kochi and the Kingdom of Portugal**.
  - Named after Manuel I (King of Portugal), as the **first Portuguese fort in Asia.**
  - In 1503, the **King of Kochi granted permission to Afonso de Albuquerque** to build Fort Emmanuel near the waterfront of the Arabian Sea.
  - The walls were made of double rows of coconut tree stems securely fastened together and with earth rammed firmly between; **it was further protected by a wet ditch.**
  - The fortifications were reinforced in 1538.
  - The Portuguese built their settlement behind the fort, **including the St Francis Church.**
- Fort remained in Portuguese possession until **1663, when the Dutch captured the territory and destroyed the Portuguese institutions.**
- The Dutch held the fort in their possession **until 1795, when the British took control by defeating the Dutch.**

- By 1806 the Dutch, and later the British, had destroyed most of the fort walls and its bastions.

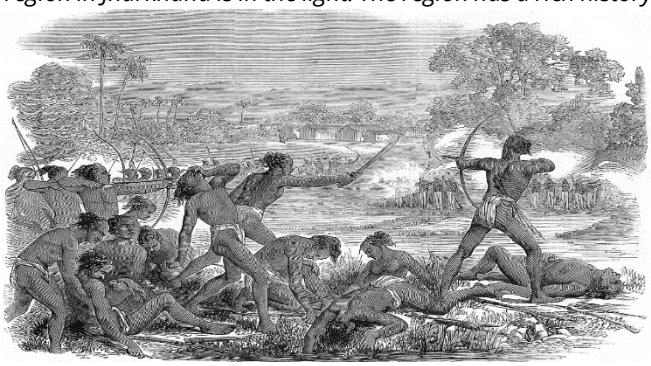
PORTUGUESE SETTLEMENTS IN INDIA

- Controlled areas in Goa, Mumbai, Daman and Diu, as well as in Gujarat.
- Established maritime strongholds and ports Mangalore, Cannanore, Cochin, and Calicut.
- Portuguese constructed military installations and towns at San Thome (near Chennai) and Nagapattinam (in Tamil Nadu).

In West Bengal, a settlement was established in Hooghly.

4. SANTHAL REBELLION (1855-56)

In the last phase of Lok Sabha elections (2024), the Santhal region in Jharkhand is in the light. The region has a rich history and ***most notably is known for the Santhal rebellion which challenged the colonial authorities and those exploiting the tribal community.***



INTRODUCTION

- Following the **Battles of Plassey (1757) and Buxar (1764),** the British East India Company gained control over Indian provinces, including Bengal, Bihar, and Odisha.
- In 1793, **Governor-General Lord Cornwallis** implemented the Permanent Settlement System **in Bengal and Bihar.**
- Permanent Settlement granted hereditary and lifelong rights to zamindars, who paid a fixed amount to the British government annually.
- It resulted in widespread **dissatisfaction** among the local population and **the exploitation of peasants.**

FACTORS RESPONSIBLE

The uprising was fuelled by a multitude of factors that pushed the Santhals to their breaking point.

- **Forced relocation and exploitation:**
  - The Santhals, an agrarian tribal community dependent on forests for their livelihood, were **encouraged to settle in the Damin-i-Koh region** (now part of Jharkhand) established by the East India Company in 1832.
  - They soon discovered that the area was ruled by **zamindars, who were tax-collection agents with significant economic power.**
  - The motive behind this relocation was to meet the demand for **agricultural labor** in areas where the population had significantly declined due to the devastating Bengal Famine of 1770.
- **Exploitation by merchants and moneylenders:**
  - Exploitative practices such as false measurements, usury, and fraudulent lawsuits perpetuated their subjugation and kept them trapped in cycles of debt bondage.
  - The exploitative systems of bonded labor, **known as "kamioti" and "harwahi,"** made it practically impossible for the Santhals to repay their debts.
- **Tyranny of zamindars and capitalist agriculture:**
  - Extraction of exorbitant rents from their meagre earnings.
  - Those employed in indigo plantations faced gruelling labour for meagre wages.
  - The oppressive economic conditions **disrupted their traditional way of life** and further plunged them into poverty.
- **Ineffectual redress and neglect by British administration:**

- The Santhals sought redressal through petitions to the British government and recourse to the courts, hoping for relief from their dire circumstances.
- However, they were met with disappointment and indifference at every turn.

- **Eruption of popular uprising:**
  - As a result of extreme oppression and neglect, social banditry emerged in 1854.
  - Led by figures such as **Bir Singh Manjhi, a group of Santhals targeted moneylenders and zamindars,** redistributing their spoils among the impoverished Santhals.

Course of the Rebellion:

- The **'Hul,'** as this momentous insurrection was known, was led by four brothers from Bhagnadihi village: Sidhu, Kanhu, Chand, and Bhairav Murmu.
- Under their leadership, **around 60,000 Santhals mobilized with traditional weapons.**
- Despite the rebellion primarily being associated with opposition against the British, it actually originated as a revolt against the **exploitation** perpetrated **by Indian 'upper' caste zamindars, moneylenders, merchants, and darogas (police officials), collectively referred to as 'diku,'** who had established dominance over the economic aspects of Santhal life.

IMPACT OF THE REBELLION

- The uprising prompted the British government to pass the **Santhal Parganas Tenancy Act in 1876,** providing some protection to tribal members against exploitation.
- The region between **Bhagalpur and the Rajmahal hills in Singhbhum district** was separated and designated as **Santhal Pargana** which was declared a non-regulation district.
- The Santhal Rebellion **shed light on the harshness** of the zamindari system imposed by the British East India Company on the local indigenous populations.
- It also exposed the **exploitative practices of moneylenders,** who took advantage of the Santhals' unfamiliarity with monetary systems and charged exorbitant interest rates on loans.
- The rebellion had a profound impact on **the Santhali identity and resistance against persecution,** contributing to the establishment of the **state of Jharkhand in 2000**.

THE SANTHAL COMMUNITY

- **Origin and Migration:** The Santhals are believed to have originated from the **Champa Kingdom in northern Cambodia.** They led a nomadic life in the past but eventually settled in the Chhotanagpur Plateau. Towards the late 18th century, they migrated to the Santhal Parganas of Bihar and later expanded into Odisha.
- The **third largest** Scheduled Tribe in India after the **Gond and Bhil** and primarily consists of agricultural people. They are predominantly located in Odisha, Jharkhand, Bihar, and West Bengal.
- Compared to other tribal groups in these states, the Santhal population has a **relatively high literacy rate.** They speak the **Santhali language, which has its own script called Ol Chiki,** recognized in the **Eighth Schedule** of the constitution.

5. AHILYA BAI HOLKAR

May 31st marks the 300th birth anniversary of the Maratha queen Ahilya Bai Holkar *who was a great administrator and visionary. In all her dealings with her subjects, Ahilya Bai was guided by her innate generosity and principles.*

ABOUT AHILYABAI HOLKAR

- **Born in 1725**, she was the Rani of Indore (Holkar dynasty) within the Maratha Confederacy.
- She established **Maheshwar (in Madhya Pradesh) as the seat of the Holkar Dynasty, south of Indore on the Narmada River.**
- After the demise of her husband (Khande Rao) she was trained in military affairs by Malhar Rao Holkar.
- She came to power after the passing of her father-in-law Malhar Rao Holkar.

CONTRIBUTIONS IN CULTURE



- **Ahilyabai funded the reconstruction of the Kashi Vishwanath Temple in Varanasi (1780)** which had been destroyed in the past and subsequently converted into a mosque by Aurangzeb in 1669.
- The current structure of **Vishnupad Temple, Gaya, Bihar was built by Maharani Ahilya Bai Holkar in 1787.**
- Ahilya Bai resurrected the jyotirlingas across the country. Renovations in Somnath, Varanasi, Trambak, Gaya, Pushkar, Vrindavan, Nathdwara, Haridwar, Badrinath, Kedarnath and many other sacred sites were undertaken during her reign.
- The **Maheshwari Sari are also part of the queen's legacy.** She not only promoted the traditional weave but also paved the way for skilling women, thus empowering them. The production of these saris was not only a way to increase the revenue collection of the state, but provided a steady source of income to the weavers. **Under her encouragement, the production of Maheswari saris gained momentum and popularity.**

ABOUT HOLKARS OF MARATHA CONFEDERACY

- **The Holkars were Subedar (one of the designations of a governor of a Subah/province)** under Peshwa Baji Rao I (Pune seat).
- When the Maratha Empire began to weaken due to internal clashes, the Holkars declared themselves the rulers of Indore in Central India, **existing as an autonomous member of the Maratha Empire until 1818.** After this they were **under the protectorate of the British Empire.**
- The dynasty was founded with **Malhar Rao, who joined the service of the Peshwas of the Maratha Empire in** 1721**,** and quickly rose to the rank of Subedar.
- In the 1720s, he led Maratha armies in Malwa region, and in 1733 was granted 9 parganas in the vicinity of Indore by the Peshwa.
- By the time of his death, he ruled much of Malwa, and was acknowledged as one of the five virtually independent rulers of the Maratha Confederacy.
- **He was succeeded by Ahilyabai Holkar (his daughter-in-law).**

6. SWAMI VIVEKANANDA

The Prime Minister engaged in meditation at the Vivekananda Rock Memorial in Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu.

SPIRITUAL SIGNIFICANCE OF VIVEKANANDA ROCK

- Located near **Kanyakumari's Vavathurai beach,** at the southernmost tip of mainland India where the **Indian Ocean, Arabian Sea, and Bay of Bengal converge,** Vivekananda Rock holds profound historical and spiritual importance.
- **In 1892,** according to the disciples of Swami Vivekananda, it was at this place, **he ultimately achieved enlightenment.**

ABOUT SWAMI VIVEKANANDA (1862-1902)

- Swami Vivekananda (original name was Narendranath Datta), emerged as a prominent **advocate** of **Ramakrishna's teachings,** adapting them to contemporary Indian society and becoming a significant figure in the propagation of neo-Hinduism.
- His ideology drew from the spiritual **experiences of Ramakrishna, the teachings of the Upanishads and the Gita, as well as the examples set by Buddha and Jesus**, all forming the foundation of his message on human values.
- **Central to Vivekananda's philosophy was Vedanta,** which he viewed as **a rational and superior approach to spirituality.**

- **His mission aimed to bridge the gap between spiritual pursuits and practical life,** advocating for a holistic approach to human existence encompassing **both paramartha (spiritual service) and vyavahara (daily conduct).**
- Vivekananda stressed the unity of God and humanity, advocating for the integration of Hinduism and Islam in India for the nation's well-being.
- He emphasized the importance of combining knowledge with action, **criticizing the neglect of social issues by religious institutions and urging Hindus to engage actively in social reform.**
- At the 1893 Parliament of Religions in Chicago, **Vivekananda highlighted the need for a balanced synthesis of Eastern spiritualism and Western materialism** to foster global happiness and progress.
- **In 1897 to inspire pride in Indian culture and foster social reform,** he founded the **Ramakrishna Mission,** which has since become a global organization dedicated to humanitarian relief, education, and social service, guided by the principle that service to humanity is akin to worship.
- **The Ramakrishna Mission, though deeply religious, does not seek to convert;** instead, it embraces universal spiritual values and respects diverse religious practices.
- **In 1898, Vivekananda established the Ramakrishna Math in Belur (Karnataka).** It was open to all regardless of caste or creed, symbolizing his vision of an inclusive spiritual community committed to service and enlightenment.
- In 1887, Narendra compiled a **Bengali song anthology named Sangeet Kalpataru** with **Vaishnav Charan Basak.**
- He also composed **'Khandana Bhava Bandhana'**, a prayer song dedicated to Ramakrishna, in 1898.

7. BHIL/BHEEL TRIBE

Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) won in Banswara, Rajasthan in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. The party has focused on the topics of formation of a 'Bhil Pradesh' and an increase in reservation for Scheduled Tribes. There has been a demand for the establishment of a separate state of ***Bhil Pradesh*** *by combining the tribal-dominated parts* ***of Gujarat and neighbouring states Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Maharashtra.***

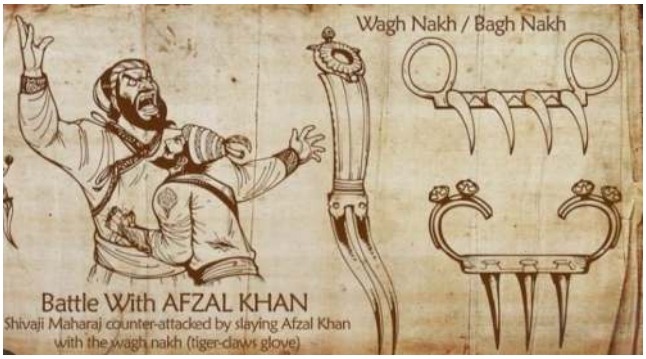
ABOUT BHIL/BHEEL TRIBE

- The tribe live in the states of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Tripura, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.
- **Classified as a Scheduled Tribe in:** Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Tripura.
- **Language:** The commonly spoken language by Bhils is Bhili. **Bhili is a subgroup of the Western Zone of the Indo-Aryan languages.** Many Bhils now speak the dominant language of the region they reside in, such as Marathi, Gujarati and Bengali.
- **Bhil is the largest tribal group in India as per 2011 Census.** They constitute **approximately 38% of the total scheduled tribal population of India.**
- **Culture:**
  - **Pithora Painting** is a well-known art form.
  - These ritualistic paintings were done by **Badwas or specially appointed male members.**
  - **Ghoomar is a traditional folk dance of the Bhil tribe.** Ghoomar is the symbol of womanhood. Young girls take part in this dance.
  - Another folk art is Swang, which consists of storytelling combined with dancing and music.
  - **Baneshwar fair is the main festival** celebrated among the Bhils. The fair is dedicated to Baneshwar Mahadev also known as Lord Shiva.
- **During the British Rule:**

- The Bhils who lived in the **Khandesh region of the present-day Dhule district of Maharashtra,** revolted against Company rule in 1818, as they had to face famine, economic distress and misgovernment.
  - The rebellion was led by Bhil leaders: Kazi Singh and Bhima Naik.
  - It was against the **deprivation of traditional rights over forest resources and land.**
  - The British used both force and conciliatory efforts to control the uprising.
- During the colonial rule, the Bhils were designated as a criminal tribe by the British colonial government under the **Criminal Tribes Act 1871,** which meant that a Bhil could be 'randomly picked up, tortured, maimed or even killed' by the colonial authorities.
- A reformer, **Govind Guru led the Bhils of south Rajasthan (Banswara, South states) to organise themselves to fight for a Bhil Raj by 1913.**

8. SHIVAJI'S 'WAGH NAKH' FROM U.K. TO BE DISPLAYED IN SATARA

*The **iconic wagh nakh or tiger claws used by Maratha king Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj** was brought to India from London. The weapon was brought to Mumbai from the Victoria and Albert Museum to commemorate the **350th anniversary of the famed Maratha ruler's ascension to the throne.***



ABOUT THE 'WAGH NAKH'

- Literally 'tiger claws', the wagh nakh is a medieval claw-like dagger which was used across the Indian subcontinent.
- It was a weapon used for personal defence or stealth attack.
- **It is believed that the 'wagh nakh' was used by Shivaji to kill Bijapur Sultanate's general Afzal Khan in 1659.**
  - Afzal Khan was a general of **Bijapur's Adil Shahi Sultanate.**
  - Shivaji used to be a **former vassal of the Adil Shahis but by the 1650s,** he had become increasingly assertive, taking forts across the Konkan, and bringing under **control** large areas of Adil Shahi territory.
  - Given Afzal Khan's success in the south, he was sent by the Sultan, with a mighty army, to subdue the Maratha icon.
  - **As per historical accounts, the Maratha ruler killed Afzal Khan at the foot of Pratapgarh Fort** in the present-day Satara district of **Maharashtra**.
  - In the **Battle of Pratapgarh, the Marathas defeated the Adilshahi forces**. The killing was a turning point in history as it helped Shivaji to establish the Maratha Empire's rule.

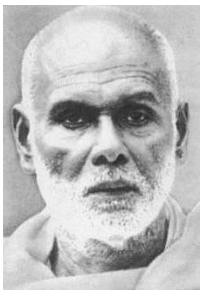
HOW DID CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S WAGH NAKH REACH LONDON?

- According to the Victoria and Albert Museum's website, the weapon was brought to Britain by East India Company officer **James Grant Duff (1789- 1858).**
- Duff was the Company Resident (political agent) of the Satara State from 1818-22. He was also an historian, writing the 'A History of the Mahrattas (1826)'.
- The **last Peshwa (Prime Minister) of the Marathas, Baji Rao II,** surrendered to the British in June 1818 after defeat in the Third Anglo-Maratha War.
  - He was banished to Bithoor near Kanpur.
  - **It is believed that he surrendered this weapon to Grant Duff.**

9. SOCIAL REFORMER NARAYANA GURU

*Recently, there was a political controversy regarding the social reformer **Narayana Guru.***

ABOUT NARAYANA GURU



- Narayana Guru (1856–1928) was a revered Indian social reformer, philosopher, and **spiritual leader from Thiruvananthapuram**, **Kerala.**
- His family belonged to the **Ezhava caste** (lower caste as per social traditions).
- From an early age, he was **drawn towards asceticism**. He lived as a hermit in forests for 8 years. He learnt Vedas, Upanishads, literature, logical rhetoric of Sanskrit, Hatha Yoga etc.
- He is known for his efforts to **reduce casteism** and **social discrimination**. Also he promoted Social justice.
- As a believer of philosophy of **Advait Vedanta,** he propounded the idea of "One Caste, One Religion, one God for Humanity." This idea was reflected in his works of social reforms:
  - **Temple Reforms:**
    - He launched the Aruvippuram **Movement** in 1888. He **consecrated an idol of Shiva at Aravipuram** and defied the religious restrictions traditionally placed on the Ezhava community.
    - In one temple **he built at Kalavancode**, kept mirrors instead of idols, to symbolise that the divine was within each individual.
  - He **lent his support to Vaikkom Satyagraha** (aimed at temple entry in Travancore for the lower castes).
  - **Education reforms** as he established the schools for marginalised sections to promote literacy and knowledge among them.
  - He taught **Sanskrit and Upanishads** to students **from all castes**.
  - He founded an **Advaita Ashram** in Kalady.
- He founded **Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam (SNDP Yogam)** in 1903 to propagate his teachings and provide a platform for social and educational reform.
- He also **authored** various spiritual and philosophical works like:
  - *Atmopadesa Satakam* (A Hundred Verses of Self-Instruction)
  - *Daiva Dasakam* (Ten Verses to God)
  - *Jati Nirnayam* (Critique of Caste)
  - *Arivu* (Knowledge)
  - *Advaitha Deepika*
  - *Thevarappathinkangal*

Not Many, But One: an English translation of poems of Sree Narayana Gurudev.

10. THE EMERGENCY (1975-1977)

The new session of the Lok Sabha (18th) started with an intriguing development when the newly-elected Speaker initiated a motion to condemn the Emergency imposed in 1975.

Introduction: In 1975, India experienced its greatest political crisis since independence when Internal Emergency was declared on 26 June. **The Emergency was a 21-month period from 1975 to 1977.**

CRISIS IN THE PRE-EMERGENCY PERIOD

- By the beginning of 1973 popularity of the Government led by Indira Gandhi began to decline.
- **Little dent was being made in rural or urban poverty or economic inequality,** nor was there any lessening of caste and class oppression in the country side.

- The immediate provocation for the rising discontent was the **marked deterioration in the economic situation.** A combination of recession, growing unemployment, rampant inflation and scarcity of foodstuffs created a serious crisis.
- **The burden of feeding and sheltering nearly 10 million refugees from Bangladesh during 1971** had depleted the grain reserves and, combined with the cost of the Bangladesh war, had led to a large budgetary deficit. **The war had also drained foreign exchange reserves.**
- **Monsoon rains failed for two years in succession during 1972 and 1973,** leading to a terrible drought in most parts of the country and a massive shortage of foodgrains, and fuelling their prices.
- **The year 1973 also witnessed the notorious oil shock when world prices of crude oil increased four-fold,** leading to massive increase in the prices of petroleum products and fertilizers. This drained foreign reserves, further increased the budgetary deficit and deepened economic recession.
- Economic recession, unemployment, price rise and scarcity of goods led to large-scale **industrial unrest and a wave of strikes in different parts of the country during 1972 and 1973, culminating in an all-India railway strike in May 1974.** The railway strike lasted twenty-two days but was broken in the end.
- In May 1973, there was a mutiny in Uttar Pradesh by the Provincial Armed Constabulary , which clashed with the army sent to discipline it, leading to the death of over thirty-five constables and soldiers.
- To tackle the deteriorating economic, **political and law and order situation firm and clear leadership was needed,** as exhibited during the Bangladesh crisis and in the handling of foreign affairs.

THE EMERGENCY

- The then **President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed proclaimed Emergency under Article 352 of the Constitution because of prevailing "internal disturbance"**.
- The proclamation suspended **the federal provisions of the constitution and Fundamental Rights and civil liberties.**
- The government imposed strict censorship on the Press and stifled all protest and opposition to the government.
- The main leaders of the Opposition were arrested **under the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA), 1971.** Among those arrested were Jay Prakash Narayan, Morarji Desai, and Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Congress dissidents such as Chandra Shekhar.
- A series of decrees, laws and constitutional amendments reduced the powers of the judiciary to check the functioning of the executive.
- **The Defence of India Act and MISA were amended in 1975** to the detriment of the citizens' liberties.
- Another law, **Conservation of Foreign Exchange and Prevention of Smuggling Activities Act passed in 1974,** was also frequently used to target political opponents
- In 1976, an effort was made to change the basic civil libertarian structure of the constitution **through its 42nd Amendment.**
- Popular hopes were raised and in **1975, Twenty-Point Programme by Indira Gandhi was announced. Its aim was the socio- economic upliftment of the vast mass of the rural poor.**
  - **The programme promised** to liquidate the existing debt of landless labourers, small farmers and rural artisans and extend alternative credit to them, abolish bonded labour.
  - It aimed to implement the existing agricultural land ceiling laws and distribute surplus land to the landless, provide house sites to landless labourers and weaker sections, revise upwards minimum wages of agricultural labour, provide special help to the handloom industry, prevent tax evasion and smuggling.
  - Three million house sites were provided to the landless and the Dalits.
  - About 1.1 million acres of surplus land was distributed to the landless; this was, however, less than 10 per cent of the surplus land.
  - **The Bonded Labour System stands abolished throughout the country with the enactment of Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976.**

DISCONTENTMENT AMONG PEOPLE

- Within a few months, **however, the people started getting disillusioned with the Emergency.**

- Popular discontent from mid-1976 reached its zenith six months later.
- Relief to the people did not last long. **Economic growth of the first year of the Emergency was not sustained.**
- **Agricultural output declined; prices rose by 10 per cent by the end of 1976.**
- The corrupt, black marketeers and smugglers resumed their activities as the shock of the Emergency wore off.
- The poor were disenchanted with the slow progress in their welfare and workers were unhappy because of limits on wages, bonus and dearness allowance and restrictions on the right to strike
- **Government servants and teachers became discontented** because they were being disciplined in their workplaces and in many cases were being forced to fulfil sterilization quotas.
- So far as the common people were concerned, **matters took a turn for the worse, for there were no avenues of protest or any other mechanism for the voicing and redressal of their grievances.** Even common people and not merely intellectuals and political workers lived in an atmosphere of fear and insecurity .
- The bureaucracy and the police now got increased power that 'was unchecked by criticism and exposure from the Press'.
- A major reason for the growing unpopularity of the Emergency regime was, **however, the development of an extra-constitutional centre of power associated with the rise to political power of Sanjay Gandhi,** who held no office in the government or Congress.
- Pushed by Sanjay Gandhi, the government decided to promote family planning more vigorously and even in an arbitrary, illegitimate and authoritarian manner. Incentives and persuasion were increasingly replaced by **compulsion and coercion and above all by compulsory sterilization.**

Thus, the climate of fear and repression, corruption and abuse of authority and excesses committed by the authorities prevailed.

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4 CHAPTER ART & CULTURE OF INDIA

1. GEOGRAPHICAL INDICATION TAGS

Recently, the Geographical Indications Registry in Chennai, Tamil Nadu has given the Geographical Indication (GI) tags to number of products from various states.

ABOUT THE PRODUCTS

1. Rupa Tarakasi (Silver Filigree), Cuttack, Odisha:

- Traditionally associated with fine craftsmanship and luxurious design in classical jewellery.
- Archaeological evidence suggest that filigree was incorporated into jewellery **as early as 3500 BCE in Mesopotamia (historical region of West Asia in present day Iran)** where **it is practiced even today as Telkari work.**
- As per the historians, Tarakasi work reached Cuttack from Persia through Indonesia some 500 years ago by sea trade.
- **The filigree artists are called 'Roupyakaras'. For Tarakasi, silversmiths use alloy of 90% or more pure silver.**

2. Banglar Muslin, Bengal:

- The Banglar muslin is one of the popular **traditional handloom craft of Bengal.**
- This finest sort of muslin is made of cotton, which are spun to create threads that maintained tensile strength at counts higher than any other cotton products.
- Original muslin was produced solely from **a cotton plant called, Phuti Karpas, that grew exclusively along the banks of a certain stretch of the Brahmaputra River.**
- Tragically, the industry was deliberately erased by past colonial rulers, **especially the East India Company and replaced with their machine-made fabrics in the 19th century.**

3. Narsapur Crochet Lac, Andhra Pradesh:

- **Narsapur in West Godavari region is known for crochet skills.**
- Crochets are beautifully **crafted with cotton thread and it is believed that the women of the farming community** of this region started creating highly attractive artefacts from colourful lace, about **150 years ago.**

4. Kutch Rogan Craft and Ambaji White Marble, Gujarat:

- An ancient textile art, **with its origins in Persia, came to Nirona Village Kutch Gujarat around 400 years ago.**
- Rogan art is produced by **boiling castor oil or linseed oil for about two days and then adding Pigments Mineral Colour (vegetable dyes) and a binding agent (the resulting paint is thick and shiny).**
- Yellow, White and red and Blue, green are the most frequently used colours.
- Rogan art is very well known for its 'Tree of life'.
- **This craft began among the Muslim Khatris community in Gujarat.**

5. Riyawan Lahsun (Garlic), Ratlam, Madhya Pradesh:

- The GI tag opens up new opportunities in international markets, complementing the state government's efforts to promote Ratlam's garlic as a district product.

6. Risa Textiles, Tripura:

- Garments worn by tribal women in Tripura.
- It is wrapped around the upper body.

- **Some of the designs are called 'kosom pali', 'khamjang' etc.**
- To weave a risa, weavers **require cotton yarn in different colours, especially in the colour red, which is most commonly used.**
- The **Reang community usually weave Risa primarily in black yarns, whereas the Debbarma community uses red yarns.**

7. Lac Bangles, Hyderabad, Telangana:

- Lad bazaar is the main production centre for lac bangles.
- **The craft was originated over 500 years ago during Mughal period.**
- The artisan skilfully embellishes the bangle with precious and semi-precious stones.

8. Majuli Mask and Majuli Manuscript Painting, Assam:

(a) Majuli Mask of Assam:

- It developed in the response to **Neo-Vaisnavism, initiated by Srimanta Sankardeva in the 15th century.**
- These masks were developed for it to be used in **Bhaona's (Traditional drama of Assam).**
- Art of making masks was prevalent in Satra community for centuries.
- Made in different variety and sizes as they are mainly **divided into different categories**: ***'Mukha bhaona' (covers the face); 'Lotokoi' (extends to the chest) and, 'Cho Mukha' (head and body mask).***

(b) Majuli Manuscript Paintings:

- Manuscripts are painted on handmade paper, which is treated with a mixture of cow dung and earth to create a smooth surface.
- The paintings are usually done in black and white, although some may have small areas of colour.
- The artists who create these paintings are known as **Sattriya artists, and they are members of the Neo-Vaishnavite monasteries on Majuli.**
- Illustrate stories from Hindu epics like Ramayana, Mahabharata, and the Bhagavata Purana.
- Three distinct styles of manuscript painting: **Gargayan script, Kaithall and Bamunia, flourish in this region.**

2. NAMDA ART OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR

The first batch of Namda Art products for export to the United Kingdom was flagged off. ***Namda is a hand-embroidered rugs*** *made with sheep wool, that reflects the rich culture and history of* ***Kashmir Valley.*** *Namda craft is under the* ***process to get a Geographical Indication tag.***

ABOUT NAMDA PROJECT

- Namda Project, an industry-based training program, **was introduced in 2021.**
- Namda craft is a rug made of sheep wool through **felting technique instead of normal weaving process.**
- It is being successfully revived under **a Skill India's Pilot Project** as part of the **Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY),** with nearly 2,200 candidates from across six districts of the state, receiving training in the dying art form.
- **Need of the project:**
  - Unavailability of adequate raw materials;
  - Dearth of skilled craftsmen;
  - Infiltration of machine-made carpets;

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- Adulteration and inadequate marketing strategies declined the **export by almost 100 per** cent and brought the heritage craft to the brink of extinction.



ABOUT NAMDA CRAFT

- It represents the traditional craftsmanship of Kashmir, focusing on **the creation of rugs primarily crafted from pure sheep wool.**
- Diverging from conventional rug-making methods, this craft employs the **felting technique instead of the typical weaving process,** eliminating any involvement of traditional weaving.
- The term 'Namda' refers to an **additional layer crafted above a standard rug**, **utilizing old blankets in its construction. This versatile craft is designed to suit various climates.**
- This artistic tradition is thought to have originated in the **11th century, attributed to the inventive Nomadic tribes of the Central Asian steppes.**
- The art form gained popularity India during the **reign of the Mughal emperor Akbar.**
  - As per the historical records **Akbar's exchequer named Nubi** personally crafted a felt for Akbar's horse and adorned it beautiful designs through embroidery.
  - This exquisite creation **earned the name Namda in honour of its skilled manufacturer, Nubi.**
- Artisans specializing in Namda can be found across India, particularly in regions like **Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Rajasthan.**
  - The craft is predominantly practiced by the **Pinjara and Mansuri communities, who are Sama Muslims native to Kutch.**

HOW NAMDA IS MADE?

The intricate process involves multiple stages, include carding, border creation, layer formation, soap solution application, rolling, drying, and the meticulous Aari work.

- Involves **carding** the wool, a process dedicated to removing impurities and refining the material.
- Application of soap solution to wash the wool. **Application of water to wool gives binding**, enhancing the **durability and longevity of the Namda.**
- Namda undergoes **rolling/pressuring using a tool called Pinjra** and drying.
- Weaver then attaches the border pattern to the wool to give the foundation.
- Next comes, initiation of the primary layer, and adding of the colour and pattern of the Namda.
- **Aari work:** This stage involves intricate embroidery that imparts a delicate form to the Namda.

3. UGADI FESTIVAL

*Pre-Ugadi festivities started with vibrant **'Jatharas' (fairs)** at Sri Kanakamma Ammavaru Temple in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh.*

ABOUT UGADI FESTIVAL

- Ugadi/Yugadi, also known as **Samvatsaradi (beginning of the year)**, is New Year's Day.

- **Celebrated in the states of:** Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka and Goa in India.
- Locally known as **Souramana Ugadi or Mesha Sankranti** (by followers of Souramana calendar system) in Karnataka.
  - **Souramana,** or the solar year, is a way of measuring time using the movement of the sun.
  - **Chandramana**, or the lunar year, is a way of keeping track of the year with the moon's movement.
- It is observed in these regions on the first day of the Hindu **lunisolar calendar month of Chaitra (falling in late March or early April as per the Gregorian calendar).**
- **Traditions and rituals:**
  - Drawing colourful patterns on the floor called **Muggulu.**
  - Mango leaf decorations on doors called **Torana.**
  - Preparing and sharing a special food called **Pachadi.**
- It has been an historic festival of the Hindus, with medieval texts and inscriptions recording major charitable donations to Hindu temples on this day.
- **Ugadi is one of the five Hindu national public holidays in Mauritius.**



S. NO.	FESTIVAL	INFORMATION
1.	**Puthandu**	• **Tamil Nadu** • First day of year on the Tamil calendar • The festival date is set with the solar cycle of the solar Hindu calendar. • References about the festival: ○ **In Netunalvatai,** by a Sangam period author, Nakkirar ○ **Silappadikaaram** by Illango Adigal ○ **Manimekalai** by Seethalai Satanar
2.	**Jude Sheetal/Maithili New Year**	• **Bihar; Jharkhand** • Celebrated by the Maithilis in Bihar, Jharkhand and even Nepal.
3.	**Novruz**	• Novruz is the Iranian New Year • In India, it is celebrated by the Parsi community. • In **2009, it was inscribed on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity.**
4.	**Vishu**	• **Kerala** • **Festival starts with Vishu Kani:** arranging of harvest's fruits, vegetables and seasonal flowers in front of a mirror. • Devotees visit Sabarimala Ayyappan Temple and Guruvayur Krishna temple for prayers.
5.	**Navreh/Kashmiri New Year**	• Celebrated by Kashmiri Pandits • Dedicated to their Goddess Sharika. • On the eve of the Navreh, the priest of the family provides **a Nechipatra, a collection of the important events and a scroll, Kreel-Pach of the Goddess.**

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6.	**Gudi Padwa/Marathi New Year**	• **Maharashtra and parts of Goa.** • People hoist Gudi dhwaja (a decorated flag to symbolize victory) outside their homes. • Some believe that the festival marks the **victory of Shivaji over Mughal dominance** in the Maharashtra region.
7.	**Shigmo/Shishirotsava**	• By Konkani speaking communities in **Goa and parts of Karnataka.** • **Two variants:** Dhakto Shigmo (small Shigmo) and Vhadlo Shigmo (big Shigmo). • **Dhakto Shigmo:** celebrated by the farmers, labor class, and the rural population; • **VhadloShigmo:** celebrated on a major scale and everyone takes part.
8.	**Cheti Chand**	• Celebrated by the **Sindhi community**. • Marks the arrival of spring and harvest • In the Sindhi community**, it also marks the birth of Uderolal in 1007.** He, as Jhulelal, became the saviour of the Sindhi Hindus.
9.	**Losoong**	• Also known as **Namsoong** • Sikkimese New Year, also observed in Darjeeling (West Bengal) • **Communities: Lepchas and Bhutias.** • Several religious dances **(known as Chaams)** are performed mostly in the famous monasteries.
10.	**Ashadhi Beej**	• Celebrated by the **Kutchi community in Gujarat** • Associated with the beginning of rains in the Kutch region.
11.	**Sajibu Cheiraoba/Nongma Panba**	• **Manipur** • Celebrated by **Meiteis, an ethnic group who follow Sanamahism (traditional Meitei religion).** • Observed on first day of Manipuri **lunar month Shajibu** (month of April every year)
12.	**Pana Sankranti/Vishuva Sankranti**	• **Celebrated in Odisha** • An earthen pot is filled with a sweet drink which is known as Pana and hung over a Basil (Tulsi) tree.

4. TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

*Recently, **six sites from Madhya Pradesh** have been added to the Tentative list of UNESCO World Heritage Site.*

These sites are:

1. Historic Ensemble of Dhamnar
2. Khooni Bhandara, Burhanpur
3. Rock Art Sites of the Chambal Valley
4. Bhojeshwar Mahadev Temple, Bhojpura
5. Gond monuments of Ramnagar, Mandla
6. Gwalior Fort

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A WORLD HERITAGE SITE AND TENTATIVE LIST

- A World Heritage Site is a place that is **listed by UNESCO for its special cultural or physical significance.**

- The list of World Heritage Sites is maintained by the international 'World Heritage Programme', administered by the UNESCO World Heritage Committee.
- To get its heritage site considered for inscription on the World Heritage List, **the country makes an inventory of important natural and cultural heritage sites located within its boundaries.**
- **This 'inventory' is known as the Tentative List.**
- Making it to the tentative list thus is the first step for any site which seeks final nomination for becoming a World Heritage site.

(a)About Historic Ensemble of Dhamnar:



(Picture: Dhamnar Caves site)

- **Location:** Mandsaur district (formerly Dasapura), Madhya Pradesh.
- **Modern Account of the site:**
  - Earliest reference to these monuments comes from **James Tod** who visited in 1821.
  - **James Furgusson** visited the site in 1845 and **Alexander Cunningham** visited the site between 1864-1865.
  - Dating of the caves is difficult due to absence of inscriptions, therefore, these monuments can be dated to **the 7th century CE on the basis of few similarities with caves at other sites, such as Ajanta and Ellora.**
  - The name 'Dhamnar' is not known from any historical or literary sources.
  - Buddhist establishment here was known as Chandananagari-mahavihara as **evidenced by a clay seal discovered by Historian A.H. Khan.**
    - Scholar **K.C Jain opined that the present name Dhamnar** is a derived from the **Shaivite epithet 'Dharmanatha'**
    - **Dharmanath:** Name of the Linga setup in the rock-cut Vaishnava temple during the medieval period.

ABOUT DHAMNAR CAVES

- **Series of 51 rock-cut caves,** stupas, chaityas, passages and compact dwellings. These caves were cut out from a hill of **coarse laterite stone.**
- These monolithic spaces were further carved to form grand doors with carvings, columns, and religious sculptural symbols.
- **Built around 1123 years ago:** 5th, 6th and 7th century CE (7th century CE was the second wave of cave construction in India).
- These caves contain structures belonging to: **Buddhism (both Hinayana and Mahayana)** and **Hinduism (presence of the Dharmarajeshwara temple).**
- Secluded spaces for monks, **also known as Viharas are found.** These are fairly simple volumes with a lack of ornamentation.
- Representation of Buddha by motifs and sculptures as a form of religious symbolic art.
- **Some caves found with no iconic ornamentation indicates that these possibly belong to the Hinayana Sect of Buddhism.**
- The Archaeological Survey of India, restored the structures here, as the porous laterite rocks which got weathered over the centuries, destabilised and weakened the structures.

SOME SPECIAL FEATURES

- **Rani ka Makan/Kamaniya Mahal cave (Cave no. 10)**
- **Bhim Bazar Chaitya (Cave no. 11):**
  - Most extensive of all the excavations.

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- **Stupa: Buddha is sculpted in seated posture.**
- Stupa with three-tier **chhatravali** and circumambulatory passage.

- **Chota Bazar/Child's cave (Cave no. 13):**
  - Chaitya-griha
  - **Nirvana image of Buddha depicted on the east wall.**
  - Depiction of Buddha, as seated upon a throne, in the teaching attitude.
  - **Buddha, is known to locals as Bhima.**
  - **Principal shrine with Pradakshinapath (circumambulation).**
    - On the back wall of the shrine, are five images, three seated and two standing.
    - Three seated figures are known by locals as: Pandu with his two sons, Arjuna and Nakula.
- **Bari Kacheri/Big courthouse (Cave no. 6):** includes stupas and chaityas; stone railing with the wooden architecture.
- **Hathi-ka-mekh/Elephant's stable/Hathi-bandhi (Cave No 12):** simple chaitya cave where the stupa is placed to support the roof.

ABOUT DHARMANATHA TEMPLE AT THE SITE

- The temple is situated north of Cave No. 12 of the Buddhist cave group.
- **Rock-cut temple is excavated in a rectangular pit within the hill.**
- The courtyard can also be accessed from the top of the hill by the rock-cut stairs provided.
- The sculpture on the south is that of **Bhairava and on the north is of Kali.** The latter carries **an inscription** dating to the 8th-9th century CE.
- **Features:**
  - ***Garbha-griha, Antarala, Mandapa* and *Mukha-mandapa*.**
  - It is surrounded by **seven subsidiary shrines.**
    - Thus, the temple falls under the ***sapta-parivara* (family of** seven) category, that is generally seen in **Southern India for Shiva temples.**
    - *Among the seven subsidiary shrines,* ***the ones located in the corners are with Latina-Nagara shikhara.***
    - *The* ***ones opposite the garbha-griha are of the Phamsana shikhara.***
  - The temple is known as **Chaturbhuj temple** by the locals due to the **image of a four-arm Sheshasayi-Vishnu** installed inside the *Garbha-girha.* Vishnu is holding Shankha, Chakra and a Lotus flower.
  - **Main temple is *Pancharatha:***
    - Consisting of one *bhadra,* two *prati-ratha,* and two *karna* projections.
    - **P*rati-ratha* is decorated with '*ghata-pallava*' motif.**
    - The vertical elevation has *shikhara.*
    - The **shikhara is Latina style of the Nagara type,** consisting of six bhumis (tiers) marked by **bhumi-amalakas** at the Karna.
- **Inside the *garbha-griha* is a Shivalinga known as Dharmanatha.**
- The southern shrine has a panel depicting dancing Shiva surrounded by four *Matrkas.* **On the right of Shiva are Maheshwari and Vaishvani while on his left are Indrani and Brahmi.**
- An interesting feature is the **omission of Buddha who is replaced by a figure of Vishnu instead.**
- There is an inscription and its palaeography helped in dating the temple to the latter half of the 9th century CE.

(b)The Gond monuments of Ramnagar, Mandla:

INTRODUCTION

- Mandla region was formerly known as the Central Provinces of India, covering parts of the present-day states of Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra.

- It was historically called Gondwana, 'the Land of the Gonds', the **largest heterogenous tribe of India.**
- Four major kingdoms ruled over the region, the most important being the **Garha-Mandla kingdom.**
- **In 1651, when the Bundelas finally** captured **Chauragarh,** during **Hriday Shah's reign,** he shifted the **capital from Chauragarh to Ramnagar (1657 A.D).**
  - On the southern bank of the Narmada River in Ramnagar and the Chaugan Rayotwari, the architectural **complexes built by Hridya Shah** still stand today.
  - The royal palace, Moti Mahal, indicates the new seat of government in the late 17th century.
  - Mughal and Rajput influences are evident in the architectural elements of these buildings.
    - **Stone latticed screens,** shows the influence of Mughal architecture.
    - **Decorative stone parapets, chattris, bangaldar roofs, multi-foil arches in the exterior facade** are characteristic Rajput features.
  - The geographical features of the site further indicate the planning principles adopted with respect **to defence mechanisms with the surrounding landscape of the dense forests** on the banks of the Narmada River.
  - None of the monuments have excessive ornamentation since they **were not intended as castles displaying artistic capacity or opulence.**

CLUSTER OF MONUMENTS

ABOUT MOTI MAHAL

- Situated near the Narmada River bank.
- **Declared as a state protected monument since 1984.**
- Moti Mahal, is built in a quadrangle shape and has a central courtyard.
- The monument also has a basement with a network of tunnels and passages.
- **It also has an elaborate drainage system, which is connected to the Narmada.**
- **A stone inscription, believed to be inscribed in 1667 A.D.,** is also found (which was previously in the Vishnu temple).
  - It is considered one of the most important historical sources **recording the genealogy of the Gond rulers of Garha Mandla.**
  - It places the origin of the family in the beginning of the **7th century and describes the chronological reign of 54 Gond rulers.**

RAIBHAGAT KI KOTHI

- It is also known as **Mantri Mahal.**
- Also, declared a **state protected monument since 1984.**
- The residence was **built by Hriday Shah for his Dewan, Rai Baghat.**
- Monument appears more symmetric with the central courtyard and the four domes on each corner.

VISHNU MANDIR (ALSO KNOWN AS SURAJ MANDIR)

- The temple **resembles a Mughal tomb or a Bengali Pancha Ratna style temple.**
- The temple was built by **Rani Sundari. She was wife of Hriday Shah.**
- The inscription stone housed in the Moti Mahal was originally in the Vishnu temple.
- The structure is built in square plan.
- As per the sources, **there were idols of Shiva, Ganesha, Surya and Durga, but none of them have remained.**
- Declared a **state protected monument since 1984.**

Begum Mahal:

- It is a **centrally protected Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) monument.**
- The structure was built by **King Hriday Shah for Chimni Rani, a Mughal princess.**

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- It is a three-storey tall structure with visible Mughal features in its architecture.

Dalbadal (Sporting Palace):

- It is a centrally protected Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) monument.
- It is a rectangular structure built by **King Hriday Shah for his generals and soldiers.**

(c)The Bhojeshwar Mahadev Temple:

INTRODUCTION

- **Situated:** along the Betwa and Kaliasot Rivers, Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh
- **Constructed:** during the 11th century
- **Patronage of:** Raja Bhoja of the Paramara dynasty
- **Dedicated to**: Lord Shiva
- **Paramara dynasty:**
  - Raja Bhoj emerged as a celebrated monarch.
  - **He was renowned his architectural treatise, the "Samaranganasutradhara".**
  - The Bhojpur temple remains the sole surviving shrine linked to Bhoja.
- The temple has been designated as a **Monument of National Importance by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).**

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES OF THE TEMPLE

- **Bhumija style emerged in the 9th century** and flourishing until the 13th century. It is **an evolved form of the Nagara temples.**
- The main structure and the shikhara in this style **harmoniously blend influences from the Dravida style of temple architecture.**
- The **temple does not have a mandapa,** which have led researchers to propose the hypothesis of it being a funerary monument.
- The unfinished shikhara is decorated with **small sub-shrines or kuta-stambhas** and **corner bands known as Lata.**
- The temple has **a square plan and it is built on a raised plinth** with ornate carvings and sculptures in its exterior.
- In the centre, the **garbhagriha is constructed which houses a massive lingam**, carved from a single stone.
- **Projecting balconies** are built on three sides of the temple.
- The northern wall features **a makara-pranala,** which provided a drainage outlet for the liquid used to bathe the lingam.
- The four brackets supporting the cornerstones feature four different divine couples: **Shiva-Parvati, Brahma-Shakti, Rama-Sita, and Vishnu-Lakshmi.**

CULTURAL CONTRIBUTIONS OF KING BHOJA

- Under his rule, Malwa and its capital Dhara became one of the chief intellectual centres of India.
- **Chintamani-Sarnika (1055 CE) was composed by his court poet Dasabala.**
- Besides the Bhojeshwar Temple, he also construction of **three dams in Bhojpur.**
  - The first dam, built on Betwa River.
  - A second dam was constructed in a gap between the hills.
  - A third dam diverted more water from the smaller Kaliasot river.
- Bhoja established the **Bhoj Shala which was a centre for Sanskrit studies** and a temple of Saraswati in Dhar.
- Bhoja was renowned as a scholar king, and several books are attributed to him. He was an expert on poetry, and the **treatise Shringara-Prakasha was authored by him.**
- **Some of his surviving works in Sanskrit language:**

- *Bhujabala-bhima,* a work on astrology
- *Govinda-vilasa,* poem
- *Raja Mriganka Karana,* a treatise on chemistry, dealing with the extraction of metals from ores, and production of various drugs.
- *Samarangana-Sutradhara,* a treatise on architecture and iconography.
- *Vidvajjana-Vallabha,* treatise on astronomy.
- *Vyavahara-Manjari,* a work on dharmasastra or Hindu law.
- *Yukti-Kalpataru*, a work dealing with several topics including statecraft, politics, city-building etc.

- **His Prakrit language poems are:** Kodanda-Kavya and Kurma-Sataka.
  - The **Kodanda-Kavya** was found inscribed on stone slab fragments at Mandu.
  - The **Kurma-Sataka** was found inscribed at the Bhoj Shala in Dhar.
- **Decline:**
  - Experienced a decline in their power, ultimately leading to the **defeat and death of the final recorded ruler, Mahalakadeva,** by the **forces of Alauddin Khilji of Delhi in 1305 CE.**

(d) Khooni Bhandara:

INTRODUCTION

- An underground water management system which is built **on Persian qanat approach, in 1615 CE.**
- Out of eight sets of these subterraneous channels, six are still intact.
- It has been declared as **state protected structure by the State Directorate of Archaeology, Archives and Museums.**
- **Commencement of Mughal rule in late 16th century:**
  - Burhanpur became the **centre of military activities and commerce** as well as the base for the expansion of Mughals in South India.
  - **Abdul-Rahim Khan-i-Khana** was the Governor of the Subah of Khandesh during the **reign of Jahangir. His capital was Burhanpur.**
  - He planned to excavate an underground canal in the vicinity of Burhanpur, to augment the potable water supply of the city.
  - The canal was constructed under the supervision **of Tabaqat-al-Ardh or the Department of Earth (sciences),** that looked after such constructions.
  - **A Persian geologist, Tabkutul Arz,** was invited to investigate the valley in the **Tapti** plains**. After the investigation, he devised a system.**
    - This was based on the ancient water supply system that in Arabic is called **Qanat (originated 3000 years ago in Persia).**
    - **Qanat or Kariz system:** It is built for transporting water from an aquifer or water well to the surface, through an underground aqueduct.

(e) Gwalior Fort, Madhya Pradesh:

INTRODUCTION

- Initiated by **Raja Sourya Sena** who finished the fortification around the plateau in 773CE.
- **Early rulers of this region included:**
  - Mauryas, Sungas, Kushanas, and Nagas, who held power there until the fourth century CE.
  - Guptas ruled over this place till the 5th century CE.
- Inscriptions on the **Chaturbhuja temple (dated 875 and 876 CE):** Shows that Gwalior was included in the kingdom of Kannauj.

- **From 1398 AD -1516 CE**:
  - Gwalior came under the **Rajput** Dynasty **of Tomars.**
  - It was extensively constructed in the reign of **Raja Mansingh Tomar.**
  - After his death, the **fortress fell to Ibrahim Lodi.**
- **Mughal rule:**
  - Mughals succeeded the Lodi dynasty at Delhi **(Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi at the Battle of Panipat in 1526).**
  - Within a decade, the Mughal Emperor Babur captured the fort from the Delhi Sultanate.
  - Mughals lost the fort to **Sher Shah Suri in 1542.**
  - Afterwards, the fort was captured and used by **Hemu, the Hindu general and, later, the last Hindu ruler of Delhi, but Akbar recaptured it in 1558.**
  - With the decline of the Mughal empire, Gwalior passed into the hands of the rising Maratha power represented by **Scindias in** Central **India.**

ABOUT THE FORT (A HILL FORT)

- It is a hill Fort.
- Protected under the Archaeological Survey of India and the Madhya Pradesh State Archaeology.
- The fort consists of a defensive structure and two main palaces, **Man Mandir and Gujari Mahal,** built by **Tomar Rajput ruler Man Singh Tomar (reigned 1486–1516 CE).**
  - Glimpses of the Bagh Paintings are found.
  - Main entrance of the Man Mandir, is the **Hathi Pol Gate (or Hathiya Paur).**
- The monuments at the fort shows **architectural blend of Mughal and Rajput elements.**
  - **Examples:** mosaic tiles, stone jalli patterns, stone columns and brackets and domed turrets; chhatris placed on the gates and corner bastions.
- **The fort has impressive ramparts and gateways**.
  - Gwalior gate is the main entrance to the fort connecting the historic city of Gwalior to the fort.
  - Also known as the Alamgiri gate, it is attributed to the **reign of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb.**
- The Fort also houses **impressive palace structures constructed later by the Sultanate and Mughal rulers.**
  - Shahjahan constructed the **Shahjahan Mahal.**
  - It is constructed in the Mughal style, but it is considerably less ornate than other Mughal palaces of the time.
- **Among the water management systems,** the fort has access to water with a number of reservoirs such as **Mansarovar Tal, Gangola Tal, Ek Khamba Tal, Katora Tal, Rani Tal, Chedi Tal, and Jauhar Kund.**
- The **Scindia School, founded in 1897 CE** by Maharaja Madho Rao Scindia, is also located within the fort complex.

TEMPLES WITHIN THE FORT COMPLEX

- An inscription found here describes a **sun temple** built during the reign of the **Hun dynasty king Mihirakula in 6th century.**
- **Teli ka Mandir:**
  - Dedicated to lord Shiva, Vishnu, and Matrikas (group of mother goddesses who are always depicted together in Hinduism).
  - Built by the **Mihira Bhoja (Gurjara-Pratiharas in the 9th century).**
  - It is the **oldest part** of the fort.
  - It integrates the **architectural elements of the Nagara style and the Valabhi prasada.**
- **Chaturbhuj temple:**

- The **second oldest record of numeric 'zero' (Symbol '0') in the world** was found here in the stone inscription. The **inscription is around 1500 years old.**
- It has an inscription that opens with a praise for *Vishnu (Vaishnavism), then Shiva (Shaivism) and nine Durgas (Shaktism).*
- The inscription also states that it was **excavated in 876 CE.**

- **Sas Bahu temples or Harisadanam temple:**
  - **11th-century twin temple.**
  - Dedicated to Vishnu in his **Padmanabha form.**
  - It was built in **1093 by King Mahipala of the Kachchhapaghata dynasty.**
  - It had a **North Indian Bhumija style architecture**.
  - The pillars show Vaishnavism, Shaivism and Shaktism related carvings.
- **Siddhachal Jain Temple Caves (Urvashi/Urwahi valley)**:
  - Built between **7th to 15th century.**
  - Jain temples inside Gwalior fort dedicated to the **Jain Tirthankaras.**
  - Many of the statues were defaced and destroyed under the orders of the **Muslim Emperor Babur of the Mughal dynasty in the 16th century.**
  - The statues depict all **24 Tirthankaras.**
  - They are shown in both **seated Padmasana posture** as well as **standing Kayotsarga posture.**
  - The largest of these are for **Rishabhanatha (Adinatha),** identifiable by the **bull emblem carved on the pedestal under his foot.**
  - Other statues include a **seated Neminatha (shell icon on his pedestal), Parshavnatha with serpent cover over his head and Mahavira (lion icon on his pedestal).**
  - It is one of the **Archaeological Survey of India's Adarsh Smarak Monument** along with other monuments in the Gwalior Fort.

(f) Rock Art Sites of the Chambal Valley:

- Chambal Basin and Central India region contain the largest concentration of known rock art sites in the world.
- Rock art sites have thrived in the hilly areas: **Vindhyan, Satpura, and Kaimur ranges.**
- **These rock art sites are from:** Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic, Chalcolithic, Megalithic, and Proto Historic periods.
- Currently, **only Chaturbhujnath Nala is partially protected by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).**



(Battle scene, on a rock painting from Chambal Valley)

- **Chambal River:**
  - Known as **Charmavati in ancient times,** originates from the Malwa trap zone.
  - **Covers:** Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh.
- Earliest traces of human habitation in the region are **Acheulian tools, including cleavers, hand axes, scrapers, cores, have been found here.**
- Chambal basin rock art includes:
  - **Cupules, with the oldest ones found at Darki, Madhya Pradesh.**
  - Petroglyphs (cupules) discovered at **Chattaneshwar and Kanyadeh (Rajasthan).**

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- **Bhanpura (Madhya Pradesh)** area also boasts a significant collection of petroglyphs.
- **Engraved ostrich eggshells found at Chandrasel in Kota district (Rajasthan)** date back approximately 40,000 years B.P.

- **Rock art themes during the Mesolithic period:**
  - Scenes from the lives of simple hunting and gathering societies.
  - **Bichrome paintings (in two colours)** were a notable feature of Mesolithic rock art.
- **Chalcolithic period:**
  - Pastoralism and cattle herding became prominent themes
  - **Economic importance of Humped cattle:** It is appearing in about ninety percent of the rock art depictions.
  - Cattle were also depicted in other art forms like terracotta bull figures, seals, and sealings.
  - Red and its variants were the most commonly used pigments.
  - **Chalcolithic sites in Chambal basin:**
    - **Ahar (Rajasthan), Kayatha (Madhya Pradesh) and Malwa (Malwa region of Central India and parts of Maharashtra in the Deccan Peninsula.**
    - Ahar culture, dating around 3600-1500 B.C.E., is believed to be the **first to settle in the Basin and establish settlements.**
    - **Ahar culture sites: Balathal, Gilund, and Ojiyana (Rajasthan).**
- **Not much information about the rock paintings from the Megalithic phase have been found:**
  - However, a few dolmens with cup marks have been discovered.
  - Cup marks were found on the capstones of dolmens and on boulders withing stone circles from the **Kotra Vihar (Madhya Pradesh).**
- **Early Historical period:**
  - Rock art is typically found in isolated locations near **perennial water sources.**
  - These locations also contain remnants of **ancient temples or mounds from this historical era.**
  - Many of these sites have temples dedicated to deities **like Shiva or mother goddesses.**
  - **Significant social, political, and economic change:**
    - Establishment of **states, organized religions, and the use of** written **scripts,** all of which are reflected in the rock art of this era.
  - **Religious symbols sin rock art:** fire altars, kalashas, swastikas, triratna, and alpana patterns.
  - Art reflects themes and designs from local traditions, including rangoli patterns and depictions of human forms.
  - Rock art includes representations of Hindu deities like Ganesha, Rama.
  - **Religious Sites in the Chambal Basin:** *Bhimlat Mahadev, Chatturbhuj Nath Nala, Garadia Mahadev, Bukki Mata, Chattaneshwar, Kanyadeh, Narsinghgarh, Kotra Vihar Jogania Mata, and Gepadnath.*

5. KASHAN STYLE CARPET OF KASHMIR

***Kashan style is a historic design of the Iranian city of Kashan**, employed in carpet making in Kashmir. Kashmir is among the leading carpet-producing States in India and over one lakh artisans are employed by the carpet industry here.*



HISTORY

- The origin of hand knotted carpets locally known **as 'Kal baffi' dates back to 15th century.**
- It is said that **Sultan Zain-ul-Abidin brought carpet** weavers from Persia and central Asia in to Kashmir to train the local inhabitants.

- **Shah Rukh Shahi Khan, popularly known as Ghiyas-ud-Din Zain-ul-Abidin** was the ninth Sultan of Kashmir, who reigned first from 1418 to 1419 and then from 1420 to 1470.
- **He was famously called Budshah by his subjects.**
- The **Mahabharata and Kalhana's Rajatarangini were translated into Persian** by his order.

- There are different types of knots and in Kashmir the **Farsi baff and the Persian system known as Sehna, or Sinneh,** knot is originally used.
- Designs and patterns in Kashmir carpets continue to be predominantly inspired by classical Persian and Central-Asia rugs.
  - Thus, Kashmir has been creating **Kashan and Kirman, Tabriz and Isfahan, Meshed and Bokhara.**

KASHAN RUGS

- Kashan rugs, renowned for their intricate designs and cultural significance, **originated in Iran.**
- Kashan rugs typically feature intricate **medallion designs (an oval or circular design, portrait, relief carving, etc. resembling a medal in shape) at the centre.**
- These rugs are renowned for their rich colour palettes. Deep reds, blues, ivories, and earthy tones are common.
- The combination of these colours adds to the rug's allure and creates a vibrant masterpiece.
- **One hallmark of an authentic Kashan rug is its fine knot density.**

6. UNESCO'S MEMORY OF THE WORLD ASIA-PACIFIC REGIONAL REGISTER

*The inclusion of the **Ramcharitmanas, Panchatantra, and Sahṛdayāloka-Locana in UNESCO's Memory of the World Asia-Pacific Regional Register** marks a significant milestone for India. This recognition celebrates India's profound literary heritage and cultural legacy, underscoring its global importance.*

IGNCA SECURES HISTORIC CULTURAL MILESTONE

- The Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) played a pivotal role in achieving a landmark moment during the **10th meeting of the Memory of the World Committee for Asia and the Pacific (MOWCAP).**
- The meeting of MOWCAP was held in Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia), which **brought together 38 representatives from member states along with 40 observers and nominees.**
- IGNCA advocated for three Indian nominations, resulting in their inclusion in 'UNESCO's Memory of the World Asia-Pacific Regional Register'.
- This achievement highlights IGNCA's steadfast commitment to preserving and promoting India's rich cultural heritage on the global stage.
- **Notably, this is IGNCA's inaugural submission to the Regional Register since its establishment in 2008.**
- **The Illustrated Manuscripts of Ramacaritamanasa,** commonly known as 'Ramcharitmanas', was created by **Goswami Tulsidasa in the 16th century in the Awadhi language**. This monumental work is regarded as one of the foremost achievements in Hindu literature, **drawing its inspiration from the epic Ramayana authored by the sage Valmiki.**
- **The 15th Century Manuscript of the Panchatantra, authored by Pandit Vishnu Sharma,** is a collection of animal fables presented in both poetry and prose. Dating back to at least the **3rd century BCE, this ancient compilation originally written in Sanskrit aims to impart practical life lessons, known as Niti**, through the interactions of anthropomorphized animals.
- **The Sahṛdayaloka-Locana manuscript, an important text in Indian poetics, dates back to the 9th and 10th centuries AD.** Authored by **Acharya Anandvardhan,** it comprises extensive discussions on **poetics, dramaturgy, and theatrical insights** in **Sanskrit literature.**

UNESCO'S MEMORY OF THE WORLD (MOW) PROGRAMME

- The Memory of the World (MOW) programme, initiated by **UNESCO in 1992,** serves as a global strategy to preserve and promote access to rare and endangered documentary heritage.
- Its mission, articulated to **prevent "collective amnesia,"** underscores the importance of **safeguarding archive holdings and library collections worldwide.**
- The programme recognizes **documentary heritage of international, regional, and national significance, maintaining registers and awarding logos to identified collections.**
- It advocates for preservation and equitable access, raising awareness among governments, the public, and businesses about the need for conservation and fundraising.
- Inscription on the MOW register validates the cultural and historical value of documented heritage, **enhancing visibility and accessibility for research, education, entertainment, and long-term preservation efforts.**
- **The Memory of the World Asia-Pacific Committee (MOWCAP), established in 1998,** specifically celebrates achievements across **43 countries in genealogy, literature, science, and more.**
  - **The MOWCAP Regional Register includes 65 item**s that reflect the diverse cultural richness and historical significance of the **Asia-Pacific region.**

7. ODISHA STYLE TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

All four gates of the Jagannath temple in Puri, Odisha were opened for devotees. The temple was closed during the Covid-19 pandemic lockdown. The main entrance was opened last year in December but the other gates remained closed.

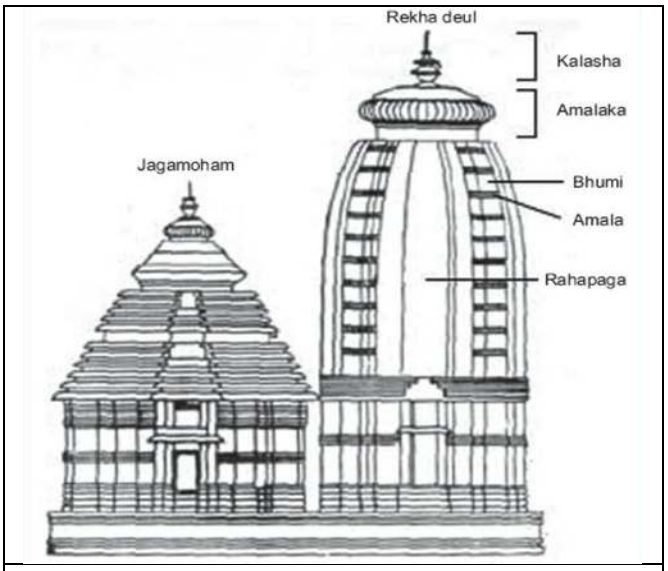
ABOUT JAGANNATH TEMPLE

- An important Hindu temple dedicated to **Jagannath, a form of Vishnu.**
- **Location:** Puri, Odisha (eastern coast of India).
- **Jagannath, Subhadra and Balabhadra** are deities worshipped at the temple.
- The temple is sacred to all Hindus, and especially in those of the **Vaishnava traditions and is one of the 108 Abhimana Kshethram of the Vaishnavite tradition.**
- **Many great Vaishnava saints,** such as Ramanujacharya, Nimbarkacharya, Vallabhacharya and Ramananda were closely associated with the temple.
  - Ramanuja established the Emar Matha in the south-eastern corner of the temple.
  - Adi Shankaracharya established the Govardhan Math, which is the seat of one of the four Shankaracharyas.
- It is also of particular significance to the followers of **Gaudiya Vaishnavism, whose founder, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, was attracted to the deity, Jagannath.**
- The worship is performed by the **Bhil Sabar tribal priests, as well as priests of other communities in the temple.**
- Unlike the stone and metal icons found in most Hindu temples, **the image** of **Jagannath is made of wood (neem wood, known as Daru)** and is ceremoniously replaced **every 12 or 19 years by an exact replica.**
- The temple is one of the **Char Dham pilgrimage sites, the other being Rameshwaram, Badrinath and Dwarka.**
- **The four gates of the temple:**
  - The four gates of the Jagannath temple are located on the mid-points of its boundary wall, and face the four cardinal directions.
  - **The main east-facing entrance is the Singhadwara (Lion's Gate),** and has two stone sculptures of lions standing guard. It is believed that those who enter through this gate attain **moksha, or liberation from the cycle of birth-rebirth.**
  - The northern, southern, and western entrances are known as *Hastidwara (Elephant Gate), Aswadwara (Horse Gate), and Vyaghradwara (Tiger Gate) respectively.*

- The Jagannath Temple is a monumental example of **Nagara-style Hindu temple architecture.** It is one of the finest preserved specimens of **Kalinga architecture (Odisha temple architecture).**

ODISHA SCHOOL/KALINGA SCHOOL OF TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

- The temples of Odisha constitute a distinct sub-style within the Nagara style of temple architecture.
- The style consists of three distinct types of temples: ***Rekha Deul, Pidha Deul and Khakhara Deul.***
    - **Rekha Deul and Pidha Deul are associated with Vishnu, Surya and Shiva temples** while **Khakhara Deul is mainly associated with Chamunda and Durga temples.**
- In general, **the shikhara, called Deul in Odisha,** is vertical until the top when it suddenly curves sharply inwards.



(Figure: Basic structure of a temple in Kalinga school)

- **Deuls are preceded, by mandapas called jagamohana in Odisha.**
- The main temple's floor plan is **usually square.** As the temple structure rises, **it becomes circular.**
- The walls of both the deula and the Jagmohan are intricately sculpted with architectural motifs and a profusion of figures.
- Temples were surrounded by a **boundary wall as in Dravidian style of temple architecture.**
- **Examples:** Sun Temple at Konark (also known as Black Pagoda as the first rays of the Sun entered the garbhagriha through the sea-facing pagoda), Jagannath temple at Puri, Lingaraj temple at Bhubaneswar, etc.

8. SRINAGAR GETS WORLD CRAFT CITY TAG

*Srinagar has earned the **World Craft City (WCC) tag from the World Crafts Council (WCC),** a non-government organisation working to empower artisans and safeguard craft heritage globally. This is likely to reopen Kashmir's centuries old linkages with craft centres in Central Asia and Iran.*

SIGNIFICANCE

- Srinagar, with over 4,000 years of documented history, has recently garnered attention for its rich artistic traditions.
- As of now, at least 10 different forms of craftsmanship survive in Srinagar and its suburbs, **including papier-mâché, walnut wood carving, carpets, Sozni embroidery and Pashmina and Kani shawls.**
- **The 14th Century marked a pivotal moment** for Srinagar's craft scene, influenced by Persian and Central Asian artisans and thinkers.
- Today, the World Crafts Council serves as a contemporary platform to celebrate cities steeped in centuries-old creativity and aesthetics.
- World Crafts Council designation for Srinagar will provide lasting benefits, including global visibility, increased market demand, sustainable income opportunities, and preservation of cultural heritage and artisanal skills through enhanced networking and collaboration.
- **In 2021, Srinagar achieved UNESCO Creative City status for Crafts and Folk Art, a significant recognition for generations of often overlooked craftsmen.**

Note:

- ***Jaipur (Rajasthan), Malappuram (Tamil Nadu) and Mysore (Karnataka)** are the other three Indian cities that have earlier been recognised as World Craft Cities.*

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WORLD CRAFTS COUNCIL

- **The World Crafts Council is a non-profit, non-governmental organization** that was founded **in 1964** to promote fellowship, foster economic development through income generating craft related activities, organize exchange programs and to offer encouragement, help, and advice to the crafts persons of the world.
- **The WCC is organised into five regions:** Africa, Asia Pacific, Europe, Latin America, and North America**. The organization is affiliated to UNESCO**.
- **The WCC was founded in 1964 by Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay and Aileen Osborn Webb**.
  - **Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay founded the Craft Council of India in 1964** to protect and enhance India's craft heritage.
- The World Crafts Council meets every four years. In 2012, the General Assembly occurred in Chennai.
- **World Craft City Programme:** It was launched in **2014 by the World Crafts Council AISBL (WCC-International)** to recognise the pivotal role local authorities, craftspeople, and communities play in crafts development across the world.

9. SOMANATHAPUR

*The Tourism Department in Karnataka is planning to promote the **UNESCO World Heritage Site of Somanathapur as part of Mysuru tourism circuit.*** **Somanathapur** is a town in Mysore district in Karnataka. It is famous for the **Chennakesava Temple also called Kesava temple.**

ABOUT CHENNAKESAVA TEMPLE AT SOMANATHAPUR

- **The Chennakesava Temple is a Vaishnava Hindu temple** on the banks of **River Kaveri in Somanathapur.**
- The temple is **a model illustration of the Hoysala architecture**.

HOYSALA ARCHITECTURE

- The Vesara style, from its nascent stage under the patronage of the Badami Chalukyas in the 7th century, it matured during the Western Chalukya era in the 11th century.
- **However, it reached its zenith as an independent and distinct style during the reign of the Hoysalas in the 13th century.**
- One of the hallmark features of Hoysala architecture is the **star-shaped ground plan (known as Stellate plan)** employed in many of their temples, although staggered square plans are sometimes observed.
- **The temples were erected on a raised platform called Jagati, which stood at approximately 1 meter in height.**
- **The Hoysalas favoured soapstone (chloritic schist)** as their primary construction material.
- This soft stone allowed for exquisite carving and intricate detailing, enabling the creation of the elaborate sculptures and motifs that adorn the temples.

- The temple is enclosed in a courtyard with a pillared corridor of small shrines (damaged).
- The main temple in the centre is on a high star-shaped platform **with three symmetrical sanctums (garbha-griha),** set in a square matrix oriented along the east-west and north-south axes.
- **The sanctums share a common community hall (sabha-mandapa) with many pillars.**
- **In 2023, the Somanathapur temple, along with the Hoysaleswara Temple at Halebidu and the Chennakeshava Temple at Belur,** was declared a **World Heritage Site by UNESCO as part of the Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysala**

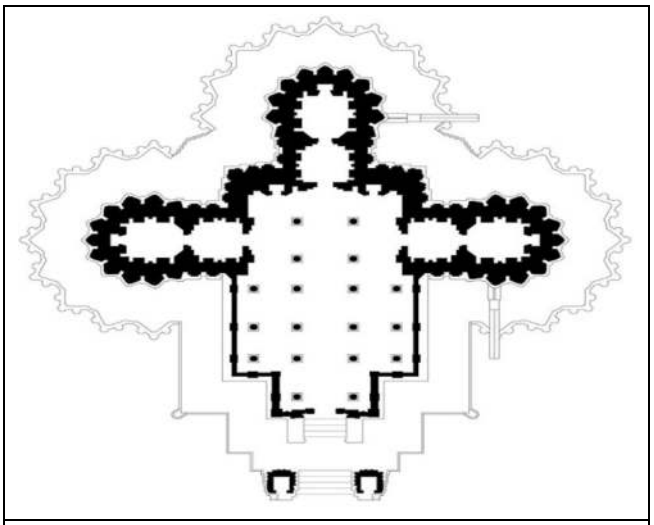
HISTORY

- The Somanathapur town was founded in the **13th century personality, Somanatha (Someya Dandanayaka in some inscriptions),** who was working as **Governor for the Hoysala King Narasimha III.**

- **Somanatha created an Agrahara, that is granted land to Brahmins** and dedicated resources to build and maintain temples therein. **The town (pur) became known after the name of the patron, Somanatha-pur.**
- In the middle of the new settlement, **Somanatha built the Kesava temple and consecrated it in 1258 CE.** This was a **Vaishnavism tradition temple.**
- The Kesava Temple was damaged according to 15th-century inscriptions, after wars between the Hindu kingdoms and Muslim Sultanates ravaged the region.
- **It was repaired in the 16th century with financial support and grants by the emperors of the Vijayanagara Empire.**

ARCHITECTURE

- The northern and southern row of small shrines inside the pillared courtyard corridor consists of eighteen single shrine and one linked-double shrine each.
- The statues in the smaller shrines were defaced, their limbs broken or destroyed. Some of the recovered broken pieces are in a heap inside the temple. **The collection includes Jaina statues in the Kayotsarga posture as well as numerous Hindu statues.**
  - **Kayotsarga is a yogic posture which is an important part of the Jain meditation**. It literally means 'dismissing the body'.
  - Kayotsarga means 'to give up one's physical comfort and body movements', thus staying steady, either in a standing or other posture.



(Floor plan of Chennakesava temple)

- **The main temple is built on a Jagati,** which symbolizes worldly platform. **It is in the star-shaped (stellate plane) form.**
- The raised Jagati platform circles around the main temple with a broad walking space, **which is the Pradakshina Patha (circumambulation path).**
- From the Jagati level, there are **four stone steps that leads the devotee into the temple's Sabha Mandapa inside.**
- The temple has **three sanctums (Garbha Griha), all supported by intricately carved pillars.**
- The three sanctums house Keshava (the image is lost), Janardhana and Venugopala.
- **The North Indian Style (Nagara style) tower (Shikhara) rises above each of the three sanctums.**

10. THANGKA ART

The Thangka painting *is a work of art and also a matter of cultural identity for the Tibetans residing in Majnu Ka Tila, Delhi. The traditional Thangkas are usually small in size and many of the original ones came in sets or as a series of narrative mythological scenes.*

ABOUT THANGKA ART

Origin and history:

- Tibetan Buddhist painting developed from widespread traditions of early Buddhist paintings which now only survive in a few sites such as the **Ajanta Caves in India and the Mogao Caves in China.**
- **The thangka form developed alongside the tradition of Tibetan Buddhist wall paintings,** which are or were mostly in monasteries.
  - The early history of the art form is more easily traced through these murals, which survive in greater numbers.

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FEATURES

- **It is a Tibetan Buddhist painting on cotton, silk applique,** usually depicting a Buddhist deity, scene, or ***mandala.***
- Thangka means ***'thing that one unrolls',*** which means unframed painting rolled up after completion. These paintings are usually called unframed.
- The most common is a **loosely woven cotton produced in widths from 40 to 58 cm (16 - 23 inches).** While some variations do exist, thangkas wider than 45 cm (17 or 18 inches) frequently have seams in the support.
- The paint consists of **pigments in a water-soluble** medium **of animal glue.** Both mineral and organic pigments are used.
- Commonly painted by **Holy lamas or Buddhist monks.**
  - The intricate pieces depict the life story of Buddha or other Buddhist deities and influential Lamas and serve both as devotional objects and teaching tools.
  - Most thangkas were intended for personal meditation or instruction of monastic students.
  - A central deity is often surrounded by other identified figures in a symmetrical composition.
  - **Narrative scenes are less common, but do appear.**
  - One important subject is the ***Wheel of Life (Bhavachakra), which is a visual representation of the Abhidharma teachings (Art of Enlightenment).***
- **Two largest thangkas** are displayed at **Potala Palace in Tibet,** which also holds a collection of 10,000 Thangka paintings dates back to 300 years.

THANGKA PAINTING IN INDIA

- **Thangkas were painted in all the areas where Tibetan Buddhism flourished,** which included *Mongolia, Ladakh, Sikkim, and parts of Himalayan India in Arunachal Pradesh,* Dharamshala*, and Lahaul and Spiti district in Himachal Pradesh.*
- Thangka paintings of **Himalayan North-East Zone** are a sacred form of art maintained and preserved by the local Buddhist.
- Thangka paintings are reliable source of information and pillar of Buddhism.
- Tibetan Thangkas have depiction of Rinpoche and Dalai Lama whereas ***Sikkimese thangkas have depiction of Chogyal or last King of Sikkim along with Rinpoche and Monks.***

Though Thangka art has also been influenced by industrialisation, commercialisation and mass production, it has not impacted the traditional production method unlike India's Madhubani art, which has seen a decline in quality due to adoption of non-traditional colour schemes.

11. 'MOIDAMS' INSCRIBED IN THE WORLD HERITAGE LIST

The Charaideo Moidams, a unique 700-year old mound-burial system of the Ahom dynasty from Assam, was officially inscribed on the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) World Heritage List*, becoming the 43rd property from India to be included in the prestigious index. The announcement was made at the ongoing 46th session of the World Heritage Committee being held in New Delhi.*

ABOUT MOIDAMS

Introduction:

- The **nomination dossier for the Moidams** was sent more than a decade ago and is presently on the **tentative list of UNESCO World Heritage Site**, which is the first step towards the monument becoming a part of the final list.
- **The Tai-Ahom clan upon their migration from China** established their capital in different parts of the Brahmaputra River Valley between **12th to 18th CE**.
  - **The Ahom or Tai-Ahom is an ethnic group,** presently in Indian states of Assam and **Arunachal** Pradesh.

- **Siukapha/Sukaphaa,** established the **first capital of the Ahoms at the foothill of Patkai hills** and named it **Cheraidoi or Charaideo.**
- While the clan moved from city to city, the **landscape of Cheraideo** continued to retain its position as most sacred, **where the Royals used to be buried after death.**
- Their unique system of vaulted mounds **continued for 700 years**, *till many Tai-Ahoms converted to Buddhism while others adopted the Hindu system of cremation.*
- **The property and Buffer zones around Cheraideo** are jointly protected and managed jointly by the **Archaeological Survey of India and the State Department of Archaeology** under the **Ancient Monuments and Sites Remains Act 1958** (Amended in 2010) and by the Assam Ancient Monuments and Records Act 1959 respectively.



SIGNIFICANT FEATURES OF MOIDAMS

- **The Mound-Burial System of the Ahom Dynasty** are a sacred landscape in eastern Assam, with more than *ninety burial mounds established by the* Tai-*Ahom over 700 years ago.*
- **The moidams of Charaideo** contain the remains of the Tai-Ahom kings. They are set within a sculpted landscape that reflects Tai cosmologies.
- **Moidams are vaulted chamber (chow-chali),** often double storied entered through an arched passage.
- On the top of the the hemispherical mud-mound, **layers of bricks and earth is laid**, where the base of the mound is reinforced.
- Excavation shows that **each vaulted chamber has a centrally raised platform where the body was laid.**
- Several objects used by the **deceased during his life, like royal insignia, objects made in wood or ivory or iron, gold pendants, ceramic ware, weapons were also buried.**
- The crematory rituals of the Royal Ahoms were conducted with grandeur, reflecting their hierarchy.
- **The Changrung Phukan (canonical text developed by the Ahoms)** records the materials used to construct a Moidam.
  - There is a great variety in materials and systems of **construction** used in building a moidam.
  - From the period between **13th CE to 17th CE**, **wood was used as the primary material** for construction **whereas 18th CE** onwards **stone and burnt bricks** of various sizes were used for the inner chambers.
  - **Boulders of different sizes, broken stones, bricks, and broken brick** were used to construct the **superstructure**, whereas **large stone slabs were used for the sub-substructure.**

The Mound-Burial System of the Ahom Dynasty are an outstanding example of a Tai-Ahom necropolis (an extensive and elaborate burial place) that represents tangibly the Tai-Ahom funerary traditions and associated cosmologies.

ABOUT TAI-AHOM KINGDOM

- The Ahom kingdom (1228–1826) was a late medieval kingdom in the Brahmaputra Valley (present-day Assam).
- **Established by Sukaphaa, a Tai prince** from present-day Yunnan Province, China.
- The Ahom dynasty created a **new state by overpowering the older political system of the bhuiyans (landlords).**



- **By the 16th century,** the Ahom empire expanded their influence and built a large state.
- The Ahom empire followed a **monarchical system of governance.**
- **The kingdom became weaker with the rise of the Moamoria rebellion,** and subsequently fell to repeated Burmese invasions of Assam.
- With the defeat of the Burmese after the First Anglo-Burmese War and **the Treaty of Yandabo in 1826, control of the kingdom passed into East India Company hands.**

12. PROJECT PARI

*The **Ministry of Culture, Government of India,** on the occasion of the **46th Session of the World Heritage Committee Meeting,** hosted by India for the first time, has initiated **Project PARI (Public Art of India).** The session of the World Heritage Committee is being held at the **Bharat Mandapam International Exhibition and Convention Centre (IECC), New Delhi.***

- **The logo of the 46th World Heritage Committee** meeting is inspired by the World Heritage Site of **Hampi (Karnataka).**
- The stone chariot from the **Vijaya Vitthala Temple** is a testament to India's architectural grandeur and sculptural prowess.
- The **tagline of the logo** is ***"सह नौ यशः which means in English as May our Glory Grow".***
- The tagline has been derived from the ancient Sanskrit scripture ***'Taitiriya Upanishad'*** which is the testament to our ancestor's wish of growth to one and all.

ABOUT PROJECT PUBLIC ART OF INDIA (PARI)

INTRODUCTION

- Public art spaces of India are a reflection of our Lok Kala and Lok Sanskriti. Public Art is very dynamic and is an intersection of past, present, and future.
- The art form which is freely accessible to the public, attracts not only attention but even thoughts begin to gather as to why this work of art is here, what is its uniqueness, what material it is made up of, and what is the thought of the artist behind this artwork.
- **Thus, making it open to various interesting interpretations.**

PROJECT PARI

- **The Lalit Kala Akademi, an autonomous institution under the Ministry of Culture,** has invited more than 150 visual artists from all over the country.
- The aim is to provide a platform to uplift the aesthetic and cultural outlook of Delhi while adding grandeur to the rich historical legacy of our national capital.
- **Lalit Kala Akademi and the National Gallery of Modern Art** seek to bring forth public art that draws inspiration from millennia of artistic heritage *(lok* kala*/lok sanskriti*) while incorporating modern themes and techniques.
- These expressions underscore the intrinsic value that art holds in Indian society, serving as a testament to creativity and artistic expression.
- The proposed sculptures being created for Project PARI include wide-ranging ideas such as *paying tributes to nature, ideas inspired by the Natyashastra, Gandhi ji, toys of India, hospitality, ancient knowledge, Kalpataru-the divine tree, etc.*
- Furthermore, in sync with the proposed 46th World Heritage Committee Meeting, some of the artworks and sculptures draw inspiration from ***World Heritage Sites such as Bhimbetka and the 7 natural World Heritage Sites in India find a special place in the proposed artworks.***

THE ART FORMS SHOWCASED

- Traditional art forms as well as sculptures, murals, and installations have been created under this beautification project.

- **The creative canvas includes but is not limited to artwork inspired by and /or drawn in styles of:**
    - ***Phad paintings*** *(Rajasthan);* ***Thangka painting*** *(Sikkim/Ladakh);* ***Miniature painting*** *(Himachal Pradesh);* ***Gond art*** *(Madhya Pradesh);* ***Tanjore paintings*** *(Tamil Nadu);* ***Kalamkari*** *(Andhra Pradesh);* ***Alpona art*** *(West Bengal);* ***Cheriyal painting*** *(Telangana);* ***Pichhwai Painting*** *(Rajasthan);* ***Lanjia Saura*** *(Odisha);* ***Pattachitra*** *(West Bengal);* ***Bani Thani Painting*** *(Rajasthan);* ***Warli*** *(Maharashtra);* ***Pithora Art*** *(Gujarat);* ***Aipan*** *(Uttarakhand);* ***Kerala Murals*** *(Kerala);* ***Alpana art*** *(Tripura) and more.*

1. Phad paintings (Rajasthan):

- Phad painting is a traditional Rajasthani scroll painting style that dates back over 700 years.
- **The Bhopas, the priest-singers traditionally** carry the painted phads along with them and use these as the mobile temples of the folk deities, who are worshipped by the Rebari community of the region.
- These paintings are created on long pieces of cloth, known as Phad, and depict epic narratives of local deities like Pabuji and Devnarayan.
- They use vibrant colors made from natural sources and are often accompanied by performances of the epic stories by local bards.

2. Thangka painting (Sikkim/Ladakh):

- Thangka paintings are traditional Tibetan Buddhist paintings on cotton or silk, originating from the Himalayan regions, particularly Sikkim and Ladakh. These paintings depict Buddhist deities, mandalas, and spiritual scenes. They are highly detailed and use vibrant mineral and vegetable pigments.

3. Miniature painting (Himachal Pradesh):

- Miniature paintings in Himachal Pradesh, particularly the Pahari style, date back to the 17th century and were influenced by the Mughal school of painting.
- Characterized by their small size and intricate details, these paintings often depict themes from Indian epics, court scenes, and nature. They use natural colours and are known for their delicate brushwork.

4. Gond art (Madhya Pradesh):

- Gond art is a tribal art form of the Gond community in Madhya Pradesh. This art uses dots and lines to create images of animals, plants, and everyday life. The colors are vibrant and often derived from natural sources.
- Gond art is a representation of the Gonds' belief in nature and their reverence for the environment.

5. Tanjore paintings (Tamil Nadu):

- **Tanjore (or Thanjavur) paintings originated in Tamil Nadu during** the **reign of the Nayakas in the 16th century.**
- Known for their rich colours, surface richness, and compact composition, these paintings depict Hindu gods and goddesses. They are characterized by the use of gold foil, making them shine and glitter.

6. Kalamkari (Andhra Pradesh):

- Kalamkari is a type of hand-painted or block-printed cotton textile from Andhra Pradesh, with origins tracing back to the 17th century.
- **This art uses a bamboo pen (kalam) and natural dyes to create intricate designs. There are two styles: Srikalahasti (freehand drawing) and Machilipatnam (block printing).**
- Kalamkari art often depicts stories from Hindu mythology, especially scenes from the Mahabharata and Ramayana.

7. Alpona art (West Bengal):

- Alpona is a traditional Bengali folk-art form used for decorating floors during festivals and auspicious occasions.
- It involves drawing intricate patterns using a paste made of rice flour. The designs are often floral or geometric and are created freehand.

8. Cheriyal painting (Telangana):

- **Cheriyal paintings are a form of Nakashi art from the Cheriyal village in Telangana, with roots in the Kakatiya dynasty (12th century).**

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- These are scroll paintings depicting scenes from Indian mythology and folklore. The paintings are characterized by their bright colors and use of natural pigments.
- These scrolls are used by storytellers to narrate tales, keeping alive the oral traditions of the region.

9. Pichhwai painting (Rajasthan):

- **Pichhwai paintings originated in Nathdwara, Rajasthan, in the 17th century.**
- These large-scale paintings are created on cloth and depict Lord Krishna, especially in the form of Shrinathji. They are detailed and often feature gold leaf.

10. Lanjia Saura art (Odisha):

- **Lanjia Saura art is a tribal art form from the Saura tribe of Odisha.**
- This art is characterized by its use of geometrical patterns to depict everyday life, mythology, and nature. It is similar to Warli art but distinct in its themes and execution.

11. Pattachitra (West Bengal):

- Pattachitra is a traditional cloth-based scroll painting from West Bengal, with origins in the ancient villages of the region.
- The paintings are characterized by intricate details, mythological narratives, and the use of natural colors. They often depict stories from the Ramayana, Mahabharata, and local folklore.
- **Pattachitra is closely associated with the Jagannath cult and is used in religious rituals and festivals.**

12. Bani Thani painting (Rajasthan):

- **Bani Thani is a style of painting that emerged in Kishangarh, Rajasthan, in the 18th century.**
- The style is characterized by stylized features like arched eyebrows, lotus-like elongated eyes, and pointed chin. It depicts Radha in a romanticized and idealized form, inspired by the poetess Bani Thani.

13. Warli art (Maharashtra):

- Warli art is a tribal art form practiced by the Warli tribe in Maharashtra, with origins dating back to 2500–3000 BCE.
- This art uses simple geometric shapes—circles, triangles, and squares—to depict scenes of hunting, farming, festivals, and dances. The paintings are traditionally created on mud walls using white rice paste.
- Warli art is deeply connected to nature and tribal life, and it serves as a visual record of the community's social life and rituals.

14. Pithora art (Gujarat)

- Pithora art is a ritualistic tribal painting from **the Rathwa and Bhil tribes of Gujarat.**
- The paintings are done on the walls of houses using natural colors and depict scenes of everyday life, animals, and gods. They are usually created as offerings to deities.
- Pithora paintings are **integral to the Rathwa culture** and are created during important religious and social events.

15. Aipan (Uttarakhand):

- Aipan is a traditional art form of Uttarakhand, primarily created by women.
- It involves creating intricate patterns using rice paste on a red background, typically on floors and walls during festivals and ceremonies.

16. Kerala murals (Kerala):

- Kerala murals are traditional frescoes that date back to the 9th century, found in temples and palaces across Kerala.
- These murals are known for their elaborate and vibrant depiction of Hindu mythology, using natural pigments on wet plaster.
- Kerala murals are a significant part of the state's cultural heritage and reflect its religious and artistic traditions.

17. Alpana art (Tripura):

- Alpana, similar to the Bengali Alpona, is a form of folk art practiced in Tripura.

- It involves creating floral, geometric, and symbolic patterns on the floor using a paste made from rice flour.

13. KALAMEZHUTHU OR KALAM PATTU ART

A Kalamezhutu workshop was recently organised by Malayalam Department in Kochi, Kerala.

KALAMEZHUTHU

- Kalamezhuthu is a distinctive traditional art form from Kerala that seamlessly integrates **painting, music, and performance.**
- While it bears some resemblance to Rangoli from North India, Kalamezhuthu stands apart due to its direct application in religious ceremonies, reflecting its deep spiritual and cultural significance.
- **Floor Art:** Kalamezhuthu is a floor painting art form prevalent. **The artists use floors of temple or noble households as their canvas.**
- **History:**
  - The origins of Kalamezhuthu are not precisely documented, but it is believed to have emerged from **ancient Tamilakam, a region encompassing parts of present-day Kerala and Tamil Nadu.**
  - Historical sources suggest that it may date back to the *9th century AD during the Chola dynasty in Tamil Nadu,* although *some propose an even older origin from the Sangam period (3rd century BC to 3rd century AD).*
  - Traditionally, this art form was performed by the **Ambalavasis, a community of temple priests and artists responsible for various temple rituals in Kerala.**
- **Process and techniques**
  - **Preparation**: The artist prepares the floor with a mixture of cow dung and rice powder to create a smooth and even base.
  - **Sketching**: An outline of the image is sketched using charcoal or chalk.
  - **Color application**: Natural pigments are mixed with water to achieve a paste-like consistency and applied using brushes made of bamboo or coconut fibre. The colours, which represent the pancha bhootha (five elements), are:
    - **Yellow**: Turmeric powder (Earth)
    - **White**: Rice powder (Water)
    - **Red**: Powdered turmeric, lime, and rice powder (Fire)
    - **Green**: Dried and powdered leaves (Air)
    - **Black**: Roasted and powdered paddy husk (Space)
- **Regional variations:**
  - **Northern Kerala**: Known as 'Kalam Pattu'
  - **Southern Kerala**: Referred to as 'Kalamezhuthu Pattu'
  - **Thrissur**: Called 'Dhumakkali'
  - **Tamil Nadu**: Known as 'Kalam Karuppai'
- The regional variations are evident in the content, execution, scale, duration, and purpose of the performances. **In southern Kerala, for instance, Kalamezhuthu might be performed as part of the Mudiyettu ritual.**

14. CORRIDOR PROJECTS ANNOUNCED FOR BIHAR'S VISHNUPAD AND MAHABODHI TEMPLES

*The **Vishnupad Temple in Gaya and the Mahabodhi Temple in Bodh Gaya** are significant cultural and spiritual landmarks in the region of Bihar. During Union Budget (2024) speech, Finance Minister announced plans to develop corridor projects for both temples, inspired by the successful Kashi Vishwanath Temple Corridor. These projects aim to transform the temples into world-class pilgrim and tourist destinations, enhancing their accessibility and appeal.*

ABOUT MAHABODHI TEMPLE

- The **Mahabodhi temple complex**, is a renowned site marking the sacred location where **Gautam Buddha is believed to have attained enlightenment (nirvana)**.
- Positioned to the east of the Mahabodhi Tree, a direct descendant of the original Bodhi Tree under which the Buddha meditated, the temple has served as a major pilgrimage site for Buddhists for over two thousand years.
- **UNESCO's listing of the Mahabodhi Temple Complex highlights its origins as the first temple constructed by Emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century B.C.**

THE LEGEND OF SIDDHARTHA GAUTAMA'S ENLIGHTENMENT

- According to traditional accounts, around **589 BCE**, Siddhartha Gautama, the future Buddha, meditated under a peepul tree near the banks of the Phalgu River, near the city of Gaya.
- After three days and nights of meditation, he attained enlightenment, leading to the construction of the Mahabodhi Temple by Emperor Ashoka around **260 BCE**.
- The temple complex encompasses several locations associated with the seven weeks that Gautama Buddha spent meditating following his enlightenment:
  - **First Week**: Under the Bodhi tree.
  - **Second Week**: The Buddha stood gazing uninterrupted at the Bodhi tree. This site is now marked by the **Animeshlocha Stupa**, northeast of the temple.
  - **Third Week**: The Buddha walked back and forth between the **Animeshlocha Stupa** and the Bodhi tree, with lotus flowers believed to have sprung up along this path, known as **Ratnachakrama (Jewel Walk)**.
  - **Fourth Week**: Spent near the **Ratnagar Chaitya**.
  - **Sixth Week**: Near the **Lotus Pond**.
  - **Seventh Week**: Under the **Rajyatna Tree**.

THE BODHI TREE AND MYTHOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE

- The **Bodhi Tree** at Bodh Gaya is considered a direct descendant of the original tree under which Siddhartha Gautama attained enlightenment.
- According to the Jatakas, this spot is the navel of the earth and will remain the last to disappear and the first to reappear when the world is destroyed and recreated at the end of a kalpa (a cosmic cycle).

The legend of Mucalinda:

- **The temple complex also features Mucalinda Lake, associated with the legend of Mucalinda,** the serpent king.
- According to tradition, six weeks after the Buddha's enlightenment, a severe storm struck, and Mucalinda emerged from beneath the earth to shield the Buddha with his hood.
- This theme of the **Buddha being protected by Mucalinda is prevalent in the iconography of Gautama Buddha in Laos and Thailand.**

THE MAHABODHI TEMPLE AND SURROUNDING COMPLEX

- The Mahabodhi Temple is notable for its **distinctive shikhara towers-a stylistic feature that continues in Jain and Hindu temples to the present day and has influenced Buddhist architecture** in other countries, such as the pagoda form.
- The main temple has undergone several restorations since the 19th century, yet it incorporates large parts of earlier work, possibly dating back to the 2nd or 3rd century CE.
- Archaeological findings at the site suggest that it has been a place of Buddhist veneration since at least the Mauryan period, as evidenced by the **Vajrasana (Diamond Throne)**, which dates to the 3rd century BCE.

THE MAHABODHI TEMPLE'S CONSTRUCTION SPANS MULTIPLE PERIODS

- **Mauryan period**: Emperor Ashoka established the original temple structure and the **Vajrasana (Diamond Throne)** at the foot of the Bodhi Tree. Representations of this early structure are found in art from Sanchi and Bharhut.
- **Sunga Period**: Additional structures were added, including columns with pot-shaped bases dating to the **1st century BCE**. These columns closely match descriptions found on reliefs from this period.
- **Sunga and Gupta Railings**: The temple's railings, dating to around **150 BCE** during the Sunga period, include carved sandstone posts and medallions featuring various scenes. Some of these elements have been replaced by replicas, with the originals housed in the Indian Museum in Kolkata.

THE CURRENT PYRAMIDAL TEMPLE STRUCTURE

- **The existing structure primarily dates back to the Gupta period (5th–6th century CE).** This architectural style is consistent with that of Hindu temples being constructed during the same era in India.
- However, archaeological evidence, **such as an inscription from Kumrahar dating back to 150–200 CE,** suggests that the Mahabodhi Temple's pyramidal design might be a restoration of an earlier construction from the 2nd or 3rd century CE. **This is supported by finds of Huvishka coins and Kharoshthi inscriptions.**
- The temple's **design reflects influences from the stepped stupas of Gandhara,** featuring a series of ascending levels with niches containing Buddha images, interspersed with Greco-Roman pillars, and crowned by a hemispherical stupa.
- *This form marks a significant evolution from the earlier an-iconic stupas, dedicated to relics, to an iconic temple adorned with multiple images of the Buddha and Bodhisattvas.*
- The 'shikhara' tower with an 'amalaka' near the top, characteristic of later Hindu temples, can be seen as a continuation of this architectural legacy.
- The Mahabodhi Temple's current appearance is also the result of multiple restorations, including those by the British in the 19th century and further efforts by the Indian government post-independence.

ABOUT VISHNUPAD TEMPLE

- The Vishnupad Temple, dedicated to **Lord Vishnu, is** located **on the banks of the Phalgu River.**
- The temple, believed to have been built on the site where **Lord Vishnu** defeated the demon Gayasura, features a **40-centimeter footprint carved into a block of basalt, known as Dharmasila.**
- Pilgrims from across India visit the temple, particularly during the Pitra Paksha period, a time in the Hindu calendar when rituals are performed to honour and remember one's ancestors.
- Several legendary saints, **including Madhvacharya, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, and Vallabhacharya,** are said to have visited this shrine, further emphasizing its importance in Hindu spiritual traditions.

ARCHITECTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

- The construction of the Vishnupad Temple as it stands today dates back to **1787 when it was rebuilt by Queen Ahilyabai Holkar of Indore.**
- The temple, approximately 100 feet tall, is built of large **grey granite blocks joined with iron clamps.**
- It features an octagonal shrine that faces east, with a pyramidal tower that rises in tiers to a height of 30 meters.
- This tower's design incorporates sloping sides with alternating plain and indented sections, creating a series of peaks that meet at the top.
- The interior of the temple houses a pavilion supported by eight rows of intricately carved pillars.
- **A silver-coated hexagon railing, known as the 'pahal,' surrounds the sacred footprint of Lord Vishnu.**
- The **temple complex also includes the Akshayavat,** an immortal banyan tree where final rites for the dead are performed.

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15. PORT BLAIR RENAMED AS SRI VIJAYA PURAM

Port Blair has been renamed 'Sri Vijaya Puram' *by the Government of India in an effort to move beyond its colonial legacy. The new name pays tribute to the region's historical ties with the Srivijaya Empire. This renaming also symbolizes the triumph of India's freedom struggle, recognizing the unique and vital role the Andaman and Nicobar Islands played in that historic fight for independence.*

INTRODUCTION

- Port Blair, the gateway to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, **was named after Archibald Blair, a naval surveyor and lieutenant in the Bombay Marine.**
- **Blair was the first to conduct a detailed survey of the Andaman Islands,** a crucial factor in the city's establishment.

Archibald Blair's early career and survey missions:

- Blair began his service in the Bombay Marine in 1771, embarking on numerous survey missions across the coasts of India, Iran, and Arabia.
- His work extended into various regions, **including the Chagos Archipelago, Diamond Harbour near Calcutta, and along the Hooghly River.**
- These early missions earned him a reputation as a skilled surveyor, leading to his involvement in a mission to the Andaman Islands.

The Survey of the Andaman Islands and naming of Port Cornwallis:

- In December **1778, Blair departed from Calcutta with two ships, the *Elizabeth* and the *Viper*, to explore the Andaman Islands.**
- His expedition, lasting until April 1779, navigated the west coast and subsequently the east coast of the islands.
- During this survey, Blair discovered a **natural harbour, which he initially named Port Cornwallis, after William Cornwallis, then Commander-in-Chief of the British Indian Army.**
- Later the island was renamed after him.
- Recognizing the strategic importance of this harbour, Blair reported his **findings to the East India Company (EIC), who were impressed by the potential of the location.**
- **Colonization of the Andaman Islands:**
  - Following Blair's discovery, the EIC decided to **colonize the islands to establish a safe harbour to monitor and counter Malay pirate activities.**
  - Port Cornwallis would also serve as a refuge for shipwrecked sailors and as a shelter for British officers during hostilities with other powers.
  - As part of the colonization process, **several convicts were transported to the islands to perform unpaid labor, and the region became a penal colony.**
- **Decline of the first colony:**
  - In December 1792, for strategic reasons, the colony was shifted to the northeast part of the Andaman Islands, **and the new settlement was named Port Cornwallis.**
  - However, this new colony did not last long, as the settlers faced severe disease outbreaks, resulting in numerous deaths.
  - **By 1796, the East India Company ceased operations on the island due to the unsustainable living conditions.**

Port Blair and the revival of penal colony post-1857 revolt:

- The Revolt of 1857 changed the course of Port Blair's history.
- The British, now burdened with a large number of Indian prisoners, **decided to renovate and resettle Port Blair as a penal colony.**
- Many of these prisoners were given life sentences, with some being hanged, and others succumbing to disease and the harsh conditions of the settlement.

- With the rise of the Indian Independence Movement, the British constructed **a vast cellular jail in 1906, now infamously known as Kaala Paani.**
- This jail housed numerous Indian freedom fighters, including **Veer Damodar Savarkar, becoming a symbol of British colonial oppression.**

CONNECTION WITH THE IMPERIAL CHOLAS AND SRIVIJAYA

- During the 11th century, the powerful **Chola emperor, Rajendra I,** used the Andaman Islands as a naval base to launch a significant military campaign against the **Srivijaya Empire (southern Sumatra), located in present-day Indonesia.**
- **Strategic importance:**
  - According to inscriptions found at Thanjavur dated to 1050 CE, the Cholas referred to the **Andaman Islands as Ma-Nakkavaram (great open or naked land),** which is believed to have contributed to the modern name of Nicobar under British rule.
  - The islands' geographic location made them an ideal staging ground for naval expeditions aimed at Southeast Asia.
  - His attack on Srivijaya was a remarkable event, reflecting the Chola Empire's strength and its influence in the region.
- **Invasion of Srivijaya:**
  - The Chola invasion of Srivijaya was unique in India's otherwise peaceful interactions with Southeast Asia.
  - For nearly a millennium, Southeast Asian states had come under the strong cultural influence of India, but this military campaign marked a rare instance of direct conflict.
  - **Reasons for invasion:**
    - The **Srivijaya Empire may have attempted to disrupt Chola trade routes** with the East, which prompted Rajendra I's military response.
    - It is also believed that Rajendra I sought to extend his **digvijaya (conquest of all directions) to Southeast Asia, thereby enhancing his imperial glory.**
    - The attack on Srivijaya was also part of the **Chola's broader expansionist ambitions,** which also included conflicts with other South Indian empires and Sri Lanka.
- **Outcome:**
  - Rajendra I's naval campaign against Srivijaya resulted in significant victories.
  - According to inscriptional records, **he captured Srivijaya's king, Sangrama Vijayottunggavarman,** and seized valuable treasures from the Buddhist empire, including the **Vidhyadara Torana, a jewelled war gate of Srivijaya.**
  - The control over the Srivijaya Empire in Southeast Asia gave access to a major commercial hub.
  - The conquest gave the Cholas control over important maritime trade routes.
  - This victory not only marked the height of Chola naval power but also demonstrated the empire's capacity to influence events far beyond the Indian subcontinent.

The Andaman and Nicobar Islands, through their association with Rajendra I's naval expeditions, gained a significant role in India's maritime strategy and historical narratives.

16. PULIKALI DANCE

Artists in Thrissur, Kerala, performed Pulikali, the traditional tiger dance, marking the grand conclusion of the Onam festivities.

ABOUT THE DANCE FORM

INTRODUCTION:



- Pulikali, a vibrant recreational folk art from **Kerala,** is an integral part of the state's cultural heritage.
- This captivating performance is held annually **during the Onam festival, which is Kerala's largest and most significant harvest celebration.**
- On the **fourth day of Onam, also known as Naalaam Onam or Chathayam,** trained artists perform Pulikali to entertain the masses.
- The performance is marked by artists painted as tigers and leopards, dancing to the rhythmic beats of traditional instruments such as the **Chenda, Chengila, Udukku, and Thakil.**
- **Usually, men and children perform this art form.** For the first time, 3 women among a 51-member team participated in the Pulikali at Thrissur in 2016.
- The theme of the dance revolves around tiger hunting, which is symbolized by the performers' costumes and movements.

SIGNIFICANCE OF PULIKALI IN THRISSUR:

- Pulikali is predominantly performed in **Kerala's Thrissur district, where it enjoys a 200-year-old tradition.**
- This region is considered the heart of the art form, with thousands of people gathering each year to witness the spectacle.
- Although Pulikali is also performed in other regions, such as the outskirts of Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam, **the Thrissur Pulikali** remains the most popular and classical of all variations.

HISTORY:

- Pulikali traces its origins back to the **reign of Maharaja Rama Varma Sakthan Thampuran, the ruler of Cochin over 200 years ago.**
- The Maharaja introduced Pulikali as a form of entertainment for the local populace, where dancers would put on tiger costumes and mimic the movements of a tiger in a performance **called 'Pulikkettikali.'**
- Over time, the event gained popularity and became a central feature of Thrissur's Onam celebrations, held in memory of this historic tradition.

PERFORMANCE:

- **It is also known as Kaduvakali in some regions and the dancers are called Pulikalikkar.**
- The elaborate body paint, in shades of yellow, red, and black, plays a crucial role in the performance.
- **The stripes, ranging from simple 'patta vara' to intricate 'zebra vara' designs,** are applied with great care to achieve the authentic look of a tiger.
- The tune used for Pulikkali Onam dance has a unique rhythm and is popularly known as *pulimelam*.
- The special rhythm, composed by **Thottungal Ramankutty Asan 70 years ago, is unique to Thrissur's Pulikali.**
- Each Pulikkali team comprises 50 dancers.

RITUALS AND PREPARATION:

- The preparation for Pulikali is not just physical but also spiritual.
- **Performers observe a 41-day fasting period starting from the first day of the Malayalam month Karkidakam.**

- During this period, they purify their bodies and prepare mentally for the dance. The ritual of getting into costume begins the night before the event.

While Pulikali remains a significant part of Onam celebrations, it is also performed during other festive occasions in Kerala. Today, Pulikali is not only a folk art but also a major cultural spectacle that draws thousands to Thrissur, preserving its legacy for future generations.

17. CLASSICAL LANGUAGE STATUS TO FIVE MORE LANGUAGES

The Union Cabinet approved classical language status to ***Marathi, Bengali, Assamese, Pali, and Prakrit.***

INTRODUCTION

- India has had **six classical languages till now**: *Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada, Sanskrit, and Odia.*
- **Tamil was the first language** to be given classical status in **2004 followed by Sanskrit in 2005**.
- With the new additions, **11 languages in India have Classical Language status**.

CLASSICAL LANGUAGE STATUS

- The term **'Indian classical languages,' or Shastriya Bhasha**, encompasses languages in India with a rich history, significant antiquity, and a distinct literary heritage.
- **In October 2004, the Centre** decided to create a new category of languages as 'Classical Languages.'
- **In November 2004, a Linguistic Experts Committee (LEC) was constituted by the Ministry of Culture under the Sahitya Akademi** to examine the eligibility of the languages proposed to be accorded classical language status.
  - **The Linguistics Expert Committee** comprises of representatives of the **Union Ministries of Home, Culture, and four or five linguistic experts** at any given time.
  - It is chaired by the **President of the Sahitya Akademi.**
- The criteria for conferring the status of a 'Classical Language,' was brought which was **implemented by the Ministry of Culture in collaboration with the Linguistic Experts' Committee.** This committee, formed by the government, **evaluates** requests for classifying languages as Classical Languages.
- **According to the Union Culture Ministry,** the criteria for bestowing classical status was **revised by the Linguistics Experts Committee**, in July, 2024.
- 9 classical languages are listed in **the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.**
  - The Eighth Schedule consists 22 languages.
  - These are: ***(1) Assamese, (2) Bengali,*** *(3) Gujarati, (4) Hindi,* ***(5) Kannada****, (6) Kashmiri, (7) Konkani,* ***(8) Malayalam****, (9) Manipuri,* ***(10) Marathi****, (11) Nepali, (12)* ***Oriya****, (13) Punjabi,* ***(14) Sanskrit****, (15) Sindhi,* ***(16) Tamil****,* ***(17) Telugu****, (18) Urdu (19) Bodo, (20) Santhali, (21) Maithili and (22) Dogri.*

TO BE RECOGNIZED AS A 'CLASSICAL LANGUAGE,' A LANGUAGE MUST SATISFY THE FOLLOWING CRITERIA

CRITERIA (NOVEMBER, 2005)

- Demonstrated high antiquity of its early texts or a recorded history **spanning 1500–2000 years.**
- Possession of a body of **ancient literature or texts** considered valuable heritage by successive generations of speakers.
- Originality of the literary tradition, **not borrowed from another speech community**.
- Distinctiveness between the classical language and literature from its modern counterparts, **potentially involving a discontinuity.**

REVISED CRITERIA (JULY, 2024):

- High antiquity of (its) is early texts/recorded history over **a period of 1500- 2000 years.**

- A body of ancient literature/texts, which is considered a heritage by generations of speakers
- ***Knowledge texts, especially prose texts in addition to poetry, epigraphical and inscriptional evidence.***
- The Classical Languages and literature could be distinct from its current form or could be discontinuous with later forms of its offshoots.

LANGUAGES GRANTED CLASSICAL LANGUAGE STATUS

- **Tamil:** Recognized as a classical language in 2004
- **Sanskrit:** Officially recognized as a classical language on January 26, 2005
- **Telugu:** Achieved official recognition as a classical language in India in 2008
- **Kannada:** Officially recognized as a classical language in India in 2008
- **Malayalam:** Recognized as a classical language in 2013
- **Odia:** Officially recognized as a classical language on February 20, 2014
- **Marathi; Assamese; Bengali; Pali and Prakrit:** 2024

BENEFITS OF CLASSICAL STATUS

- The Ministry of Education takes steps to promote classical languages.
- Three central universities were established in **2020 through an Act of Parliament for promotion of Sanskrit language.**
- The **Central Institute of Classical Tamil** was set up to facilitate the translation of ancient Tamil texts, and offer courses in Tamil.
- To enhance the study and preservation of classical languages, the **Centres for Excellence** for studies in **Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, and Odia were also set up.**
- **Two major international awards annually** for distinguished scholars in Classical Indian Languages.

Requesting the **University Grants Commission** to initiate, initially in Central Universities, a designated number of **Professional Chairs for Classical Languages** for eminent scholars in Classical Indian Languages.

18. 'FEMALE DHAKIS' AT THE DURGA PUJA TRADITIONS

Traditionally, playing the dhak (a large drum integral to the celebration of Durga Puja in Eastern India) was an exclusively male activity. However, in recent years, women have begun breaking this gender norm by taking up the dhak as a profession and asserting their place in this art form. This shift is particularly significant because the beats of the dhak are central to Durga Puja, a festival that venerates a female goddess, yet, paradoxically, women were long excluded from playing this vital instrument.

SETTING NEW PRECEDENTS IN THE DURGA PUJA CELEBRATIONS



- Playing Dhakis at Durga Pujas has been predominantly a male art form because it is said that the 'dhaks' are too heavy for women. This art form has been **passed on from generation to generation through male heirs only.**
- Mohila Dhaki Babadhamraj Sampradaya, a **troupe of 10 female dhakis** from Bardhaman district, North Bengal are fighting all social taboos to pursue their dreams.

ABOUT DHAKIS

- Dhakis are one of the **cultural groups** of Bengal. They are **traditional drummers,** mainly men who play the instrument, mostly during Durga Puja.
  - They are involved in other professions throughout the year but for five days they represent the traditional folk culture of Bengal.
  - They mainly belong to Bardhaman Murshidabad and Birbhum district of West Bengal.



- Dhakis carry **dhaks decorated with feathers** and play a different tune and beat of the dhak for every ceremony, from the arrival of the Goddess to her immersion on Dussehra or Vijay Dashami.
- **They perform a variety of musical patterns during Durga Puja, according to the rituals.**
  - There are different beats for the Sandhya Aarti (evening prayer), Chakshudaan (drawing eyes of the idol), Devi Baron (applying vermillion to the deity's feet and face) and Bhasan (immersion of the idol).
  - The Bol or beats are set to different taal (musical measures).
  - It is played for devotees performing dhunuchi nritya, an intense and fast dance to appease the goddess.

ABOUT DHAK

- The dhak is a huge membranophone instrument (drum) from Bengal and Assam.
  - A membranophone is any musical instrument which produces sound primarily by way of a vibrating stretched membrane.



- The shapes differ from the almost cylindrical to the barrel.
- It is suspended from the neck, tied to the waist and kept on the lap or the ground, and usually played with wooden sticks.
- It is mainly used in Hindu religious festivals, especially of Sakta and Shaiva traditions, including Durga Puja, Kali Puja and Charak Puja.
- It is also played in Islamic festivals like Muharram in Bengal.

HISTORY OF DHAK

- According to scholars, Dhak dates back **roughly 3,000 years.**
- The instrument is recorded in the **chronicles of Fa Hien**, who visited India in the fifth century (375 - 417 AD).
- King Dharmapala II of the Pala dynasty constructed the renowned Buddhist Vihara at Paharpur (modern-day Bangladesh) in the 8th century AD, which emerged as a significant centre of Buddhist learning.
  - The terracotta figures at this site depict scenes of people dancing and playing traditional instruments such as the dhak, kansar, cymbals, and veena.
- The **Shunya Purana** written in the 13th century mentions 42 different musical instruments including dhak, dhol, kara, jaydhak and mridanga among others.
- Dhak was used in earlier times for music, dance, warding off wild creatures, announcing the time, sounding warnings, in addition to being employed in sacrificial rites.

ABOUT DHUNUCHI NAACH

- Dhunuchi Dance is associated with **Durga Worship in West Bengal** and other parts of **Eastern India.**



- The devotee who performs it is known as Dhanucchi, who balances the earthen bowl containing burning incense either with his/ her hands or on his/ her forehead or in his/her mouth.
- It is called Dhunuchi because it is performed with Dhunachi, which is a native Indian incense burner used during Aarti.
  - Dhunachi is traditionally made of earthenware so that heat is insulated from the handle and it can be held in arms for long duration without any discomfort.
- Dhunuchi dance is performed with **two Dhunachi in hands** (with single Dhunachi in each hand) along with the fast beats of Dhak.

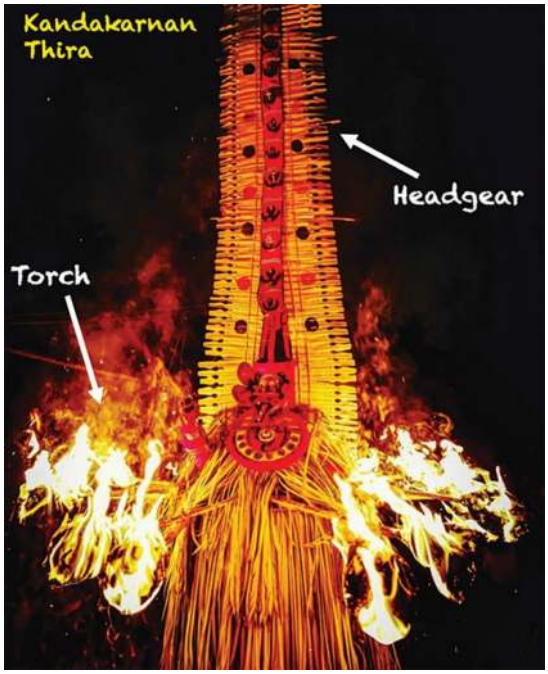
- It is performed by **both men and women.**

19. KANDAKARNAN THIRA ART FORM

*Recently, hundreds gathered at the Krishna Menon Museum and Art Gallery in Kozhikode, Kerala to witness the **Kandakarnan Thira performance.***

ABOUT KANDAKARNAN THIRA

- It is a ritual dance and a part of the **Theyyam art form** which is primarily performed in the temples and groves in the **Malabar region of Kerala.**
  - Theyyam (the dance of God) is a **broad ritual dance form and living tradition** practiced in Malabar region of Kerala. It involves worshipping deities through dance, drama, music, art and rituals.
- Kandakarnan Thira is a unique form of Thira **dedicated to Kandakarnan**, a fierce guardian deity, who is believed to **protect humanity from diseases.**



WHO PERFORMS?

The dance is performed by artists from the Malaya community, who are also known as **"perumalayan".**

WHAT DOES IT SYMBOLISE?

- The Kandakarnan Thira performance represents the **survival of the human race from contagious diseases**.
- The performer wears a headgear (crown) that is about 20 feet tall and has 16 torches attached to their hips. The performer's face also has marks left behind by smallpox.

WHAT ARE THE RITUALS?

The performance is often accompanied by musicians and takes place at night. The ritual involves invoking deities, walking on red-hot embers, and performing in sacred shrines and ancestral temples.

20. GOVERNMENT SEEKS TO RELAUNCH NATIONAL MANUSCRIPT MISSION

*The Union Ministry of Culture is set to "revive and relaunch" the **National Mission for Manuscripts** (NMM) and is mulling the formation of an autonomous body to help preserve ancient texts in India. Presently, NMM is a part of the Indira Gandhi National Centre for Arts. The new body, likely to be named the **National Manuscripts Authority,** will be an autonomous entity under the Ministry.*

ABOUT NATIONAL MISSION FOR MANUSCRIPTS

- Established in February 2003 by the Ministry of Tourism and Culture.
- It is part of the Indira Gandhi National Centre for Arts.
- **Objective:** To unearth and preserve the vast manuscript wealth of India.
- The **mission has the mandate** of identifying, documenting, conserving and making accessible the manuscript heritage of India.
  - It will document each and every manuscript and manuscript repository, for a **National Electronic Database** that currently contains information on four million manuscripts making this the largest database on Indian manuscripts in the world.

- **Need:** India has a huge wealth of knowledge on all subjects in these manuscripts as yet undiscovered. Many individuals have a vast number of manuscripts lying in personal custody. India has more than ten million manuscripts that need preservation.

WHAT IS MANUSCRIPT?

- A manuscript is a **handwritten composition** on paper, bark, cloth, metal, palm leaf, or any other material dating back at least seventy-five years that has significant scientific, historical, or aesthetic value.
- Manuscripts are different from historical records such as epigraphs on rocks, and revenue records, which provide direct information on events or processes in history.

21. INDIRA GANDHI PEACE PRIZE 2023

*Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament, and Development was given to **Daniel Barenboim** for his contribution to fostering peace through musical and cultural dialogue initiatives and to **Ali Abu Awwad** for his advocacy for dialogue through his organisation Roots. The award was announced in 2023.*

ABOUT INDIRA GANDHI PEACE PRIZE

- **The Prize was established in 1986.**
- It is awarded by the **Indira Gandhi Memorial Trust.**
- **It includes a cash award of Rs 25 lakh and a citation.**
- The Prize is **awarded annually** to **a person or organization without any distinction of nationality, race or religion**, in recognition of creative efforts towards:
  - Promoting international peace and disarmament, racial equality, and goodwill and harmony among nations.
  - Securing economic co-operation and promoting a new international economic order.
  - Accelerating the all-round advancement of developing nations.
  - Ensuring that the discoveries of science and modern knowledge are used for the larger good of the human race.
  - Enlarging the scope of freedom and enriching the human spirit.

22. MAHA KUMBHA MELA

*The **Maha Kumbh Mela 2025** was held between 13 January to 26 February, 2025 at Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh.*

ABOUT KUMBH, ARDHKUMBHA AND MAHAKUMBH

- **Kumbh Mela** is a major pilgrimage and festival in Hinduism or Sanatana tradition. It is a **religious pilgrimage** that is celebrated **four times**, over a **course of 12 years**, at **four river-bank pilgrimage sites**:
  i. Prayagraj (Ganges-Yamuna-Sarasvati rivers confluence)
  ii. Haridwar (Ganges)
  iii. Nashik (Godavari)
  iv. Ujjain (Shipra). All the pilgrims take a holy dip in the river water.
- **Kumba** is held at Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain and Nasik every three years.
- **Ardhkumbha** is held at Prayagraj and Haridwar every 6 years.
- **Mahakumbha** is the event that takes place **after every 144 years,** following 12 Purna Kumbh Melas.

KEY FACTS ABOUT KUMBHA MELA

- Kumbh Mela has been included in the **UNESCO's Representative list of Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity (2017).** The event intrinsically encapsulates the **science of astronomy, astrology, spirituality, ritualistic traditions, and socio-cultural customs and practices**, making it extremely rich in knowledge.

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- Each site's celebration is based on a **distinct set of astrological positions** of the **Sun, the Moon, and Jupiter**. The celebrations occur at the exact moment when these positions are fully occupied, as it is considered to be the holiest time in Hinduism.
- This congregation, primarily, includes Ascetics, Saints, Sadhus, Sadhvis, Kalpvasis and Pilgrims from all walks of life. The seekers believe that bathing in these rivers is a means to **prāyaścitta** (atonement, penance, restorative action) for past mistakes, and that it cleanses them of their sins.

ORIGIN OF CONCEPT

1. Ancient India:

- **Puranas** are the oldest source of *Magha mela* (probably the older name of Kumbh mela). According to these texts, the gods and demons once engaged in a cosmic battle over a **kumbha (pot)** containing Amrita, the elixir of immortality. This struggle was part of their joint endeavour to churn the milky ocean. During this celestial tug-of-war, drops of amrita fell on **four earthly locations: Haridwar, Ujjain, Nashik, and Prayag** (now Prayagraj). These sites, sanctified by the divine nectar, later became the venues for the Kumbh Mela.
- **Other references:** However, the earliest mention of holy bath at Prayag is mentioned in Sanskrit text **Rigveda** and Pali text **Majjhima Nikaya.**
- **7th century Buddhist monk Hiuen Tsang**, who travelled during the period of King Harsha, mentioned about people gathering to take dip in hold rivers.

2. **Medieval India:**

- It was **Adi Shankara** in the 8th century who formalised the Kumbha Mela. He intended to establish major gatherings for philosophical discourse and debates among the Hindu monastic community. These gatherings were aimed at consolidating and strengthening the philosophical foundations of Hinduism, fostering a sense of unity and shared purpose among its practitioners.

23. NATIONAL MARITIME HERITAGE COMPLEX

*The **National Maritime Heritage Complex** (NMHC), envisaged to be one of the largest maritime complexes in the world, is under construction near **Lothal** in Gujarat.*

ABOUT NATIONAL MARITIME HERITAGE COMPLEX

- National Maritime Heritage Complex (NMHC) is an under construction **tourism complex** near **Lothal**, **Gujarat.**
- Spread over 400 acres, the complex will present the **maritime history & heritage** of India covering 4500 years.
- **Developed by:** Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterway.
- **Project components of NMHC** include **NMHC museum**; Open Aquatic Gallery, Lighthouse Museum, Bagicha Complex, Coastal State Pavilions and Recreation of Lothal city, Eco resorts and Museuotel, Theme based parks, Maritime research institute etc.
- The Directorate General of Lighthouses and Lightships (DGLL) will construct the **World's tallest light house** in the complex.

VISION OF THIS COMPLEX

- Become a leading Global Tourist Destination.
- Preserve and showcase India's Maritime heritage.
- Become a centre for International Maritime Fairs and exhibition.
- Establish International Collaboration and exchange programs.
- Collaboration with Coastal states and UTs.
- To be established as a Maritime training and research centre.

ABOUT LOTHAL IVC SITE

Historical Significance:

- Lothal was an **ancient maritime port city** of the Indus Valley Civillisation, dating back 4500 years.

- **Location**: Ahmedabad district, Gujarat (80 km southwest of Ahmedabad).
- The name "Lothal" combines two Gujarati words, *Loth* and *Thal*, meaning "the mound of the dead."
- It flourished as a **thriving trading port** during 3700 BCE, linked to ancient trade routes from Sindh to Saurashtra.

ARCHAEOLOGICAL DISCOVERIES

- Excavations (1955–1960) by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) uncovered the world's **oldest known artificial dock**, connected to an ancient course of the Sabarmati River.
- Key features include:
  - **Acropolis** and **Lower Town**
  - **Bead Factory** and **Warehouses**
  - Advanced **Drainage System**
  - Unearthed **canals** and **dockyards** highlight its significance as a trading hub.

GLOBAL CONNECTIONS

- Artefacts suggest trade links with **Mesopotamia**, **Egypt**, and **Persia**.
- An entire township with markets and docks showcases the city's advanced urban planning.

ARTEFACTS AND MUSEUM

- The **Archaeological Museum** near the site displays:
  - Jewellery, pottery, seals, religious symbols.
  - Everyday objects that reflect the daily life and craftsmanship of the time.

UNESCO NOMINATION

The site has been proposed for inclusion as a UNESCO World Heritage Site, underlining its cultural and historical importance.

ARCHAEOLOGICAL LEGACY

- Lothal's excavation has contributed the **largest number of antiquities** in modern Indian archaeology.
- It is believed to have been part of a major river system, making it a key node in ancient trade and commerce.

24. PM TO RELEASE COLLECTED WORKS OF SUBRAMANIA BHARTI

The Prime Minister of India will release the compendium of complete works of great Tamil poet and freedom fighter C. Subramania Bharati (a prominent leader of the independent movement and a prolific writer and poet).

WHO IS SUBRAMANIA BHARTI?



- Born on the 11th of December 1882, S. Bharti was a Tamil author, poet, journalist, Indian independence activist, social reformer and polyglot. Subramania Bharati was given the title of "**Mahakavi Bharati".**
- **Early Career:**
  - He worked as a **journalist in Swadesamitran** (a Tamil daily) in 1904.
  - In 1906, he also started working for Tamil weekly **India** and the English newspaper **Bala Bharatham.**
- **Themes in his writing:**
  - Emancipation of women, standing against child marriage, reforming Brahminism and religion.
  - Idea of patriotism for India and the independence movement against the British Empire.

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- He participated in the **Indian Independence Movement**. On account of his arrest orders, he escaped to the French ruled Pondicherry. While there, Bharati edited and published the weekly Journal **India** and **Vijaya**, which the British banned to suppress his nationalist outputs.

LITERARY WORKS OF BHARTI

- Bharathi used **simple words and rhythms**, unlike the previous century works in Tamil, which had complex vocabulary. He also proposed novel ideas and techniques in his poems.
- **His noted works include** *Panjali Sabatham*, *Kannan Paatu*, *Kuyil Paatu*, *Paapa Paatu*, *Chinnanchriu Kiliye* and *Vinayagar Nanmanimalai*.
- He also translated **Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*** and ***Bhagavad Gita*** to Tamil.

25. NAANGIARKOOTHU

ABOUT NAANGIARKOOTHU

- Naangiarkoothu (or Nangiaramma Koothu) is a distinguished **Sanskrit dance-theatre form from Kerala,** with a rich heritage spanning at least 1500 years.
- This is a **solo dance drama** performed by female members (Nangiar) of the ***Chakkiar* community** (known for their mastery of *Koothu*)
- It is traditionally presented in the **temple theatre**, the **Koothambalam or Koothupura**.
- It is mainly centered on the **legends of Lord Krishna.** Verses are sung and interpreted through mime and dance.

- It is predominantly characterised by **Abhinaya**, the expressive aspect of dance, with minimal emphasis on nritta, or pure dance elements. It comprises two significant segments:
  - **Nirvahanam**, a retrospective solo act recounting past events.
  - **The play itself,** featuring dialogues and multiple characters.
- The mudras are even more elaborate. Movements, gestures and facial expressions have their origin in ***Natyasastra*** (the treatise on theatre, written by Sage *Bharatha* in the 2nd century BC).
- The performance is accompanied with **Mizhavu** (a percussion instrument) and **Ilathalam** (cymbals).
- It is still **performed in temples** like Vadakkunnatha temple at Thrissur, Sri Krishna temple at Amabalappuzha, Koodal Manickyam temple at Irinjalakkuda and Kumaranalloor temple at Kottyam.

26. MEHRAULI ARCHAEOLOGICAL PARK

*The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has told the Supreme Court that two structures inside the Mehrauli Archaeological Park in Delhi bear religious significance as devotees visit daily to the 13th century **Ashiq Allah Dargah** and **Chillagah of Baba Farid**, the revered 13th century Sufi saint.*

ABOUT MEHRAULI ARCHAEOLOGICAL PARK

- It is a large area spanning over 200 acres in South Delhi and belongs to pre-Sultanate to Colonial period architecture.
- It covers over **400 monuments** including destroyed temples (Jain and Hindu), masjid, Dargahs, Qutub Complex, forts and tombs of many rulers including Balban.
- Archaeological structures in this park showcase **Indo-Islamic architecture** mostly belonging to the Delhi Sultanate era.

IMPORTANT STRUCTURES

1. Rajon ki Baoli:

- It is a stepwell and also includes a mosque and tomb. It was built during the period of **Daulat Khan Lodhi** (1506 CE).

- The name Rajon Ki Baoli is derived from the 'Rajbirs' or 'Mistris' - the term used for masons. It got its name in the early 20th century because of the masons that moved in permanently into the area.

2. Jamali Kamali Mosque and Tomb:

- It is the tomb of a Sufi saint **Shaikh Jamali Kamboh** and possibly his disciple **Kamali**. They belonged to the period of transition between Lodhis and Mughals.

3. Tomb of Ghiyas ud din Balban:

- It was built in 1287 in rubble masonry style. According to many historians it had India's first true **Islamic** Dome (Alai Darwaza of 1311 being the earliest surviving dome).

4. Jahaz Mahal:

- It was so named, since its reflection (illusion) in the surrounding reservoir looked like a **ship floating on a lake**.
- It is inferred to have been built during the **Lodi dynasty period** (1452–1526) as a pleasure resort, Sarai or an inn.

5. Zafar Mahal:

- It is considered as the last monumental structure built as a summer palace during the fading years of the Mughal era. It was built near the Dargah of sufi saint **Hazrat Khwaja Quttubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki.**
- Nomenclature: Named after the last Mughal ruler **Bahadur Shah Zafar** (who built the doorway or Hathi Gate in the palace and completed the structure in 1847).
- **Patronage:** began during Mughal ruler Akbar Shah II (18th century).

6. Moti Masjid:

- The royal mosque is situated adjacent to the wall of **Dargah of Hazarat Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kak**i.

This is a very small mosque with a double entrance. One door opens inside the premises of Dargah, and another opens in the Zafar Mahal. This was built by **Bahadur Shah I.**

27. WINTER CHAR DHAM CIRCUIT

*In December 2024, the state government of Uttarakhand inaugurated the **winter Char Dham circuit**, aimed at drawing tourists to the state in the **off-season winter months.***

CHAR DHAM IN UTTARAKHAND

- Char Dham are **four** revered Hindu shrines or dhams located in the **Garhwal Himalayas** in **Uttarakhand.**
  - **Gangotri:** shrine of Goddess **Ganga** (Uttarkashi)
  - **Yamunotri:** shrine of Goddess **Yamuna** (Uttarkashi)
  - **Kedarnath:** shrine of **Lord Shiva** (Rudraprayag)
  - **Badrinath:** shrine of **Lord Vishnu** (Chamoli)
- Each year, from May to November, lakhs of pilgrims visit these shrines, accounting for roughly 8.4% of Uttarakhand's annual domestic tourist footfall.

WINTER CHAR DHAM CIRCUIT

- During the winter months, **heavy snowfall leaves Char Dham shrines inaccessible,** and their gates are shut.
- The **presiding deities** of these temples are brought to **shrines at lower altitudes:**
  - **Mukhba** in Uttarkashi is the winter seat of Gangotri Dham
  - **Kharsali** in Uttarkashi is the winter seat of Yamunotri Dham
  - **Omkareshwar Temple** in Ukhimath, Rudraprayag is the winter seat for Kedarnath.
  - **Pandukeshwar** in Chamoli is the winter seat for Badrinath.
- The **winter Char Dham circuit** is **aimed at drawing pilgrims to these shrines,** and thus attract tourist footfall to Uttarakhand during off-season months.

28. MODHWETH FESTIVAL

*Members of the **Toda tribe** in the Nilgiris district gather around a 'Moonpo' (head) temple in the Muthanad mund (village) in Udhagamandalam (Ooty).*

ABOUT MODHWETH FESTIVAL

- **Modhweth Festival is** the **most important festival** of the **Toda tribe.**
- The **yearly festival** is celebrated at the **Moonpo temple** in **Muthanadu Mund** (village) in the Nilgiri district, during the last Sunday of December or on the first Sunday of January.
  - **Moonpo temple is** an ancient temple known for its **vertical spire** made of thatched roof with a flat stone on top.
  - The temple is unique in that it is one of the last of the Toda temples with a similar design left in the Nilgiris.
  - Toda men from 14 different clans living in different villages in the upper slopes of the Nilgiris come to the village to celebrate the festival. The temple draws not just Todas but also other tourists.
- Todas offer prayers to the deity, ***Thenkish* Amman**, and **perform a dance outside the temple** to give good health, rains and harvests.
- The celebrations culminate with **Toda youth lifting a greased boulder**, weighing around 80 kg, to showcase their strength, balance and masculinity.
- As is the custom with most Toda rituals, **women are excluded** from taking part in the celebrations.

29. GANGASAGAR MELA

West Bengal announced new initiatives to attract pilgrims to Gangasagar Mela.

MAJOR HIGHLIGHTS

- The slew of initiatives announced by the state government include:
  - **participation certificate** for pilgrims participating in the annual pilgrimage.
  - **e-Anushandhan** (pilgrims can access facilities at the mela ground)
  - **e-Parichay** (QR code-enabled identity band) to prevent missing people in the mela crowd.
- The state government has been demanding a **national mela status** for the Gangasagar Mela.

ABOUT GANGASAGAR MELA

- An **annual religious festival** held on **Sagar Island** in the state of West Bengal.
- Held at the **confluence** of **Ganga** with **Bay of Bengal** in West Bengal.
  - Travelling a distance of approximately **2,525 km** from Gangotri (origin), Ganga ends her journey in **Sagar Island**, where it merges with Bay of Bengal.
- The festival starts a few days before **Makar Sankranti** and concludes shortly after.
- **Rituals**:
  - **Holy dip** in the Ganga, **offering Arghya** (water) to Sun God and performing **Deepdan** (lighting lamps) and seeking liberation.
  - Considered the **second-largest religious** gathering in India, following Kumbh Mela.

HISTORICAL MENTION OF THE FAIR

- Gangasagar is mentioned in **Mahabharata's** Vana Parva, which provides proof of the existence of the pilgrimage site in 1500–2000 BC.
  - According to Mahabharata- **Kapilmuni**, the progenitor of **Samkhya philosophy,** had an ashram at Gangasagara.
- It is also mentioned in **Raghuvaṃśa**, a Sanskrit epic poem written by poet **Kalidasa** in **fifth century AD.**

- **King Devapala** of Pala dynasty mentions in an inscription that he performed rituals at the confluence of Gangasagar.

30. LEZIM FOLK DANCE

*A scene from upcoming Bollywood film Chhava, based on the life of Maratha ruler **Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj** has led to controversy in Maharashtra. In the scene, the actor who portrays the king is seen performing **Lezim** (also spelt lazium) folk dance.*

LEZIM FOLK DANCE

- **State**: Maharashtra
- **Musical instrument**: **Lezim,** a unique wooden stick, with jingling cymbals attached to it that the dancers carry while performing the dance. Dholki, a drum instrument, is used as the main percussion music in the performance.
- **Performance:**
  - During the rule of **Chhatrapati Shivaji,** Lezim was a sport **played by men** to build their muscles.
  - Some of the community preserved this sport. It is mainly performed during Ganesha Chaturthi.
  - Presently, it has become part of physical education drills in schools/colleges in the state.
- **Costume:** Dancers wear a traditional costume which consists of a white kurta, pajama and a colorful belt with a colourful turban.

CHHATRAPATI SAMBHAJI MAHARAJ

- He was the **eldest son** of **Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj**. He was the second Chhatrapati of the Maratha Empire, ruling from 1681 to 1689.
- He came to power following a bloody succession battle with his half-brother Rajaram in 1681.
- Mughal emperor Aurangzeb (1618-1707) was his contemporary.
- His rule was largely shaped by the **wars between the Marathas and the Mughal Empire**, as well as other neighbouring powers such as Abyssinians of Janjira, Wadiyars of Mysore and Portuguese Empire in Goa.
- Sambhaji and 25 of his advisors were captured by Mughal forces of Muqarrab Khan in a skirmish at Sangameshwar (Ratnagiri District) in 1689.

Chhatrapati Sambhaji and his minister Kavi Kalash were brought to **Tulapur** (Pune district), where they were tortured and **executed under the orders of Aurangzeb.**

5 CHAPTER PRACTICE QUESTIONS

1. ANCIENT INDIA

Q1. Consider the following statements with reference the Harappan sites in India:

1. Padta bet, a recently discovered burial site, is situated in Maharashtra.
2. At Dholavira in Gujarat, a water harvesting system have been discovered.
3. The evidence of 'Ploughed fields' has been found from Kalibangan in Rajasthan.

How many of the statements given above is/are incorrect?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q2. With reference to the rock art sites in India, consider the following pairs:

S. NO.	Rock art site		Associated State
1.	Maski	**:**	Uttarakhand
2.	Lakhudiyar	**:**	Uttar Pradesh
3.	Boloor Panne Koteda	**:**	Karnataka
4.	Piklihal	**:**	Tamil Nadu

How many of the pairs given above is/are ***incorrectly*** matched?

(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs
(c) Only three pairs (d) All four pairs

Q3. With reference to the history of India, consider the following statements:

1. Painted Grey Ware pottery have been found at the site of Purana Qila in Delhi.
2. The ancient city of Indraprastha is mentioned in Buddhist text as capital of Kuru kingdom.
3. The Kuru Kingdom emerged as the most powerful state in the late Vedic Period (900-500 BCE).

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q4. Consider the following statements with reference to the Nalanda Mahavira:

1. Kumaragupta I was the founder patron of the Mahavihara.
2. The philosophical teachings at the Mahavihara only focused on the Mahayana traditions.
3. Asanga and Nagarjuna were the famous scholars associated with the Mahavihara.
4. During the period of Palas, the Mahavihara began to decline.

Which of the statements given above is/are incorrect?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 4 only
(d) 1 and 4 only

Q5. Consider the following statements with reference to the practice of erecting 'Nadu Kal'?

1. It has been mentioned in the Sangam work 'Ahananuru'.
2. The oldest 'Nadu Kal' memorials are found in Tamil Nadu.
3. The practice of erecting 'Nadu Kal' evolved to honour the Sangam poets.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Q6. Consider the following statement, with reference to the cave architecture in India:

1. The Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves were carved out as residential blocks for Buddhist monks during the reign of Kharavela.

2. The 'Hathigumpha' inscription associated with King Kharavela is written in Brahmi script.
3. A Varaha avatar of Vishnu as he rescues goddess earth from the deep and chaotic waters is sculpted on rock cut caves of Udayagiri, Odisha.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 3 only

Q7. With reference to 'Mudras in Buddhism', consider the following statements:

1. 'Vitarka Mudra' signifies the discussion and transmission of the teachings of the Buddha.
2. The 'Abhaya Mudra' symbolizes 'warding off evil' and 'eliminating negative thoughts'.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q8. Consider the following pairs with reference to the Indus Valley Civilisation:

S.NO.	Important site		Associated River
1.	Surkotada	:	Indus River
2.	Kalibangan	:	Ghaggar River
3.	Lothal	:	Luni River

How many of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q9. Consider the following statements with reference to the Great Stupa of Sanchi, Madhya Pradesh:

1. The stupa was first built during the period of Shunga rule in the Malwa region.
2. The Satavahanas are credited with constructing the 'Toranas' around the original stupa.
3. 'Shalabhanjika sculpture' is used as a decorative element in the Eastern gateway of the stupa.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q10. Consider the following statements with reference to the Megalithic Culture:

1. Megalithic sites are predominantly concentrated in the Deccan region, particularly south of the Godavari River.
2. Rock-cut caves and Menhirs are unique classifications of Megalithic structures.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q11. Consider the following statements with reference to the Harappan script:

1. Harappan script has long inscriptions.
2. Harappan script is largely pictographic.
3. Harappan script is written from left to right.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

2. MEDIEVAL INDIA

Q1. Consider the following statements with reference to the cultural and religious history of India:

1. Ravidas was the contemporary of Delhi Sultanate ruler Sikander Lodi.
2. Ravidas adhered to the 'Saguna form' of Bhakti.
3. In his preachings, Ravidas gave the concept of 'Beghumpura'.

How many of the statements given above is/are incorrect?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q2. With reference to the history of medieval India, consider the following statements:

1. Ghiyasuddin Balban's tomb in Mehrauli, is the first site where true arch and dome was introduced.
2. During Sikander Lodi's reign, a stepwell known as 'Rajon ki Baoli' in Mehrauli was constructed.

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3. 'Zafar Mahal' built in red sandstone in Mehrauli was commissioned by Mughal emperor Shahjahan.

How many of the statements given above is/are incorrect?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q3. In the context of Medieval Indian history, 'Raja Punja Bhil' was well known for:

(a) In the Battle of Khanwa, he supported Rana Sangha with his Bhil army.
(b) He established the Garha-Mandla kingdom in the central region of India.
(c) He fought alongside Maharana Pratap in the Battle of Haldighati against the Mughal forces.
(d) He provided his service to Maharana Raj Singh during Aurangzeb's invasion of Mewar.

Q4. Consider the following statements:

1. 'Dakhni language' developed under the patronage of Bahmani Sultans.
2. Ibrahim Adil Shah II wrote 'Kitab-e-Navras' in Dakhni.
3. The Sultanates of Deccan region used 'Dakhni' as a court language.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q5. Consider the following statements:

1. The earliest Satnami sect was founded by Guru Ghasidas.
2. Under Guru Jagjivandas the ideals of 'Saguna form of Bhakti' were included in the Satnami sect.
3. The Satnamis revolted during the reign of Mughal emperor Jahangir.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q6. Consider the following statements with reference to the Kalinga style of Temple architecture:

1. The ground plan of main temple usually circular.
2. The 'Shikhara' is Kalinga style is called 'Deul'.
3. The 'Rekha Deul' is the Kalinga temples is always associated with Durga temples.
4. Temples have a boundary wall which is a common feature in Nagara style of temple architecture.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) Only three
(d) All four

Q7. Consider the following statement with reference to Chennakesava Temple at Somanathapur in Karnataka:

1. The temple was built during the rule of Chalukyas in the Deccan region.
2. The temple is associated with the Shaivite tradition of the Bhakti movement.
3. Nagara style 'Shikhara' is found at the Chennakesava temple.

Which of the statements given above is/are not correct?

(a) 1 and 3 only (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Q8. With reference to the history of India, consider the following statements:

1. 'Moidams' are the mound-burial system practiced during the period of Ahom dynasty.
2. 'Woods and Stones' were the primary materials used for the construction of Moidams.
3. The 'moidams of Charaideo' in Assam have recently been added to UNESCO's World Heritage site list.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Q9. 'Wagh Nakh', in the context of history of India, is best related to:

(a) A royal sceptre used by Chola rulers which represented the king's role as a divine agent.
(b) A scripture related to the history of origin of Sikh state in India.

(c) Weapon used by Shivaji to kill Afzal khan in the battle of Pratapgarh.

(d) Throne of the Sikh ruler, Maharaja Ranjit Singh.

Q10. Consider the following statements with reference to the historic city of Hampi:

1. It is located on the banks of River Krishna.
2. The Virupaksha temple at the site of Hampi was built during the reign of Deva Raya II.
3. The Ranga Mandapa, known for musical pillars, is found at the Virupaksha temple.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q11. Who is credited with introducing papier-mâché art to Kashmir in the 14th century?

(a) King Zain-ul-Abidin
(b) Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani
(c) Shah Hamdan
(d) Central Asian craftsmen

Q12. Who among the following Sikh Gurus is credited with the composition of the Dasam Granth?

(a) Guru Nanak Dev
(b) Guru Gobind Singh
(c) Guru Tegh Bahadur
(d) Guru Angad Dev

3. MODERN INDIA

Q1. With reference to the socio-religious reform movement in the 19th century India, consider the following statements:

1. Mahima Dharma movement emerged as a reaction against the ban on the entry of lower castes in the Jagannath temple.
2. Mahima Dharma established by Mahima Gosain emphasises on the 'Advaitabada' of Indian philosophy.
3. The concept of 'Satsanga Gosthi' in Mahima Dharma was introduced by Santha Kabi Bhima Bhoi.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q2. Consider the following statements with reference to the 'Bhil tribe' in India:

1. The Bhils were regarded as a criminal tribe by the British government.
2. Bhima Naik led the Bhils of Rajasthan to fight for a Bhil Raj in 1913.
3. The Bhil rebellion in Maharashtra against the British was led by Govind Guru.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q3. Consider the following statements with reference to the Santhal rebellion (1855-56):

1. The rebellion started as a protest against the forced imposition of Ryotwari System.
2. The zamindars extended support to the tribes to protest against the exploitative colonial system.
3. The Santhal community referred the state agents like moneylenders and merchants as 'Dikus'.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q4. Consider the following statements with reference to Rani Ahilya Bai:

1. She belonged to the Holkar dynasty, which was an autonomous state within the Maratha confederacy.
2. She transferred the capital of Holkar dynasty from Maheshwar to Indore.
3. The present Vishnupad Temple (Bihar) was built by Ahilya Bai.

How many of the statements given above is/are ***incorrect***?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q5. Consider the following statements:

1. The ending of 'Khuntkatti system ' by the colonial government was one of the main reasons for the emergence of Munda rebellion.
2. The 'Khuntkatti system' was the practice of animal sacrifice followed by the Munda tribes.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q6. Consider the following statements with reference to Post Independent developments in India:

1. The National Emergency in 1975 was proclaimed by the then President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed.
2. The Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA) was introduced by the Union Government during the period of emergency.
3. During the period of emergency, the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act was enacted.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Q7. With reference colonial period in India, consider the following statements:

1. Fort St. George was the first British fortress in India.
2. The 'Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle' granted control of Fort St. George to the French East India Company in India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q8. Consider the following statements with reference to the history of India:

1. In 1943, Subhas Chandra Bose proclaimed the Andaman and Nicobar Islands as the first territory of India to be liberated from British rule.
2. In 1943, Subhas Chandra Bose hoisted the Indian National Flag for the first time upon his return to Calcutta.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q9. With reference to the India National Movement, consider the following statements:

1. Bhagat Singh was against the launch of Non-cooperation movement in 1921.
2. Bhagat Singh in association with Sachindranath Sanyal founded the Hindustan Republican Association.
3. Bhagat Singh founded 'Kirti' as the Publication of the Naujawan Bharat Sabha.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q10. With reference to the history of India, "Ulgulan" or the Great Tumult is the description of which of the following events?

(a) The Revolt of 1857
(b) The Mappila Rebellion of 1921
(c) The Indigo Revolt of 1859 - 60
(d) Birsa Munda's Revolt of 1899 – 1900

Q11. Consider the following statements with reference to Subramania Bharti:

1. He translated Patanjali's Yoga Sutra and Bhagavad Gita to Tamil.
2. He was the President of the Lucknow Session of Indian National Congress in 1916.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q12. Who among the following is related to works, *Atmopadesa Satakam, Deiva Dasakkam, Arivu* and *Jati Nirnayam?*

(a) Shankaracharya
(b) Ramanujacharya
(c) Narayana Guru
(d) Manickavasagar

4. ART AND CULTURE

Q1. Consider the following statements:

1. 'Rupa Tarakasi' from Bengal has been Geographical Indication (GI) tag.
2. A Geographical Registration is given to an area and not a trader.
3. The raw material for a GI tag product from an area have to come from that particular region.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q2. With reference to the heritage and culture of India, consider the following statements:

1. Pinjara and Mansuri communities native to Kutch region are associated with the Namda craft.
2. Namda Craft originated in India during the Delhi Sultanate period.
3. Namda Craft employs the use of 'Khatamband' and 'Taldar' in the designing process.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q3. Consider the following statements:

1. The Lalit Kala Akademi functions as an autonomous body under the Ministry of Culture.
2. The Chairman of the Lalit Kala Akademi is appointed for a term of five years.
3. The Lalit Kala Akademi awards artists for their contributions in performing and visual art forms.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q4. Consider the following pairs:

S. No.	Festivals		Associated State
1.	Puthandu	:	Maharashtra
2.	Shigmo	:	Manipur
3.	Ugadi	:	Andhra Pradesh
4.	Sajibu Cheiraoba	:	West Bengal

How many of the pairs given above is/are incorrectly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) Only three (d) All four

Q5. Consider the following statements:

1. 'Kashan style' employed in carpet making originated in Jammu and Kashmir.
2. Kirman and Mashed are well-known type of carpets produced in the state of Gujarat.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q6. Consider the following statements with reference to the 'Classical Dance' in India:

1. 'Atavakul' is the collection of forty basic dance movements in this dance form.
2. 'Tandava' aspect of dance is the dominant in the performance.
3. It has found mentioned in 'Ghoshayatra' written by Kunjan Nambiar.
4. The dance form is mainly associated with the states of Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka.

How many of the above given statements relate to the Indian Classical dance form 'Mohiniattam'?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) Only three (d) All four

Q7. Consider the following statements with reference to the heritage and culture of India:

1. Garudam Thookkam is a ritual dance form, performed in the Vishnu temples of Odisha.
2. Chenda and Kombu Pattu are the musical instruments used in the performance of Garudam Thukkam.
3. The performers in Garudam Thookkam employ 'Thalavattam' rhythmic patterns.

How many of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q8. Kumartuli, a renowned place, recently was in news in relation to:

(a) A Vajrayana Buddhist site in Odisha.
(b) A recently discovered Harappan site in Bihar
(c) A place famous for its sculptures in West Bengal
(d) A site in Assam related to Vaishanavism.

Q9. Consider the following statements:

1. 'Yoga for Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' is the theme for International Day of Yoga, 2024.
2. UNESCO declared 21st June as the 'International Day of Yoga' in 2014.
3. The 'Ashtanga philosophy' is mentioned in the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali.

Which of the statements given above is/are not correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Q10. Regarding 'Thangka art form', consider the following statements:

1. It is usually associated with the depiction of Buddhist deities.
2. The art form originated in North Eastern region of India.
3. 'Bhavachakra' is an important subject of the Thangka art form.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Q11. Consider the following pairs of floor paintings and the state they belong to:

1. Aipan: Karnataka
2. Alpana: West Bengal
3. Kalamzhuthu: Kerala

Which of the pairs is/are correctly matched?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) Only three
(d) None of the Above

Q12. Consider the following statements with reference heritage and culture of India:

1. The Gotipua dance form from Odisha is traditionally performed by young girls known as 'Mahari dancers.'
2. The dance form is characterized 'Tribhangi' and 'Chouka' posture.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q13. Consider the following statements with reference to the 'Officially recognised Classical languages in India':

1. Tamil was the first language to be given classical status in India.
2. A classical language must have a recorded history of more than 2,000 years.
3. The Eighth Schedule of the Constitution lists all classical languages.

How many of the statements given above is/are not correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Q14. Consider the following statements with reference to the 'Pulikali art form':

1. It is an all women dance-drama performance associated with Onam celebrations.
2. The performance is accompanied by the musical instruments 'Thakil' and 'Chenda'.
3. The art form originated under the patronage of Marthanda Varma, the ruler of the Travancore kingdom.

Which of the statements given above are not correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Q15. With reference to the Indian folk theatre, consider the following pairs:

S. No.	Folk Theatre		Associated State
1.	Theyyam	:	Kerala
2.	Koodiyattom	:	Tamil Nadu

3.	Burra Katha	:	Karnataka
4.	Bayalata	:	Andhra Pradesh

How many of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All three (d) None

Q16. Consider the following statements with reference to Kandakarnan Thira:

1. Kandakarnan Thira is a Theyyam art form performed in the Malabar region of Kerala.
2. The dance is performed exclusively by women from the Nair community.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q17. 'Jala Chitra Nrityam', where the dancer draws pictures on the floor with his or her toes while dancing, is related to which classical dance form?

(a) Kathak (b) Bharatnatyam
(c) Kuchipudi (d) Kathakali

Q18. Consider the following statements with reference to the Dadasaheb Phalke Award:

1. The award was instituted in 1969 to honour Dhundiraj Govind Phalke.
2. It is presented by the Ministry of Culture during the International Film Festival of India.
3. Devika Rani was the first recipient of this award.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 2 and 3 only

Q19. Which of the following is a key feature of the Nangyarkoothu dance drama?

(a) Predominantly focused on nritta (pure dance elements)
(b) Accompanied by the percussion instrument Mizhavu and cymbals Ilathalam
(c) Based on the legends of Lord Shiva
(d) Performed exclusively in secular theaters.

Q20. What is the significance of the Thanka Anki procession in Sabarimala?

(a) It marks the beginning of the Mandala Puja festival.
(b) It involves the transportation of sacred ornaments to Sabarimala.
(c) It is conducted to celebrate the birth anniversary of Lord Ayyappa.
(d) It is a cultural festival celebrated in Aranmula.

Q21. With reference to Thrissur Pooram, consider the following statements:

1. It is an annual event to celebrate the birth anniversary of Lord Ganesha in Kerala.
2. Elephants are an important part of public display.
3. This festival does not use any musical instrument.

Which of the statements given above is/are incorrect?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Q22. Which of the following texts provides detailed information on scales, melodic forms, tala, and musical instruments?

(a) Sangeeta Ratnakara
(b) Matanga's Brihaddesi
(c) Natya Shastra
(d) Gita Govinda

Q23. With respect to *'Lezim'*; consider the following statements:

1. It is a folk dance performed mainly in the state of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.
2. It is named after the tribal deity of the local Chenchu tribes.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Q24. Which of the following statements about Jallikattu is *incorrect*?

(a) Jallikattu is traditionally held in Tamil Nadu during the Pongal festival in January.
(b) The term 'sallikattu' is derived from the Tamil words for 'coins' and 'package,' referring to the prize tied to the bull's horns.
(c) The sport originated during the Gupta period and has historical evidence dating back 2,000 years.
(d) The Constitution Bench of supreme upheld the validity of Tamil Nadu laws protecting Jallikattu.

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Q25. Which of the following statements about the Toda tribal people and their culture is NOT correct?

(a) The Toda lands are part of The Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, which is designated as a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

(b) Toda religious practices are centered around a pantheon of gods, including the goddess Tökisy and the god of the underworld, Ön.

(c) The Toda people are vegetarians but consume eggs and fish as part of their diet.

(d) The Toda language belongs to the Dravidian language family.

5. ANSWERS

ANCIENT INDIA									
1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**
a	c	b	c	a	b	a	a	b	c
11									
a									

MEDIEVAL INDIA									
1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**
a	a	c	a	d	b	b	a	c	a
11	**12**								
b	b								

MODERN INDIA									
1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**
b	a	a	a	a	c	a	a	d	d
11	**12**								
a	c								

ART AND CULTURE									
1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**
a	b	a	c	d	b	b	c	a	c
11	**12**	**13**	**14**	**15**	**16**	**17**	**18**	**19**	**20**
b	b	b	c	a	a	c	c	b	b
21	**22**	**23**	**24**	**25**					
c	c	d	c	c					